

Noida Sector 75: Fire breaks out in 12th-floor flat, family rescued

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

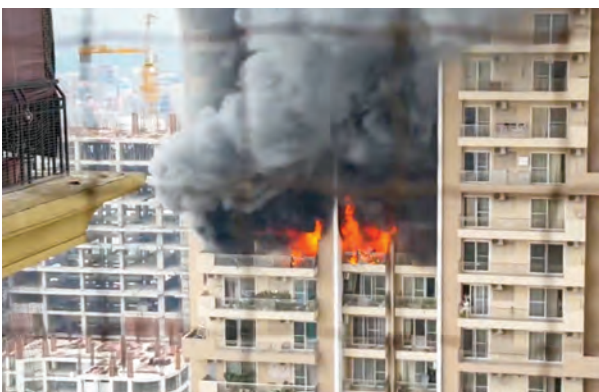
A fire broke out in a 12th-floor flat of a high-rise residential society in Sector 75 here on Friday morning, following which a family trapped inside was rescued, and the building was evacuated.

Chief Fire Officer (CFO), Gautam Buddh Nagar, Pradeep Kumar, said the fire was caused by a short circuit in an air conditioner.

Officials said the incident occurred around 7 am at Ivy County society in Sector 75, where flames erupted from a flat on the 12th floor of the 28-storey building.

Taking cognisance of the incident, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath directed officials to expedite relief and rescue operations and ensure proper medical assistance, if required, according to an official statement issued in Lucknow.

The chief minister also directed the administration to remain alert at all levels and ensure continuous mon-



Smoke billows from a fire breaking out from a flat on the 12th floor of the 28-storey building at the Ivy County society at Sector 75 area in Noida

itoring of the relief efforts.

Kumar said, "After receiving the information about the fire, the local police and fire service unit immediately reached the spot and started firefighting operations." He said along with fire tenders, a hydraulic platform was deployed at the site.

"Due to the presence of fire-fighting equipment within the building, our equipment and vehicles were not engaged in the firefighting

operation. The fire was possibly caused by the air conditioner's malfunction, or it potentially originated in the flat's 'puja' room. Our personnel entered flats 1203 and 1204 and doused the fire. Six fire tenders were used," Kumar said.

He said the fire service team rescued the husband, wife, and their children who were trapped inside the flat.

"The blaze was brought under control with the assis-

tance of six fire tenders. There was no loss of life," the CFO said. Police said residents evacuated the building via the staircases, and occupants of neighbouring flats were also moved to a safe location as a precaution.

Meanwhile, videos of the Ivy County fire surfaced on social media.

Several users raised concerns that the fire tender's water stream, directed towards the building from the ground level, appeared to reach only the sixth floor, while the fire had broken out on the 12th floor.

Many users questioned whether the Noida fire department, which serves several high-rise residential buildings with towers ranging up to 20 or 30 floors, was adequately prepared to handle such situations.

Responding to the concerns, CFO Kumar said the impression that the fire tender's water jet could reach only the sixth floor resulted from a different operation being carried out at the spot.

Worker dies, two injured as boundary wall collapses during PWD sewage work near Lodhi Colony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A boundary wall and an adjoining store room at the Lodi Crematorium near Lodhi Colony collapsed in the early hours of Friday during PWD sewage pipeline construction work, killing one worker and injuring two others. All three of them were buried under the debris before being rescued and taken to AIIMS Trauma Centre.

The incident occurred at around 1:08 am in the Hazrat Nizamuddin police station area. The Public Works Department was carrying out rainwater drainage and sewer line laying work at the site using JCB and Hydra machines. During the excavation and pipeline laying process, the boundary wall and the adjacent store room suddenly gave way, trapping three workers under the rubble.

On receiving information, a team led by Additional DCP-2 Jasbir Singh, along with fire service and ambulance teams, reached the



One person died and two were injured after the boundary wall of the Lodi crematorium ground collapsed during drain construction work in New Delhi

spot and launched a joint rescue operation. All three workers were pulled out from the debris and rushed to the AIIMS Trauma Centre.

Of the three, Devendra, 50, was declared dead by doctors on arrival at the hospital. Rajesh, 48, sustained injuries to his face and lips and is undergoing treatment. Umar, 20, is reported to be out of danger.

Police have registered a case and begun an investigation into the circumstances

of the collapse. Legal proceedings are being initiated to fix responsibility for the incident.

The collapse raises questions about the safety protocols being followed during the overnight construction work. The use of heavy excavation machinery, including JCBs and Hydra cranes, during sewer line laying in close proximity to existing structures creates significant stress on surrounding walls and foundations.

Whether the boundary wall had been assessed for structural integrity before excavation began in its vicinity is among the questions that investigators are expected to address.

The Lodi Crematorium is located in a well-established part of South Delhi, in the jurisdiction of the Hazrat Nizamuddin police station. The PWD work being carried out at the site was part of an ongoing civic infrastructure activity involving the laying of sewer and rainwater drainage pipelines.

Workers employed on infrastructure projects, particularly those working night shifts when supervision may be lighter and visibility is lower, face heightened risk from structural collapses during excavation work.

The combination of heavy machinery, underground digging, and existing structures nearby creates conditions where sudden collapses can occur with little warning, leaving workers with almost no time to move clear.

DUUG admissions delayed; registrations only post-CUET results

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University (DU) might once again face a delayed undergraduate admission cycle as it waits for the declaration of the Common University Entrance Test (CUET-UG) results before opening registrations.

This has renewed concerns among teachers over disruptions to the academic calendar that have persisted since the entrance examination was introduced. The development comes despite university officials earlier indicating that the registration for admission would begin by the third week of May.

According to Dean of Admissions Hanee Gandhi, the undergraduate admission process is expected to



begin after the CUET-UG results are announced.

"The UG admission process will tentatively start after the CUET-UG results are declared. While we will be taking precautions to avoid any unnecessary delay in the start of the academic session, at least four lists are expected to be released leading up to the admission," Gandhi said.

The delay follows fresh disruptions in the conduct of

CUET-UG this year. On May 30, the examination was affected by a technical glitch, forcing the National Testing Agency (NTA) to revise schedules and organise a one-time re-examination for more than 3,700 students who had left examination centres before the test could resume.

The revised examination dates have been fixed for June 6 and 7, the NTA said in a post on X.

DU EXTENDS PG ADMISSION REGISTRATION DEADLINE TILL JUNE 9

New Delhi: Delhi University on Friday extended the registration deadline for admissions to its postgraduate programmes for the 2026-27 academic session under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS-PG), according to a public notice. The university said candidates can now complete their registration process till 4:59 pm on June 9, as compared to the earlier deadline of June 7. A correction window for already registered candidates will remain open from 10 am on June 10 to 4:59 pm on June 11. The admission branch also announced the schedule for seat allocation

and admissions under the first and second rounds of the CSAS-PG process.

According to the notification, the first round of seat allocations will be declared on June 15. Candidates allotted seats will be required to accept them between June 15 and June 17. Departments, centres and colleges will verify and approve applications from June 15 to June 18.

The last date for online payment of fees by candidates allotted seats in the first round is June 19, according to the notification. The second round of allocations will be announced on June 22.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 21-year-old woman was found dead inside her matrimonial home in east Delhi's Gazipur area, police said on Friday. The deceased was found lying on a sofa on the fourth floor of a house in Gopal Gali of Gazipur village, they said.

According to police, a PCR call was received at around 3 pm on Thursday informing them about a woman lying dead inside a house. Following the information, a police team rushed to the spot and initiated an investigation.

Police retrieved the body and said the exact cause of death would be determined after the results of the post-mortem are received.



Preliminary inquiry revealed that the deceased had married Tarun (26) in October 2025. Police also found that Sumit (23), the younger brother of Tarun and the deceased's brother-in-law, was present in the house at the time of the incident.

As the death occurred within a few months of marriage, an executive magistrate also visited the spot and initiated proceedings

as per legal provisions, police said.

Police said they are examining all aspects of the case and recording statements of family members and others connected with the incident. No arrests have been made so far, and further legal proceedings are underway. The investigation is underway, police said, adding that further action would be taken based on the findings.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This Is To Inform We Crown Traders Limited, Having Registered Office At 2888, 2nd Floor, Hauz Quazi, Lal-Qua Bazaar, Sikri Walan, Hauz Qazi, North Delhi, Delhi-110006. We Owner Of 800 Shares Of The Kama Holding Limited. Company Share's Which We Have Lost Original Share Certificate While Coming Back To Home In Auto-Rickshaw On Date: 15-10-2016. The Total Of 800 Missing Share Certificate Were Mentioned In The Below Table. Those Documents Were Not Found Even After Searching In Many Place. If Any One Finds The Original Documents In The List Below, Please Contact Crown Traders Limited.

Folio No.	Certificate	Distinctive No.	No. of shares
SPP0002799	2876	106607-106706	100
SPP0002799	2877	106707-106766	60
SPP0002799	200002	35907997-35908636	640
TOTAL			800

ESAF

ESAF SMALL FINANCE BANK

Regd. Office: ESAF Bhavan, Mannuthy, Thrissur - 680 651, Kerala

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts and remaining overdue/urme deemed despite repeated notices will be auctioned for recovery of the Bank's dues, in accordance with applicable banking regulations and policies.

DETAILS OF AUCTION

Mode of Auction: Off-line (Physical Auction through Branches)

Date of Auction: 04-07-2026

Time: 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM

Auction Venues: The auction will be conducted at the following ESAF Small Finance Bank branches in HARYANA

Interested bidders are requested to visit the respective branches for participation. For detailed branch addresses and contact numbers, please visit the Bank's official website

BRANCH NAME - LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER

FARIDAABAD: 63260000061044

Important Instructions: Borrowers may redeem their pledged gold ornaments by clearing the total dues along with applicable charges at least two days prior to the auction date. Interested bidders must carry valid KYC documents. GST Registration Number is mandatory for firms/companies, wherever applicable. Bidders are required to deposit an Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Rs.2,500 before participating in the auction. The auction will be conducted on an "as is where is" and "as is what is" basis. The Bank reserves the right to cancel/postpone the auction or reject any bid without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBJA Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.

Place: Thrissur

Date: 06 June 2026

(Sd/-) Authorized Signatory

ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd.



Baba Farid University of Health Sciences

Sadia Road, Faridkot-151203 Ph. 01639-256232, 256236

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-tender are invited for following works upto 22-06-2026

(1) Construction of 1st floor building on garages near OPD in GGS Medical College & Hospital, Faridkot.

E-tender are invited for following works upto 30-06-2026

(1) Special Repair of Girls PG Hostel in GGS Medical Residential Campus, Faridkot. (2) Repair of General washroom (Ground Floor) in GGS Medical, Faridkot. (3) Repair of General Washroom (Single Block) Amrit Pharmacy at GGS MCH, Faridkot. (4) Rate contract of Special Repair of painting and other repair of various buildings at GGS MCH, Faridkot.

Terms and conditions can be downloaded from <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in>. The tenders will be accepted in E-Tender mode only. Bidder can also download tender notification and document from the University website i.e. www.bfuhs.ac.in

3108/12/2026-27/12051 Dated CHD :- 05/06/2026

Sd/- Registrar



AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wisth Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Off: Axis House, Block-B, Bortmayer Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Regd. Off: Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samarbhawan Temple, Law garden, Ellorabridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & 1 Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001.

POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) have failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower & Co-borrower: 1. Sanjay Sharma R/o House No. 269 Tipstia Karanwala Budhha Nagar Cr Noida U.P. - 201306 (borrower) 2. Mrs. Suchma W/o Sanjay Sharma R/o House No. 269 Tipstia Karanwala Budhha Nagar Cr Noida U.P. - 201306 (Co-borrower) Description Of Property : All That Piece And Parcel Of Plot No. 84, Admeasuring 356.5 Sq. Mtrs. Sector Ph-03 Block, "Chorasia Estate" Gaulam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh - 201310 And Bound As Under - East: As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed, North: As Per Title Deed, South: As Per Title Deed.

Date of Demand Notice	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
17-Jan-2026	04-Jun-2026	Rs. 18,550,464/- (Rupees One Crore Eighty Five Lakhs Forty Thousand Four Hundred Sixty Four Only)

The above-mentioned Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) are hereby given a 30 days Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days' from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Place: Noida, Date: 06.06.2026

Sd/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.



SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

Corporate Off: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051 Regd. Off: Commercial IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price / Earnest Money Deposit :-	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	Lan No. 009139211833923 1. Shadab Mirza S/O-Aslam Mirza 2. Tarannum Mirza, W/O -Shadab Mirza.	Flat Bearing No. F1-06 On First Floor Rear Side Rhs Referred To As The "Said Flat" Of Residential Plot Bearing No. B-133, B-124 & B-135 Area Measuring 100+100+100-300 Sq. Yds, Falling In Kharsa No. 311, Situated In Rail Vihar Sahkari Awas Samiti Ltd., Hadbast Village Sadullabad, Pargana & Tehsil Loni, Distt. Ghaziabad (UP) (Hereinafter Referred To As The "Said Property"). Boundaries (As Per Technical). East Entry & Flat No. F1-02 West Vacant Plot North : Vacant Plot South Staircase	Rs. 9,90,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026
	Lan No. 00543921152646 1. Anand Kashyap 2. Manju 3. Vikas Bholanath	Flat No Ufg-5 On Upper Ground Floor Back Portion Lhs Admeasuring 554 Sq Ft Without Roof Rights Built On Free Hold Plot No B-3 & B-4 Total Land Admeasuring 368 Sq. Yds Kharsa No 1207 Situated At Hayat Encave Village Loni Pargana & Tehsil Loni Ghaziabad UP-201103	Rs. 13,40,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026
3.	Lan No. 613939211685714 1. Pushpendar Singh 2. Rekha Rani	Residential Flat Bearing No Gt-3, On Ground Floor Rear Rhs Without Roof Rights Said Flat Built On Plot Bearing No A-153, Area Measuring 280 Sq.Yds., Out Of Kharsa No 346/1, Situated At Block B Nearby Rail Vihar Gate, Rail Vihar Shekhari Awas Samiti Ltd. Hadbast Village Sadullabad Pargana & Tehsil Loni Distt. Ghaziabad (U.P.) (Hereinafter Referred As The Said Property). Boundaries:- East:- Vacant Plot, West:- Plot No B-80, North:- Rasta South:- Plot No. B-38	Rs. 18,40,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026
4.	Lan No. 613939211679466 1. Kamal Chand Somkar 2. Rama Dal Chand	Residential Flat Bearing No. Si-2, On Second Floor, Front Middle Side, Covered Area Measuring 467 Sq. Ft. "Said Flat", Built On Property Bearing No. B-81, (Area Measuring 260 Sq. Yds), Out Of Kharsa No. 218, Situated At Rail Vihar Shekhari Awas Samiti Ltd. Village-Sadullabad, Pargana Loni, Distt. Ghaziabad (U.P.) (Hereinafter Referred As The Said Property). Boundaries:- East:- Vacant Plot, West:- Plot No B-80, North:- Rasta South:- Plot No. B-38	Rs. 16,70,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026
5.	Lan No. 820639211886272 1. Anuraadha Singh 2. Rahul Kumar	Residential Ground Floor Rhs Witout Roof Rights, Built On Plot No 71, Area Measuring 470 Sq.ft Out Of Kharsa No 223, Situated At Block B Nearby Rail Vihar Gate, Rail Vihar Shekhari Awas Samiti Ltd. Hadbast Village Sadullabad Pargana & Tehsil Loni Distt Ghaziabad	Rs. 16,10,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026
6.	Lan No. 6139392011765056 1. Jitender Jaint 2. Meenu Jaint	Flat (Without Roof Rights)Plot No B-42, Kharsa No 217 Area Measuring 316 Sq. Ft., i.e. 29.36 Sq.meter., In Rail Vihar Colony Tehsil Loni Distt Ghaziabad Up Bounded As Under:- East:- Plot No B-41 West:- Plot No B-43 North:- Plot No 77 South:- Rasta 30 Ft Wide	Rs. 9,90,000/-	15.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	14.07.2026



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Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also contact : Joydeep Sur, on his mobile no. +91 9830398605, email id: Joydeep.Sur@grihashakti.com and Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com

Place : Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh

Date : 05.06.2026

Sd/- Authorized Officer, SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that our clients, Surennder Kumar S/o Late Soonda Ram and Rekha Devi W/o Surennder Kumar R/o House No. M-465, Raghubir Nagar, Tagore Garden, New Delhi-110027 have disowned and declared their son Ashish Vinay and his wife Muskan Arora from all their movable & immovable properties due to their aggressive attitude & quarrelsome nature and disrespectful nature and have severed all relations with them. Any person dealing with them in any manner whatsoever shall be doing so at his/her own cost, risk, and responsibility. Our clients shall not be held responsible for any of their acts.

ROHIT YADAV (ADVOCATE)

Ch. No. 402, Civil Sub. Tahsil, Courts, Delhi-110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

WE, Anil Kumar, Sunita Gupta & Rama Gupta, presently residing at Flat No. A-1, I.T.D. Employees Co-operative, Group Housing Society, Ltd. Known As Marsh Apartment, Peera Garh Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087. The Original Share Certificate, have been Lost/Misplaced in respect of Flat No. A-1, I.T.D. Employees Co-operative, Group Housing Society, Ltd. Known As Marsh Apartment, Peera Garh Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087. An F.R. to this effect has been issued by the said Society. In the event of any person claiming the said Flat No. A-1, I.T.D. Employees Co-operative, Group Housing Society, Ltd. Known As Marsh Apartment, Peera Garh Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087, please contact with the undersigned at the address mentioned below within 15 days from today. Failing which, it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of encumbrances, liens, etc.

Lucern Legal LLP

B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida UP-201301 Contact No. 0120-4269379

NOTICE

This is to inform you all that KK HOSPITAL situated at Plot 2-Under Enclave, Peeragarhi, New Delhi - 110087, is destroying OPD, IPD and Ultrasound medical records upto 1st Jan 2023. For patients who desire to keep these medical records, please contact at Hospital from 06-06-2026 to 14-06-2026. Remarks: Medical records are considered private information. Please contact by your self.

Thank you. Hospital Manager

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Built-up Second Floor without roof and right upon the said floor is hereby called only (i.e. the said floor), covered area measuring 87.48 sq. mtrs., parking covered area measuring 21.87 sq. mtrs., built-on plot of land area measuring 108.83 sq. mtrs., i.e. 138.35 sq. yds., bearing Property No. 18214, Old No. 15314/4-D, Plot No. 20, out of Kharsa No. 391, Khewat No. 27, Khatoni No. 133, situated at the area of Village Udhampur, in the abadi of Gali No. 5, Ward No. 13, Sector No. 11, Ilage Shahdara, Delhi-110032, hereinafter referred to as the "said property".

NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our clients, Mr. Sanki Aggarwal and Mrs. Anand Aggarwal (hereinafter called the owners) are the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 16.07.2025 executed by Mrs. Ganeshra Realstate Developers Infraharc Pvt. Ltd. It has been also informed that initially Mr. Bhagwan Das was the owner of said property vide Sale Deed dated 05.04.1965 and after his unfortunate death Mrs. Krishna Verma had acquired the said Property vide Regd. Will dated 10.01.2007. Thereafter, Mrs. Krishna Verma gifted the said property in favour of Mrs. Anu Varshney and Mrs. Taruna Verma vide Gift Deed dated 01.04.2021. Thereafter, (1) Mrs. Anu Varshney (2) Mrs. Taruna Verma sold the said property to the seller and finally, seller has sold the said floor to our client as mentioned above. The said owners have also informed that the said floor is not mortgage anywhere and there is no dispute or any litigation pending upon the said floor.

Any person including Bank/s, Financial Institution/s, relatives having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the said floor is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of response having been received to the notice, the title of the owners in respect of the said floor shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our clients/owners, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate

For M/s Intelective Law Offices A-74, LGF, Defence Colony, New Delhi-110024

Govt announces sweeping measures against fire violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Friday announced sweeping measures against illegal constructions and fire safety violations following the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy, empowering district magistrates to order FIRs, suspend negligent officials, and oversee strict enforcement drives across the capital.

The Chief Minister instructed officials to stop illegal construction immediately wherever violations are detected and begin legal proceedings against builders, owners, and colonisers without delay. She also directed authorities to review older high-rise buildings and take sealing or closure action where serious violations are found.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta chaired a high-level meeting at the Delhi Secretariat attended by senior officials from Delhi Police, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the Delhi Development Authority, NDMC, Fire Services and district administrations. The government made it clear that negligence at any level would attract strict legal and financial consequences.

The Chief Minister directed that accountability should extend beyond junior officials and include senior officers as well. Adverse remarks will also be recorded in the annual performance reports of negligent officials, affecting future promotions and career progression.

Addressing reporters after the meeting, Urban Development and Home

Minister Ashish Sood said the government aimed to create a permanent and foolproof system to prevent incidents caused by unauthorised construction and fire safety violations. He said action would now be taken under provisions of the Disaster Management Act, 2005, against officials whose negligence or alleged collusion allows illegal construction, unsafe buildings, or violations of safety norms.

The law provides for imprisonment of up to two years along with financial penalties. Sood said provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act could also be invoked wherever necessary.

The government has decided that officials found responsible for negligence may face recovery of govern-



ment losses from their salaries, pensions, and personal properties under the Revenue Recovery Act, 1890. According to the new policy, builders, colonisers, and owners involved in illegal activities may also face free-

ing and attachment of bank accounts and movable or immovable assets.

One of the major decisions taken during the meeting was the expansion of the powers of district magistrates. The government said district

magistrates would now have authority to identify accountability of officials from different departments working within their districts, initiate disciplinary proceedings, order registration of FIRs and take immediate action

against officers failing to perform their duties.

Officials said the move was aimed at addressing long-standing coordination gaps among agencies such as MCD, DDA, Delhi Fire Service, and police authorities. Joint inspection committees headed by district magistrates will now conduct intensive checks of guest houses, hotels, banquet halls, restaurants, and commercial establishments across Delhi.

These committees will include senior officers from the Delhi Police, Fire Services, and civic bodies.

Any establishment found operating without valid permission or violating fire safety norms will face immediate sealing action. The government also ordered a review of all buildings exceeding

approved construction limits and directed strict monitoring of structures taller than 17.5 metres.

To strengthen monitoring, the government will introduce drone surveys, satellite mapping, and digital tracking systems to identify illegal construction activity every three months.

Officials said a dedicated drone monitoring cell would be established at the divisional commissioner level.

The government also plans to launch an online complaint portal allowing citizens to report unauthorised construction and file complaints against officials. Another major decision involves introducing a third-party insurance system for buildings, guest houses, and nursing homes.

MCD demolishes 82, seals 43 properties across Delhi since June 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi has demolished 82 properties and sealed 43 others across all municipal zones since June 1 on the directions of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

The Friday's enforcement drive in South Delhi resulted in the sealing of five bed-and-breakfast guest houses in Hauz Rani, including Flourish Inn, a property linked to Lavkesh Bajaj, the owner of Flourish Stay, where 21 people died in a fire on Wednesday.

The five guest houses sealed in Hauz Rani on Friday are Green Residency, Sky Inn, Flourish Inn, Venue Inn, and Mikasa Inn. MCD had earlier identified more than



12 B&B guest houses operating in violation of building bye-laws in Hauz Rani during a joint survey conducted after the fire. The sealing of Flourish Inn is significant because locals and investigators have identified it as one of the properties operated by Bajaj, who is currently in police custody.

In Friday's South Delhi drive, MCD also took sealing and demolition action against eight properties in

Saidulajab in Saket, and demolished and sealed one property in Khirki Extension. In Savitri Nagar, Sainik Farm, and Khanpur areas, demolition and sealing action were carried out against three properties. Three basements running libraries in violation of the law in Gautam Nagar were also sealed.

Further drives are being planned for 32 properties in Saidulajab and nine properties in Khirki Extension in the



coming days. MCD said the areas will be kept under constant vigil to identify any further unauthorised construction and non-compliant guest houses.

Across all zones since June 1, the South Zone has seen demolition action against 12 properties and sealing of 14. The Civil Lines Zone recorded demolition action against seven properties.

Eight illegal properties were demolished in the

Narela Zone. MCD also issued more than 150 notices, including unauthorised construction notices, sealing notices, and demolition orders, against properties for misuse and bye-law violations across all zones.

A senior MCD official said the sealing and demolition work was carried out by MCD teams assisted by Delhi Police, with bulldozers deployed to remove illegal structures.

Hotel fire: Six injured patients remain on ventilator support, condition stable

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Six patients injured in the recent hotel fire in south Delhi remain on ventilator support, though all of them are stable and showing signs of improvement, Max Hospital in Saket said on Friday. Sources added that the six patients are foreign nationals.

The hospital said a total of 15 patients are currently admitted at its Saket complex, of whom 13 are international patients.

According to the hospital, nine patients are admitted in the ICU and wards, and the overall condition of all those undergoing treatment remains stable.

The hospital further said



that two injured international patients were brought to its emergency department from another hospital on June 3, the day of the fire incident. Both patients were discharged on the evening of June 4, it said.

"All admitted patients are recovering, and the hospital continues to provide com-

prehensive medical care and regular monitoring to ensure the best possible outcomes," the hospital said in a statement.

Twenty-one people were killed and several others injured after a massive fire broke out at a hotel in Delhi's Hauz Rani area on Wednesday.

People are scared to come: The effect of hotel fire on foreign patients, translators

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Currently, when the phone rings, Ben is uncertain whether it will be a patient confirming travel plans to Delhi or postponing the journey indefinitely following the fire in Malviya Nagar.

For over a decade, the Congolese national has assisted French-speaking African patients in navigating Delhi's hospitals by translating medical records, accompanying them during consultations, and arranging accommodation and transportation. Two days after a fire destroyed a bed-and-breakfast (B&B) facility in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani area, resulting in 21 fatalities, including several foreign nationals, these plans were abruptly halted.

"We were expecting patients, but they have put their tickets on hold till further notice," Ben said.

"People are scared to come. We had already given them estimates of hotel costs and treatment expenses. Now we don't know where we will accommodate them," he added.

The tragedy has produced ripple effects extending beyond the immediate victims. It has unsettled translators, interpreters, and patient facilitators who serve as the initial point of contact for many foreign nationals seeking medical treatment in Delhi.

Ben arrived in India in



2009 to study animation and graphic design at a private college in Chennai. Currently, in addition to teaching French, he assists patients from French-speaking African countries. He charges approximately ₹2,000 per hour to translate prescriptions and discharge summaries, accompany patients during consultations, and facilitate navigation of cultural and language barriers.

"We are all helping people from our countries. Most of us are from French-speaking countries, such as the Congo. We don't charge every patient. Those who can afford to pay do so, but many who come here for long-term treatment already face high expenses. The fire has deterred prospective patients. Ben stated that it has also complicated arrangements for those already present in Delhi.

"For people coming for surgery or treatment, the first question now is where they will stay," he said, adding that the situation is disturbing.

According to facilitators,

the primary issue is not solely the availability of rooms but also their affordability. Many patients arrive with budgets intended to cover treatment, medications, and extended accommodation near hospitals.

"Suppose you have informed a patient and they have planned their budget accordingly. Then suddenly you tell them the place where they were supposed to stay is no longer ₹1,000 or ₹1,500 a night but double that amount," Ben said.

For certain families, the additional expense has escalated into a financial crisis.

"They are calling relatives back home and asking for financial support to continue staying here," he said. Anxiety has intensified amid reports of inspections and crackdowns on several guest houses operating in the area, further disrupting accommodation for patients.

Patients, many of whom are already coping with serious illnesses, are concerned they may be forced to relocate during the course of their treatment.

Deadly Malviya Nagar fire leaves neighbourhood's businesses in dark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The deadly fire that claimed 21 lives at a hotel in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar has not only disrupted the hospitality sector in the area but also dealt a severe blow to dozens of small businesses that depend on guests staying in the locality's hotels and guest houses.

Several eateries, laundries, grocery shops, and travel service providers in the Hauz Rani area said their businesses have come to a near standstill since authorities sealed or vacated several hotels and guesthouses following the June 3 blaze.

A dhaba owner, Abdul Wasim, said most of his customers are patients and attendants staying in nearby hotels. "Our dhaba was already closed during Eid last month, and we opened

for hardly one or two days. Again, it has remained shut for three days, and God knows how many more days it will be closed," he said.

"Many of our customers used to come from nearby guest houses for breakfast and dinner. Some of my workers are worried about their wages, and a few have already left for their villages," Wasim added. Rakesh Kumar, who runs a laundry service in the area, said the closure of hotels has virtually wiped out his business.

"Nearly 80 per cent of our work comes from hotels and guest houses. Bedsheets, towels, and guests' clothes are washed here every day. Since the fire, there has been hardly any work. We may suffer losses of around Rs 1 lakh if the situation continues for another few weeks," he said.

Mohammad Arif, owner

of a convenience store, said sales have dropped as many guests have left the locality. "Usually, there is movement throughout the day. People buy water bottles, snacks, medicines and daily-use items. Since Wednesday, the area has been unusually quiet. Our sales have fallen by more than half," he said.

The usually busy neighbourhood appeared subdued, with fewer people on the streets and little commercial activity visible.

Sanjay Gupta, who runs a food corner near the hotel cluster, said several businesses in the lane survive on the steady flow of patients visiting nearby hospitals.

"Many attendants stay here for weeks during treatment. They eat at our shops every day. Now, many hotels are vacant, and customers have disappeared overnight," he said.

2 masked visitors, 30 minutes: Probe into Delhi professor's murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Preliminary investigation revealed that two individuals — a man and a woman — entered a Delhi professor's house on Wednesday, the day she was murdered, wearing masks and carrying bags. They left about 30 minutes later. It remains unclear whether their visit occurred before or after the murder of Professor

Debosmita Paul. Her body was discovered on Thursday afternoon by her sister. Paul lived alone in the flat, which belonged to her sister. She had been separated from her husband since 2022 following a domestic dispute; he resides in Bengaluru, while her parents live nearby.

A scholar of English literature with a distinguished academic record, Paul completed her undergraduate studies at Maharaja



Debosmita Paul

Agrasen College (University of Delhi), earned her post-

graduate degree from Barkatullah University, and obtained both her M.Phil. and PhD (2016) from Jamia Millia Islamia.

Her research focused on partition studies, postcolonial literature, Indian writings, and translation.

Colleagues and students at Shivaji College described her as a dedicated teacher and mentor who contributed actively to departmental research and student

development.

The discovery unfolded around 2:35 pm on Thursday when police received a PCR call from her sister, Devarati Paul. Devarati had grown concerned after repeated calls to Debosmita went unanswered since morning. Arriving at the apartment, she found the flat locked from the outside. She broke open the lock and discovered her sister's body lying in a pool of blood.

LG Sandhu orders deployment of armed female police personnel in DTC buses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Giving the utmost priority to the safety of women in public transport, Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed the deployment of armed female police personnel in DTC buses.

Underlining that the security of women has to be ensured till their doorsteps, he also called for the speedy installation of panic buttons and CCTVs in the buses and the presence of more women marshals.

This slew of measures was the key takeaway from a high-level review meeting on Friday, chaired by Sandhu with the Secretary-cum-Commissioner (Transport), GNCTD, Managing Director, DTC and other senior officers of the Transport Department. The agenda were the safety measures for women in public transport.

After reviewing the rollout of the Pink Smart Card initiative and the status of CCTV deployment, panic buttons, operations of the control centre, deployment of bus marshals, and women partic-

ipation in bus operations, the LG underlined that the safety and security of women passengers should not only be ensured while they were travelling inside the DTC buses and other modes of public transport but also to their doorsteps once they have de-boarded at the stations, depots or bus stands. For this purpose, the LG directed the officials to onboard the cab and three-wheeler operators, e-rickshaws, etc.

For this purpose, the L-G directed the officials to onboard cab and auto aggre-



gators and e-rickshaws and the deployment of female armed police personnel in

the buses, the officials said. Rollout of the Pink Smart Card initiative, status of CCTV

and panic button deployments, operations of the control centre, bus marshals, and women's participation in bus operations were reviewed in the meeting.

Acknowledging the department's successful rollout of the Saheli Pink Smart Card, Sandhu stressed the need to make the card usable in all modes of public transport to ensure seamless travel for women passengers.

He emphasised leveraging the current operational baseline of 1,002 women conductors and 77 women drivers to further expand

female recruitment across public transport fleets.

The department was also asked to focus especially on electric vehicles as last-mile connectivity options to reach remote areas, peripheral pockets, and unserved neighbourhoods in the city.

Sandhu also emphasised the need to introduce and encourage carpooling initiatives only for women by onboarding private aggregators like Uber, Ola, Bharat Taxi and Rapido.

This would ensure that at any given time, even if the driver was male, a lady pas-

senger was not forced to travel alone, officials added.

Delhi is ranked as the second worst city in mobility, according to the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs' Ease of Living Index, which also has the least number of buses per 100,000 population amongst all the Tier 1 cities.

DTC operates one of the largest public bus networks in India, with lakhs of passengers relying on it for daily travel. But the system has struggled with complaints of indiscipline, poor service and lack of accountability.

Delhi CM launches NamO Oxygen Parks on World Environment Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On the occasion of World Environment Day, Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched 18 NamO Oxygen Parks from the Maidangarhi area in South Delhi on Friday. The launch aims to strengthen urban greening, improve air quality, and promote community-led environmental stewardship in Delhi.

During the event, the Union minister and the chief minister also planted saplings. In a statement, the chief minister said, "This year, the Delhi government presented a green budget in which 21 per cent of the



budget has been marked for green projects. The Government has a target to plant 15 lakh plants this year." The Chief Minister said these NamO Oxygen Parks are different from ordinary parks as they prioritise indigenous and environmentally beneficial species such as peepal, banyan,

jamun and mango trees.

She added that the government not only wants to plant trees but is also focusing on protecting them, adding that all government departments have been asked to focus on developing green buildings and protecting trees.

The event also witnessed the release of three docu-

ments. They include 'Working Plan Document for the National Capital Territory of Delhi (2026-27 to 2036-37)', a 10-year framework document outlining strategies and targets for environmental governance, conservation, and sustainable development in Delhi.

Another document is 'Delhi Bird Atlas', a compilation of data on Delhi's avifauna, produced through citizen science efforts involving birdwatchers, naturalists, and volunteers across the city. The event was also attended by Delhi's Environment, Forest and Wildlife Minister SardarManjinder Singh Sirsa, South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Chhatarpur MLA Kartar Singh Tanwar and other dignitaries.

PM announces India's 100th Ramsar site in UP's Ballia

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Lucknow

The Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary in Uttar Pradesh's Ballia district has been designated as India's 100th Ramsar site, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced on Friday. Ramsar sites are wetlands of international importance under the Ramsar Convention, an environmental treaty established in 1971.

In a post on social media, Modi said, "A century as far as Ramsar sites are concerned! Glad that the Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary (Surha Tal) in Ballia, Uttar Pradesh has been designated as India's 100th Ramsar site. This wetland is rich in avifaunal biodiversity, attracting several migratory and resident birds."

The prime minister also



stated that India's unwavering commitment to protecting its natural surroundings and wetlands in particular is clearly reflected in this milestone.

"Over the years, efforts to conserve and rejuvenate wetlands have been strengthened through greater community participation, science, innova-

tion and awareness initiatives. These endeavours are helping preserve biodiversity, secure ecological balance and create a greener future for coming generations," he said.

The Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary, which is also known as Surha Tal, is the 13th Ramsar site of Uttar Pradesh, according to an

official statement issued in Lucknow. UP Forest Minister Arun Kumar Saxena presented the certificate related to it to Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on the stage during an environment day program, the statement said.

India is one of the Contracting Parties to the 'Convention on Wetlands', known as the Ramsar Convention, signed in Ramsar, Iran, in 1971. India became a signatory to the convention on February 1, 1982.

Ramsar sites are significant as they can serve as model examples of the nation's commitment to conservation and management under internationally accepted frameworks.

In designating a wetland as a Ramsar site, countries agree to establish and oversee a management framework aimed at conserving the wetland.

Parvesh Singh reviews flood-prone spots in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Friday said all necessary arrangements have been put in place ahead of the monsoon, with officials on high alert. The minister was on an inspection visit to the Zakhira underpass, one of the biggest waterlogging hotspots identified by Public Works Department (PWD).

"After the last spell of rains, PWD and the Delhi Jal Board officials have been continuously visiting identified waterlogging locations and assessing the situation on the ground," he told reporters after the visit. Singh said all necessary arrangements have already



been completed ahead of the monsoon season.

"With about a month and a half still left for the rains, all pump stations and officials are on high alert and monitoring each point closely. Our effort is to ensure that Delhi residents

do not face inconvenience," the minister said.

During the inspection, the minister reviewed the construction of a drainage system being developed from Rama Road to Zakhira flyover on the Rohatk Road to reduce waterlogging in

the area. "Every department must work in coordination to deliver a 'water-logging-free' Delhi this monsoon," he added.

Singh said the Delhi government has undertaken a city-wide drive to identify, monitor and rectify vulner-

able locations. Meanwhile, the PWD has issued an order directing officials to complete the desilting work of its drainage network by June 15 — before the arrival of monsoon in the city.

"Cleaning of drains should start immediately now onward and it shall be ensured that all drains are properly cleaned by June 15. Proper evidences in the form of photographs/videos in support of drains having been cleaned, should be maintained," the order said.

The minister also directed the officials to ensure strict supervision of all ongoing works and their timely completion.

Gujarat retains top exporter status in India despite global headwinds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat continued to dominate India's export landscape in 2025-26, retaining its position as the country's largest exporting state despite facing global trade uncertainties and pricing pressures in key sectors.

According to data released by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), Gujarat recorded exports worth \$10.63 billion during the financial year, accounting for approximately 25.6 per cent of India's total exports. The state maintained a substantial lead over Maharashtra,



which ranked second with exports of around \$70 billion and a 16.2 per cent share of the national export basket.

While Gujarat remained the country's leading export hub, overall exports from the state declined by 4.9 per cent

compared to the previous financial year. Industry observers attribute the slowdown to tariff-related challenges in major international markets and softer prices for several key export commodities.

Analysts noted that fluctuations in crude oil prices and continued weakness in the natural diamond market affected export earnings from the state. However, Gujarat's long-standing strengths in infrastructure, industrial development, port connectivity and entrepreneurship helped it preserve its leadership position in external trade.

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GDP reveals India's economy is strong: PM

"India has moved far beyond negativity. It is a nation of boundless optimism and extraordinary aspirations. On one hand, we secured oil and gas supplies from various parts of the world and on the other, we ramped up historic investments in renewable energy," the PM said addressing a gathering in Surat after inaugurating and laying foundation stones for development projects of ₹18,000 crore in Gujarat.

On the occasion Prime Minister pointed out that voters have repeatedly given mandate to the BJP as they trust his Government's development initiatives and growth-driven agenda for the country. This was reflected in the massive mandate the BJP-led NDA received in the recent elections in West Bengal, Assam, and Puducherry, and in panchayat and municipal corporation polls taking place across the country, he mentioned. The PM noted the current decade is proving to be a period of crises for the world and referred to the COVID-9 pandemic, wars and now energy crisis in the wake of the West Asia conflict, but asserted India faced each of these challenges with strength and resilience through the collective efforts of its 140 crore citizens.

The PM also attacked the Opposition for constantly mocking his government's 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' initiative. "They consistently belittle this national resolve. These are the people who have always kept India dependent on other nations. They forget that a country dependent on others can never attain the heights of development it truly deserves," he insisted.

To accelerate the 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' initiative, the country is currently focusing heavily on connectivity. Projects like the Vadodara-Mumbai Expressway, the Dedicated Freight Corridor, and the Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train corridor reflect this priority of India, he stated.

India eases tax rules for foreign investors

Foreign investors are subject to a long-term capital gains tax of 12.5 per cent on listed shares and bonds held longer than 12 months.

They pay a withholding tax of 20 per cent on interest earned in Government bonds. The Ordinance signed by President Droupadi Murmu defines the BIS as the international financial institution established in 1930 and headquartered in Basel, Switzerland.

It also references existing statutory definitions of FII and Government securities under Indian law.

With the view to enhance participation by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) in G-sec, it said, the government has decided to expand the list of specified securities under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) to also include new issuances in government securities in tenors of 15-year, 30-year and 40-year as also Sovereign Green Bonds in the tenors of FAR-eligible securities.

The sub-categories of investment limits, namely, 'general' and 'long-term' will also be merged into a single limit for investment in Government securities and SGSs, respectively, it said. These measures will help in development of a smooth yield curve, and attract stable systematic inflow of long-term, patient foreign capital, including long-term investors such as pension funds, insurance companies, and sovereign wealth funds. This is also expected to boost foreign exchange inflows for the country, it added.

RBI holds repo rate at 5.25%...

It also cited risks from a below-normal monsoon forecast and possible El Nino conditions, which could put pressure on food prices in the months ahead. RBI lowered its growth expectations for the current fiscal year, projecting real GDP growth at 6.6 per cent in 2026-27, below the 6.9 per cent April forecast. The projection is also lower than 7.6 per cent estimated for 2025-26.

It forecast inflation to rise to 5.1 per cent in 2026-27, with price pressures expected to peak at 5.9 per cent in the third quarter before easing. This compares to the previous projection of 4.6 per cent average retail inflation for the year.

Core inflation is expected at 4.7 per cent, up from earlier projection of 4.4 per cent.

While headline inflation remains below the RBI's 4 per cent target with a tolerance band of 2-6 per cent, MPC cautioned that higher global energy prices and supply shocks could trigger broader second-round effects on wages and inflation expectations.

"The MPC felt it would be prudent to wait for greater clarity to emerge," the Governor said, adding that the central bank would remain data-dependent and closely monitor inflation risks.

India lodges strong protest over Pakistan's...

"The Government of India categorically rejects any attempts by Pakistan to bring material changes to areas under its illegal occupation," the statement said, adding that such measures cannot conceal the fact that Pakistan continues to occupy Indian territory unlawfully.

Reiterating its position, India underlined that Pakistan must vacate all areas under its illegal and forcible occupation. The Government maintained that any electoral exercise or administrative action undertaken by Pakistan in these territories carries no legitimacy and does not alter India's sovereign claim over the region.

The development comes amid continuing tensions between the two countries over the status of Jammu & Kashmir and related territories, with New Delhi consistently opposing any attempts to alter the character or status of areas it considers an integral part of India.

Another solid growth year as GDP hits 7.8%

Quarterly sector-wise data showed particularly strong growth in trade, hotels, transport, communication, broadcasting and storage-related services, which expanded 12.5 per cent year-on-year. Financial, real estate and professional services followed with a growth of 10.4%. Manufacturing registered an increase of 7.3%, while the construction sector grew by 8.4% during the quarter.

Notably, manufacturing, trade, repair, hotels, transport, communication & services related to broadcasting, storage and financial, real estate & professional services sectors have attained double-digit growth at both constant and current prices in FY26. Hailing the robust economic growth in the country, the government is hopeful that the Centre's macro stability and supply measures can bring back India on a 7 per cent growth trajectory in the next fiscal year, also.

In a statement, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MOSPI) said that real GDP or GDP at Constant Prices is estimated

to attain a level of ₹323.12 lakh crore in the FY 2025-26, against the First Revised Estimate (FRE) of GDP for the year 2024-25 of ₹299.89 lakh crore. The growth rate in Real GDP during 2025-26 is estimated at 7.7% as compared to 7.1% in 2024-25.

Nominal GDP or GDP at Current Prices is estimated to attain a level of ₹346.36 lakh crore in the year 2025-26, against ₹318.07 lakh crore in 2024-25, showing a growth rate of 8.9%. "Real GVA is estimated at ₹294.91 lakh crore in the year 2025-26, against ₹273.36 lakh crore in FY 2024-25, registering a growth rate of 7.9% as compared to 7.3% growth rate in 2024-25. Nominal GVA is estimated to attain a level of ₹314.87 lakh crore during FY 2025-26, against ₹288.54 lakh crore in 2024-25, showing a growth rate of 9.1%," it said.

This is the second set of GDP data in the new series, with 2022-23 as the base year.

Commenting on the data, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday said the Government is committed to further drive the 'Reform Express' with decisive policy measures to ensure positive economic momentum amid global challenges. "Our government, led by Hon'ble PM Shri @narendramodi, is committed to further drive the 'Reform Express' with decisive policy measures to ensure positive economic momentum amidst the global challenges," Sitharaman said in a post on X.

Addressing a press conference after the release of the data, Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said the GDP data reflects a balanced picture with respect to different components of the economy.

He also said India will return to a 7 per cent growth rate in the next fiscal year on the back of policy measures. "We have no reason to second-guess them (RBI forecast) at this point, because there are both possibilities on the upside and on the downside with respect to the numbers that they have presented," he said here. "So, even if the growth were to slip below 7 per cent as the RBI forecast suggests... macro stability measures and supply assurances will bring us back to a 7 per cent plus growth track in FY28 or as soon as external conditions improve," Nageswaran said.

On the expenditure side, both private final consumption expenditure (PFCE) and gross fixed capital formation (GFCF) registered over 7.5 per cent expansion during 2025-26. The gross value added (GVA) has been estimated at Rs 294.91 lakh crore in 2025-26, against Rs 273.36 lakh crore in 2024-25, registering a growth rate of 7.9 per cent as against 7.3 per cent in the preceding year. The GVA in the fourth quarter of FY26 was Rs 80.18 lakh crore against Rs 74.32 lakh crore in the year-ago period, registering a growth of 7.9 per cent.

From ID fraud to fire tragedy: Lavkesh's...

When investigators traced the address listed on Sweetly Sarkar's Indian passport, it led them to Bajaj. The address, B-50, 2nd Floor, Gali No 18, Chattarpur Enclave, Delhi, belonged to him. During interrogation, Bajaj admitted that he had knowingly permitted the accused to use his residential address for obtaining Indian identity documents in exchange for money, thereby facilitating their illegal stay in the country. All three, Bajaj, Sweetly Sarkar, and Pushpo Sarkar, were arrested, and a chargesheet was filed before the court. A Police Information Report was separately submitted regarding the minor child.

The revelation that Bajaj had a prior criminal record involving fraudulent documents and

foreign nationals assumes particular significance given that 12 of the 21 people killed in Wednesday's fire were foreign nationals, most of them relatives of patients receiving treatment at a nearby private hospital.

In the current fire case, investigators have established a series of serious safety violations at Flourish Stay. The building was licensed for only six rooms under Delhi's bed-and-breakfast scheme, but was allegedly operating 25 rooms, including those in the basement. Windows in parts of the building were reportedly sealed. Multiple LPG cylinders were stored in the kitchen. Officials believe these violations contributed to the rapid spread of the fire and made evacuation nearly impossible.

Investigation has now expanded beyond Bajaj. Police are searching for accountant Jai Mishra, who has been on the run since the fire. Raids are being conducted across Delhi and the NCR. Sources said Mishra handled accounts, administrative work, and operational affairs for Bajaj's hospitality business. Documents being examined by investigators reportedly show that some licences linked to the guest house were obtained in Mishra's name. Police are also examining the role of manager Rakesh and other staff members.

Love, conflict, murder: Mohali office...

The accused, Harjinder, who also worked in the same company and whose workstation was reportedly located near hers, allegedly entered her cabin carrying two knives and launched a sudden assault from behind.

As per the CCTV footage and preliminary investigation, Dimple was busy with her work when the accused approached from behind and repeatedly stabbed her in the neck. Caught off guard, she screamed and attempted to flee towards other staff members in the hope of finding help. However, the attacker relentlessly chased her through the office premises, continuing the assault as she ran for her life. Even after she reached the office entrance area, he allegedly caught up with her and continued stabbing her repeatedly.

The footage reportedly shows terrified employees rushing to intervene. Yet the attacker brandished the knife and threatened anyone who came near, forcing several staff members to back away. In a dramatic moment, one employee managed to snatch a knife from the attacker. But the accused had allegedly come prepared. He immediately pulled out a second knife and resumed the assault on the already critically injured woman. Investigators believed that the presence of two knives indicates premeditation. Witnesses said that the attacker appeared uncontrollable and continued his assault despite repeated attempts by colleagues to stop him.

Once he was convinced the victim would not survive, the accused reportedly moved to another part of the office and began attacking himself. CCTV footage shows him repeatedly stabbing and slashing his own throat in a desperate suicide attempt.

When the self-inflicted wounds failed to render him unconscious immediately, he allegedly slit his throat with the knife before collapsing in a pool of blood.

The incident triggered panic across the office. Employees alerted the police and emergency services, following which both the victim and accused were rushed to Fortis Hospital. Doctors declared Dimple dead as she

succumbed to her injuries during treatment, while the accused, Harjinder alias Harry, remains hospitalized in critical condition. Police have seized CCTV footage, collected forensic evidence, and initiated a detailed investigation. Preliminary findings suggested that the accused and victim had worked together for nearly three years and may have shared a personal relationship that later ended.

Investigators suspected that the accused had been struggling to accept the breakup and had unsuccessfully attempted to revive the relationship. Police believed an argument between the two shortly before the attack may have triggered the violence. However, officials have stressed that the exact motive has not yet been conclusively established and all angles remain under investigation.

Shah vows zero tolerance...

Shah had assured BSF troops that the project would be launched within the force's 60th year, making the Pakistan and Bangladesh borders more secure. In dense forests and unfenced pockets along the 4,096-km Bangladesh border, the announcement carries operational weight.

The Home Minister acknowledged the force's daily challenges: "Every border has its own challenges, from human trafficking to arms smuggling to drug supply, but the BSF jawans do their best to face these challenges." Yet he stressed that stopping these flows is necessary for realising Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a 'Viksit Bharat' (developed India) by 2047. "To make India a 'viksit' nation by 2047, we have to stop the entry of fake notes, human trafficking and drug smuggling from across the borders," Shah declared.

The emphasis on West Bengal, Tripura, and Bihar is not accidental. These states, or those linked to them through migration corridors, have long been at the centre of debates over illegal immigration from Bangladesh. The smart border concept is designed to bridge these gaps through technology, intelligence from local administration and community networks.

Shah's directive for the Union Home Secretary and BSF chief to tour the frontiers underscores the hands-on approach the government intends to adopt. But it may not address root causes, including porous governance, political patronage in some pockets and economic pull factors across the border. Yet the Modi government's strategy appears multi-pronged: complete the remaining fence, overlay it with AI surveillance, accelerate deportation of identified infiltrators and use the high-level demography panel to generate actionable data. The panel's terms of reference include recommending a "permanent operational system" for identification, detention and deportation.

For the BSF, Friday's address at Lankamura was both validation and a challenge. The force, stretched across difficult terrain, now stands on the cusp of a shift from boots-on-the-ground vigilance to a tech-augmented, intelligence-led model. Shah's assurance that the Centre will "bridge the gaps in guarding international borders" signals political backing at the highest level. As India moves towards its 2047 centenary milestone, the battle on its eastern and western frontiers is no longer just about territory. It is about demographic integrity and national security. "Shah's message from Tripura was clear: the era of tolerance for demographic engineering is over.

Assam Cabinet expansion: 11 BJP MLAs sworn in

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

BJP MLAs Ranaj Pegu, Ashok Singhal, Biswajit Daimary and AGP's Keshab Mahanta were among the 12 legislators who took oath as ministers on Friday as Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma expanded his Cabinet, taking the strength of the council of ministers to 17.

Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya administered the oath of office and secrecy to the MLAs at a function at the Jyoti-Bishnu Antarjatik Kala Mandir in Guwahati.

The chief minister, Union ministers Sarbananda Sonowal and Pabitra Margherita, Assam Assembly Speaker Ranjeet Kumar Dass, BJP State president Dilip Saikia and several NDA MLAs were present at the event.

"It's a balanced team which

represents the aspirations of all sections of people and their experience and wisdom will further strengthen our resolve to build a #ViksitAssam," the CM said about the new ministers in a post on X.

In another post, Sarma said, "Team Assam has grown today and is ready to serve the people with renewed zeal". Congratulating all those who have taken the oath, the CM said their experience and wisdom will add immense value to the Council of Ministers and chart the path to fast-paced growth and prosperity.

Among the new faces in the Cabinet are BJP's Ashwini Ray Sarkar, Nilima Devi and Sushanta Borgohain.

Ray Sarkar, representing Golakganj in Dhubri district, became an MLA for a second time this year after 2016.



Assam Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya in a group photograph with State Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and the newly sworn Cabinet Ministers during the oath-taking ceremony of ministers-designate in the Assam Council of Ministers in Guwahati on Friday

Nilima Devi, the president of the BJP's Mahila Morcha, has been elected to the assembly for the first time and represents the Mangaldoi constituency.

Borgohain, a third-time MLA, had first represented the Congress from 2011-16 and later joined the saffron party.

He had won on a BJP ticket in 2021. He represents the Demow constituency in Upper Assam.

AGP's Mahanta, who was in both Himanta Biswa Sarma's previous cabinet as well as in the Sarbananda Sonowal-led first BJP Government in the State, was included in the

new council of ministers.

BJP MLAs Bimal Borah, Jayant Mallabaruah, Kaushik Rai, Krishnendu Paul and Pijush Hazarika, who took the oath, had also served as ministers in the previous Himanta Biswa Sarma Government. Pegu, a former Chief Executive Member of

the Mising Autonomous Council, represents the Dhemaji constituency and has been a minister since 2021.

Daimary, the speaker in the last Assembly and a former Rajya Sabha member, has been elected from the Tamulpur constituency.

Singhal, a veteran BJP leader, has been a minister since 2021 and represents the Dhekiajuli constituency.

Borah has been representing the Tingkhong Assembly constituency in Upper Assam and has been a minister since 2021.

Hazarika has been representing the Jagirroad constituency since 2011 and has been a minister since 2016.

Mallabaruah has won from the Nalbari constituency from 2011 to 2016 and again from 2021, holding ministerial berth in Sarma's cabinets.

Nation Focus



KHARGE FILES NOMINATION FOR RS FROM KARNATAKA

AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge filed nomination papers for the Rajya Sabha from Karnataka at Vidhana Soudha here on Friday. Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, former CM Siddaramaiah, Congress general secretaries Randeep Singh Surjewala and KC Venugopal, and several ministers were present.

The nomination papers were submitted to the Assembly secretary, MK Vishalakshi, officials said.

Kharge is the Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, and his term in the Upper House of Parliament is coming to an end on June 25. The party has also fielded Pawan Khera and Mansoor Ali Khan for the Rajya Sabha election from Karnataka.

NEET leak issue: Digvijaya urges PM to issue white paper

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Digvijaya Singh has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the NEET-UG paper leak issue, urging the Government to issue a white paper documenting the instances of paper leaks or irregularities in NTA-conducted examinations in the last eight years and the action taken on them.

Singh, who is also the chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, said that at a

State Governments, the Rajya Sabha MP said.

Amidst the absence of official information, there are plenty of reports and rumours that have taken their place, Singh pointed out. "For instance, one repeated complaint I have received is that the main accused in the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak in Hazaribagh, Sanjeev Kumar alias Mukhiya, is reportedly out on bail.

Similarly, the CBI has reportedly filed a closure report stating that no irregularities occurred in the UGC-NET exam of 2024, which had been cancelled



time when lakhs of students are under heavy pressure, it is critical to reinforce their faith in the system.

"I am writing to you to raise a very important concern which several students have relayed to me in the last few weeks. At a time when the cancellation of the NEET-UG 2026 examination has wreaked havoc on the mental health of lakhs of students, one critical stressor for them has been the lack of clarity on how previous paper leaks, etc., have been investigated," Singh said in his letter to Modi.

There is presently no consolidated public record of cases relating to paper leaks, and how they are being prosecuted by the CBI and other investigative agencies of the Centre and

by the National Testing Agency (NTA) back then," he said.

When asked by a Delhi court to provide a written explanation for its closure report, the CBI has asked for more time, Singh pointed out. The CBI's delay in providing its explanation has similarly sent out a negative message among India's students, Singh said.

"To inspire renewed confidence in the administration's ability and willingness to deliver justice to India's students, I therefore propose that the Government of India issue a white paper documenting the list of instances of paper leaks and/or irregularities which have occurred in NTA-conducted examinations in the last eight years," Singh said.

CBSE files police complaint over cyber attacks on portal

PRAMOD KUMAR SIINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has formally lodged a complaint with the Delhi Police Cyber Cell after coordinated cyber attacks targeted its Post-Result Services Portal. The online platform, used by millions of students for result-related services, was secured through the board's round-the-clock monitoring system, officials confirmed on Friday.

In an official statement, the CBSE said the portal, which handles re-evaluation applications, photocopies of answer sheets, verification of marks, and digital mark-sheet downloads, came under sustained assault in recent days. The board's 24x7 cybersecurity monitoring team detected and blocked every attempt in real time, the statement said. "There was no data breach, no leakage of student information, and no com-



promise of the system at any stage," it added.

CBSE officials described the incident as a serious attempt to disrupt the academic ecosystem at a time when the portal sees heavy traffic after the declaration of Class 10 and Class 12 board results. The Post-Result Services Portal, introduced to digitise and streamline post-examination formalities,

processes lakhs of applications every year. Such an attack could have exposed students' sensitive personal and academic data, including Aadhaar-linked details and examination records. The complaint filed with the Delhi Police Cyber Cell invokes the provisions of the Information Technology Act and seeks a thorough investigation into the origin

and motive of the attacks. Police sources said preliminary inquiries point to a possible organised syndicate, though no arrests have been made so far. A senior police officer said investigators are coordinating with central agencies and forensic experts to trace the attackers.

CBSE Chairperson reiterated the board's commitment to digital safety, saying student data security is its topmost priority. The Chairperson also said the board has invested significantly in advanced firewalls, intrusion detection systems, and continuous monitoring protocols. Cybersecurity experts hailed the board's response as exemplary. Dr Anjali Sharma, a leading cyber forensic consultant based in Delhi, noted that educational institutions are increasingly becoming soft targets for cybercriminals, especially during the results seasons when traffic spikes.

TMC to move HC over LoP recognition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The TMC will move the Calcutta High Court on Monday, challenging the West Bengal Assembly speaker's decision to recognise rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of the Opposition in the House, party MP Kalyan Banerjee said.

The decision was taken at a meeting convened by TMC supreme Mamata Banerjee on Friday evening, where senior party leaders discussed the fallout of the rebellion by a section of its MLAs that has shaken the organisation after its defeat in the recent assembly elections.

The TMC on June 3 suffered its first split in its 28-year history as 58 rebel MLAs elected expelled leader Ritabrata Banerjee as leader of opposition, wresting control of its legislature



party, and secured recognition from the Assembly Speaker, plunging Mamata Banerjee's outfit into its gravest internal crisis since its inception.

"We have decided to move court against the decision of the Speaker. We think the decision is against established norms and parliamentary procedures. Rules have been violated," Kalyan Banerjee told reporters after the meeting. Reacting to the proposed

legal challenge, Ritabrata Banerjee dismissed the allegations and asserted that all constitutional and procedural requirements had been followed.

"All norms have been followed. Today, there was a meeting convened by Mamata Banerjee. Please go and see how many legislators attended that meeting," he told reporters, suggesting that the majority of elected representatives remained with the rebel camp.

Annamalai quits BJP, announces new party

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Chennai

Former Tamil Nadu BJP President K Annamalai, who gained huge popularity due to his aggressive style of politics and took on the Dravidian parties head-on, resigned from the party's primary membership on Friday.

Asserting that his goals are bigger and that more people would have to be taken along under a fresh, inclusive agenda, he announced that he would launch a new political party and face the next polls in Tamil Nadu.

In a social media address, Annamalai said, "I have great respect for PM Modi," and asserted that he has quit the BJP in a dignified manner. He further asserted his commitment to ushering in a new kind of politics.

"From today onwards, a new path, a new movement, a new political movement,"



Former Tamil Nadu BJP president K Annamalai resigned from the party's primary membership on Friday

he declared after BJP national chief Nitin Nabin accepted his resignation. Annamalai is said to have tendered his resignation during his recent visit to Delhi.

"The National President of the Bharatiya Janata Party, Nitin Nabin, has accepted the resignation submitted by the Tamil Nadu Ex-State President, K Annamalai, from the primary membership of the party," BJP national general secretary Arun Singh

said in a statement on Friday.

While Annamalai's supporters welcomed his decision by bursting firecrackers and distributing sweets, the BJP said his exit was no loss to the party.

In his address, the former Tamil Nadu BJP chief said the new movement, which he proposed to launch, must, from the foundation level, have new dimensions and a new perspective.

1,000 Indians deported from US this year, says MEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 1,076 Indian nationals have been deported from the US this year so far, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday, noting that the two sides are committed to acting against illegal migration. MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said a total of 3,567 Indians were deported in 2025. "A total of 1,076 Indian nationals have been deported from the US to India so far this year. During 2025, a total of 3,567 people were deported from the US," he said.

The Trump administration has been targeting illegal migrants in the US as part of a major crackdown. Both sides are in close touch on the issues of deportation, migration and mobility, Jaiswal said. "Discussions regarding migration and mobility are underway between the two sides."

Bihar council polls: Nitish's son among 4 JD(U) nominees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The JD(U) on Friday announced four candidates for the upcoming polls to the Bihar Legislative Council, which included Nishant Kumar, the son of party chief and former chief minister Nitish Kumar. Biennial polls to nine seats of the 75-member strong Vidhan Parishad were announced recently, along with the bypoll to the one vacated by the JD(U) president, who became Rajya Sabha MP in April.

The BJP's upper caste candidates include Sanjay Mayukh, the party's national media co-in-charge, who will make a hat-trick in the legislative council, besides Bhojpur superstar Pawan Singh, who had contested the 2024 Lok Sabha polls from Karakat as an Independent candidate. The remaining BJP candidates, Anil Thakur and Sheela



Pandit, both EBCs, are grass-roots-level workers.

Speculations are rife that one of the NDA candidates could be Deepak Prakash, a state minister who is the son of Rashtriya Lok Morcha president Upendra Kushwaha. Neither Nishant nor Deepak Prakash is a member of the legislature, and rules require them to get elected to either House within six months of induction into the cabinet. Filing of nomination papers for the biennial elections, as well as the by-poll, ends on June 8.

Lalan Prasad, a leader from the extremely backward class (EBC), Dhanuk, who is known to be loyal towards the JD(U) supremo, is the party's candidate to the bypoll to the legislative council seat vacated by Nitish Kumar, said the party's state president, Umesh Kushwaha.

The other JD(U) candidates for the upcoming polls are both women — party spokesperson and women's wing chief Bharti Mehta, besides Shivrani Devi Prajapati, a party worker from West Champaran.

Maharashtra approves ₹2,267 cr for Kumbh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government on Friday approved ₹2,267 crore for the acquisition of 191.21 acres of land reserved for the Sadhu Gram project for the 2027 Nashik-Trimbakeshwar Kumbh Mela.

The Government warned that diversion of the Kumbh project-linked funds for any other purpose would be treated as a serious financial irregularity, inviting action against those responsible.

The Urban Development Department issued a Government resolution (GR) sanctioning ₹2,267 crore to the Nashik-Trimbakeshwar Kumbh Mela Authority for the acquisition of the land reserved within the civic corporation limits for the temporary township (Sadhu Gram) that will house seers and religious akharas (organisations of Hindu ascetics) during the mega congregation.

The GR stated that the approved amount includes



compensation for the acquisition of 191.21 acres of land and ₹3 crore towards administrative expenditure connected with the acquisition process.

According to the Government, around 377 acres had been reserved for Sadhu Gram and allied uses in the Nashik Development Plan-2017. Of this, nearly 94 acres have already been acquired, while the remaining land is required to be secured ahead of the 2027

Kumbh Mela. The resolution directed that compensation payable to landowners be verified and transferred immediately through RTGS (Real-Time Gross Settlement, an electronic payment system). It fixed joint responsibility on the Nashik district collector and the city's municipal commissioner to ensure the timely acquisition and possession of the land so that the project does not suffer delays. In a key condition, the GR said the funds

sanctioned for the Sadhu Gram land acquisition project can be utilised only for that purpose and cannot be diverted to any other work. Any permanent or temporary diversion of the principal amount or interest earned on it would be treated as a "serious financial irregularity", and the implementing agency, authority, urban local body or officials concerned would be liable for action, the order warned.

The Government clarified that the sanction is a one-time funding arrangement and that any increase in project cost beyond the approved amount would have to be borne entirely by the Nashik Municipal Corporation.

No additional grant over and above the sanctioned sum would be provided by the State Government, the GR emphasised. The resolution was issued in pursuance of a decision taken at a meeting of the state cabinet's infrastructure committee held on April 22.

States Focus



KARNATAKA ISSUES ORDER FOR FREE STUDENT BUS PASSES

The Karnataka Government on Friday issued an order implementing the free bus pass scheme for all students, which was announced by Chief Minister DK Shivakumar after the first Cabinet meeting following his assumption of office. The Cabinet on Wednesday decided to extend free bus pass facility to all students studying in schools and colleges across the State. "Accordingly, the Government has granted in-principle approval to extend the free bus pass facility to all school and college students in Karnataka travelling on buses operated by the State's four transport corporations," a statement said. The facility can be availed of by students travelling on buses operated by the Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC), Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTCL), North West Karnataka Road Transport Corporation (NWKRTC), and Kalyana Karnataka Road Transport Corporation (KKRTC). (PTI)



CASTE CENSUS FOR TN TOP PRIORITY: THIRUMAVALAVAN

VCK's newly inducted Minister for Social Justice, Vanni Arasu, who attended the council's first session under the newly formed coalition Government in Tamil Nadu, advocated for a comprehensive state-wide caste census, party chief and MP Thol Thirumavalavan said on Friday. Briefing reporters, Thirumavalavan outlined the party's legislative agenda, emphasising that an inclusive data collection mechanism was vital for equitable governance. "Our primary demand is a thorough, data-driven census," he said. He underlined the need to map the educational, social, and economic conditions of Scheduled Castes and other marginalised communities across the State. (PTI)

AirTrunk to invest ₹3 lakh crore in India: PM Modi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Leading hyperscale data centre specialist AirTrunk plans to invest more than ₹3 lakh crore in India by 2030 in support of digital infrastructure capacity, positioning the country as a cornerstone of global growth strategy.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday announced the investment plans of AirTrunk, the Asia-Pacific and Middle East technology company, and its strategy to develop 5 GW of data centre capacity in India after his meeting with AirTrunk founder and CEO Robin Khuda.

"India's digital infrastructure journey is gathering remarkable momentum. AirTrunk has announced plans to invest around ₹3 lakh crore (\$30 billion) in

India and develop 5 GW of data centre capacity. This is among the largest proposed investments in the country's digital infrastructure ecosystem," he said in a post on X.

Modi noted that such investments will strengthen India's position as a global hub for cloud computing and AI, while generating employment opportunities, supporting local supply chains and accelerating innovation-led growth.

"It is clear that the future of the world's digital economy is increasingly being shaped in India," he said.

AirTrunk is a hyperscale data centre specialist creating a platform for cloud, content and large enterprise customers across the Asia-Pacific and Middle East (APME) region. AirTrunk CEO Khuda said that Prime Minister Modi's vision for India's digital



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a meeting with AirTrunk Founder and CEO Robin Khuda in New Delhi

economy has helped create one of the world's most compelling destinations for technology investment. "India has the scale, talent, and ambition required to become

a global AI powerhouse. AirTrunk is excited to support that vision," he said in a company statement. Backed by Blackstone — one of the largest foreign investors in

India— and the Canada Pension Plan Investment Board (CPIB), AirTrunk's proposed investment programme would rank among the largest digital infrastructure initiatives currently being considered in the country and help enable the next wave of growth in cloud and artificial intelligence.

"AirTrunk plans to invest more than ₹3,000 billion (\$30 billion) in India by 2030 in support of digital infrastructure capacity, positioning the country as a cornerstone of AirTrunk's global growth strategy and one of the company's most significant long-term investment markets," AirTrunk said in its statement.

The company's proposed development pipeline in India, across multiple states and union territories, would

support India's ambition to become a global destination for AI and cloud infrastructure investment while generating significant economic activity, employment, and technology ecosystem growth, it said.

The announcement follows AirTrunk CEO Khuda's first senior Government engagement programme in India since the company's entry into the market through the acquisition of Lumina CloudInfra in April this year. Through this acquisition, AirTrunk's existing development pipeline in India includes 600 MW across Mumbai, Chennai, and Hyderabad.

The company develops and operates data centre campuses with industry-leading reliability, technology innovation and energy and water efficiency.

Great Nicobar project defence claim is a lie, says Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday said the Government's argument that the Great Nicobar Island Project is about defence and a transshipment port is a "lie", and alleged that it is actually about benefiting one businessman so that he can build hotels and casinos on India's most irreplaceable ecological land.

Gandhi released an over 15-minute video based on his visit to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands in late April and urged people to sign a petition to tell the Government, "we choose green over greed".

"This World Environment Day, I want to ask every young Indian one question: What kind of India do you want to inherit? One where rainforests have been bulldozed for casinos, coral reefs



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi interacting with people during a visit to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands

erased from maps, tribal communities pushed off their land, and the air we breathe turned into poison? Or one where India's natural heritage is protected, our tribal communities are safe, and progress works with nature, not against it," Gandhi said on X.

He alleged that right now, the Government is destroying Great Nicobar Island. "More than 1.5 crore trees,

BJP hits back at Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday hit back at Rahul Gandhi's criticism of the Great Nicobar development project, alleging that the Congress leader is "disturbed" by India's growing geopolitical expansion and would rather want to see other countries become more powerful than India.

The remarks came after Gandhi's statement on World Environment Day on Friday. In an over 16-minute video statement on social media, he termed the Modi Government's argument that the Great Nicobar Island Project is about defence and a transshipment port a "lie," alleging that it is actually about benefiting one businessman so that he can build hotels and casinos on India's most irreplaceable ecological land.

BJP national spokesperson Tuhin Sinha said the vision for the Great Nicobar



BJP national spokesperson Tuhin Sinha

project dates back to the 1970s and accused the Congress of failing to implement such "futuristic" projects despite having conceived them decades ago. "If the Congress could only imagine such projects but was unable to implement them, that is certainly not our fault.

"Through this project, India's active land presence in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands will effectively move nearly 400 kilometres further south, deeper into the Indian

Ocean. The development planned at the southern tip of Great Nicobar Island will be located only about 75 to 80 kilometres from the Strait of Malacca, which handles nearly 30 per cent of global maritime trade today," he said.

"You can therefore imagine the immense commercial and shipping significance of a port located so close to it. You can also imagine the geostrategic importance of Great Nicobar Island," he added.

TMC's Firhad Hakim resigns as Kolkata mayor



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior TMC leader Firhad Hakim on Friday resigned as the mayor of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC), citing that he was unable to work properly.

Hakim, a former state minister and one of the most prominent faces of the TMC, submitted his resignation amid continuing political churn within the party, following its defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections.

Sources said the resignation has been forwarded to the appropriate authorities.

Hakim, also an MLA, had been serving as the mayor of KMC since November 2018 and was the first Muslim mayor of the city since Independence.

NIA declares former TMC MLA absconding in Bhangar blast case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The NIA on Friday declared former TMC MLA Saokat Molla absconding in connection with the Bhangar blast case in West Bengal, as it continued to carry out extensive searches to trace him, a senior officer said.

Molla, the ex-MLA from Canning Purba, is believed to have gone into hiding, the officer said.

All three mobile phones used by the accused are switched off, he said, adding that all relevant details of the accused have been shared with the BSF to ensure that he does not leave the country.

"We have declared Saokat Molla absconding and have alerted all agencies concerned. Necessary information has been shared with the BSF and other authorities to prevent any attempt to cross the international border," the officer said.

The official added that the agency is pursuing multiple leads regarding Molla's whereabouts.



"There are indications that he may be hiding at a relative's residence. Several teams are carrying out searches and verification exercises. We are confident of tracing him soon," the official said.

On Thursday, the central probe agency conducted searches at Molla's residence, party office and several locations, arresting one more person as part of its ongoing investigation into the explosion that took place in March, taking the total number of arrests to three.

The person arrested on Thursday is the driver of the four-wheeler, which was used to transport the bomb makers.

"With the arrest of Sainur Molla, the driver of the SUV, the total arrests in the case have gone up to three," a release by the probe agency said. "A total of eight locations, including the residence and suspected hide-outs of former MLA and absconder Saokat Molla—a prime suspect and conspirator in the case—were searched as part of the operations," it mentioned.

The NIA officers questioned members of Molla's family and later held his son. According to the official, the central probe agency sleuths have evidence that Molla was last seen travelling on a motorcycle in the Chunakhal area towards Basanti early Thursday.

Target \$30 billion marine exports in 5 years: Piyush Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam (Andhra Pradesh)

Union Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday said the country should target marine product exports worth \$30 billion over the next five years, up from the current \$8 billion.

Addressing the National Workshop on Seafood Exports here, Commerce and Industry Minister said that in 2013-14, India exported marine products worth about \$5 billion.

"Hon'ble Minister Rajiv Ranjan (Lalan) Singh and I discussed this only a week ago when we conceptualised this programme under his leadership. We felt that this sector should set a target of no less than \$30 billion over the next five



years," Goyal said. He added that the target could be achieved through higher production and greater attention to quality.

Goyal said India had achieved 70 per cent growth in marine product exports

Shivakumar, German delegation discuss investment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday held talks with a high-level German delegation here and discussed investment opportunities to strengthen bilateral economic cooperation, officials said.

The delegation, led by Mario Voigt, Minister-President of the German state of Thuringia, is currently on a visit to Karnataka, they said.

Speaking on the occasion,



Shivakumar said Karnataka and Thuringia would work closely to identify areas of mutual interest, including

joint ventures, technology transfer, and the exchange of skills and talent. He added that the Government of Karnataka

and Thuringia would collaborate to drive innovation and advance next-generation technologies.

Welcoming the delegation, Minister for Large and Medium Industries MB Patil, who was also part of the meeting, said Karnataka and Thuringia share strong potential for collaboration in sectors such as optics and photonics, semiconductors, biotechnology, electric vehicles, renewable energy, and advanced manufacturing.

Arunachal Govt sets up panels on infiltration, tribal rights

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu on Friday said his Government has constituted four high-powered committees to examine infiltration issues, strengthen the Inner Line Permit system, re-verify ST certificates and protect the rights of indigenous people.

Khandu said the panels were formed in line with the resolutions adopted at consultative meetings, held on May 27 and May 29 under his chairmanship, on issues concerning indigenous tribal rights, Arunachal Pradesh Scheduled Tribes, the ILP framework and related concerns. Khandu said the panels



Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu

bring together representatives of the All India Tribal Federation (AITF), All Arunachal Pradesh Students' Union (AAPSU), Arunachal ST Bachao Andolan Committee, legal experts, scholars and Government officials to ensure a broad-based and participatory approach in addressing the issues.

Addressing concerns over infiltration and illegal immigrants, the Government has formed a high-powered committee headed by Environment and Forests Minister Wangki Lowang, an official order stated.

The committee has been tasked with studying the prevalence of infiltration and

immigration in the State and recommending measures for stronger border control, biometric and digital verification systems, and action against forged identity documents and undocumented settlement networks.

The panel has also been mandated to suggest administrative and legal measures to curb illegal immigration and strengthen existing safeguards within the constitutional and legal framework.

It will submit its recommendations to the Government within six months of its first meeting.

To further strengthen the Inner Line Permit regime, the Government has constituted another committee headed by Agriculture and Horticulture Minister Gabriel

D Wangsu. The committee will examine the existing system of issuance, monitoring and verification of ILPs, review the 2026 ILP guidelines and recommend restructuring measures to strengthen the framework.

It has also been tasked with proposing technology-driven mechanisms for ILP issuance and monitoring, developing a robust verification process, and recommending suitable categories for issuance of such permits to tourists, visitors and workers.

The Government has also constituted a panel headed by Education Minister Pasang Dorjee Sonu to examine the re-verification of APST certificates and related matters.

Tamil Nadu CM's Cabinet unveils roadmap for 436 projects: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The first meeting of the Tamil Nadu Cabinet led by CM C Joseph Vijay, on Friday, unveiled a comprehensive roadmap for 436 targeted projects across various Government departments, Electricity Minister CTR Nirmal Kumar said.

Briefing reporters after the meeting, Kumar stated that the chief minister has set specific, long-term goals for every department, emphasising time-bound execution of welfare and development initiatives.

"Chief Minister Vijay



presided over the first Cabinet meeting today and provided a clear, visionary direction for all departments. A total of 436 specific projects and goals have been outlined to guide the governance trajectory of this administration," Kumar said.

The minister underscored that the departmental plans mainly incorporate the promises in TVK's election manifesto. "The respective ministers and top officials of each department will thoroughly assess these plans, formulate detailed execution strategies, and determine the timeline to implement them efficiently. A presentation will be done to the chief minister for final approval," he added.

According to the minister, the cabinet meeting prioritised accelerating development and creating enhanced employment opportunities for youth and women.

Congress infighting will derail governance: Karnataka BJP Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka BJP chief BY Vijayendra on Friday launched a sharp attack on the newly formed Congress Government in the State following Minister Ramalinga Reddy's resignation over portfolio allocation, alleging that infighting within the ruling party would derail governance and development.

Speaking to reporters, Vijayendra said the resignation of the senior Congress leader within hours of the allocation of portfolios exposed deep divisions within the ruling dispensation. "Shivakumar may be the chief minister, but this is Siddaramaiah's Cabinet. The very first wicket has fallen," he said.

Referring to Reddy, who announced resigning from the minister post, alleging



Karnataka BJP chief BY Vijayendra

that assurances regarding the Bengaluru Development portfolio had not been honoured, the BJP leader claimed that the Congress Government was already witnessing internal power struggles.

"The Shivakumar Government will not even last two years. Already, there is a tug-of-war over who should get which portfolio and who should be given charge of which district. Amid

this infighting, Reddy himself has resigned today," he said.

Vijayendra alleged that the ongoing tussle within the Congress would come at the cost of governance.

"With the Government that exists today under DK Shivakumar's leadership, it is impossible to expect development in the State. They are engaged in betraying the trust and expectations of the people," he said.

Claiming that people were disillusioned with the Congress Government, he said, "The people of the State expect this anti-poor and anti-people Congress Government to be removed. They want a BJP Government to come to power."

The BJP state chief further predicted that the Congress leadership would remain preoccupied with internal rivalries.

"It would not be surprising if a mid-term election is held even before that," he said.

Meanwhile, Leader of the Opposition R Ashoka also took a swipe at the Congress on social media, claiming factionalism had become a defining feature of the party in Karnataka.

In a post on 'X', he remarked that, "Kannadigas may one day wake up to a morning without the sun, but not a day without Congress infighting in Karnataka."

Pune liquor deaths expose State Govt negligence: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The recent Pune liquor tragedy, which resulted in 22 deaths, has exposed the Maharashtra Government's failure to implement recommendations made in 2015 after a much bigger incident in Malvani in north Mumbai, Congress leader Sachin Sawant said on Friday.

The Pune incident is a consequence of the Government's negligence, the Congress national secretary said, adding that action taken against 26 personnel from the police, excise and other departments was inadequate and did not address the larger issue of systemic failures.

"What happened to the recommendations of the Malvani committee? The Devendra Fadnavis Government must disclose this. The Pune hooch tragedy is not merely a failure of the local administration, but a test of whether the Government has learnt any lessons from previous disas-

ters," he told reporters. After the incident in Malvani, in which 106 persons died, the State Government had formed a committee under the chief secretary to suggest measures to curb the manufacture and sale of illicit liquor, and the Home Department had issued directions on February 17, 2022, to all departments to implement the committee's recommendations, he said.

These included stricter control over methanol production and transportation, coordinated action by police and excise authorities against illicit liquor units, and stronger measures against organised criminal networks involved in the trade, he said.

"Despite these recommendations, such incidents continue to occur, which means the State Government has failed across departments," Sawant said while questioning the preparedness of authorities to deal with hooch-related emergencies. Pointing out that the com-



Congress leader Sachin Sawant

mittee had recommended standard operating procedures, antidote stockpiles and training for doctors and healthcare personnel, the Congress leader asked whether hospitals treating victims of the Pune tragedy had adequate medicines and trained staff available.

Enforcement agencies appear to act only after major tragedies, he said, citing raids conducted on methanol stockpiles and illicit distilleries in places

such as Bhiwandi following the Pune incident. "Had the recommendations made after the Malvani tragedy been effectively implemented, could the Pune Sawant demanded that the Government place in the public domain a detailed status report on the implementation of every recommendation made by the Malvani committee and explain the reasons for delays in carrying out pending measures.

Kerala unveils action plan to tackle human-animal conflict

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Kerala forest department has prepared a 100-day action plan to reduce human-animal conflict in the State, an issue highlighted by the Congress-led UDF during its Assembly election campaign in the high-range regions.

Addressing a press conference after holding meetings with forest officials in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala Minister Shibu Baby John said a centralised solar fencing monitoring system and an automatic fault-detection system would be set up with public participation.

He said the system would allow controlled public access to report faults in solar fencing along forest borders.

The State forest minister said solar fencing currently covers 2,000 kilometres of border areas and that fencing along an additional 100 kilometres would be completed within the next 100 days.

The Government also plans to extend solar fencing by another 1,900 kilometres over the next five years. "Another major step is vista clearance-the clearing of trees and dense shrubbery up to 20 metres from the solar fencing-to prevent elephants from pushing trees onto the fences to gain entry," John said.

He added that shrubs and undergrowth near forest roads would also be cleared with the help of local self-Government departments.

Funds from MPs, MLAs, NGOs, and CSR initiatives would be explored to meet



the costs of the programme. He said vista clearance covering 100 kilometres would be completed within the next 100 days.

Similarly, the number of Rapid Response Teams (RRTs) would also be increased.

"At present, we have 28 RRTs, which are inadequate to monitor 6,000 kilometres of forest boundaries. We are planning to create 25 more satellite RRTs that will function out of forest offices," the minister said.

The Kerala forest department currently relies on Primary Response Teams (PRTs) comprising trained local community members in panchayats located along forest borders.

Similarly, the department will also create Metro Rescue Teams, modelled on the PRTs, in which trained volunteers will help drive away straying animals.

In the first phase, eight metro rescue teams will be formed in Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, Kottayam, Ernakulam, Thrissur, Palakkad, Kozhikode, and Kannur. Drone squads will also be formed to provide

timely alerts about animals straying into human settlements and to monitor stranded animals in populated areas or farmlands.

"We will also ensure AI-aided real-time warning systems and monitoring systems in all forest divisions. Camera traps will also be deployed in areas witnessing severe human-animal conflict for better monitoring of animal movement," John said.

The quality of existing forests would be improved by removing invasive species such as Senna and Acacia.

The department is also exploring the production of value-added products using invasive species as a revenue-generation model for tribal communities. The action plan also seeks to address the compensation system for victims and survivors of human-animal conflict.

The proposal includes a 50 per cent increase in compensation for fatalities caused by human-animal conflict and a single-window clearance system to ensure compensation is disbursed within seven days.

Himachal, UNDP sign MoU on waste management, green initiatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

An MoU to advance climate-resilient, inclusive and sustainable development in Himachal Pradesh was signed by the State Government and the United Nations Development Programme on Friday.

The agreement was signed in the presence of Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and Environment, Science, Technology and Climate Change secretary, a statement issued here said.

The partnership envisages collaboration in key areas such as circular economy, waste management, social inclusion of waste management workers, electric mobility for waste collection and other climate-resilient development priorities, it said.

It also covers natural resource management and biodiversity conservation, including landscape restoration, ecosystem-based adaptation, nature-based solutions, biodiversity-linked sustainable livelihoods for local communities, protection of critical habitats and biodiversity corridors and strengthening of regulatory and governance



frameworks for ecological resilience in climate-vulnerable regions of the State.

The partnership will also promote gender-responsive and socially inclusive development by ensuring the participation of women, marginalised communities and informal workers in planning and imple-

mentation processes, the statement said.

Speaking on the occasion, Sukhu said the agreement would enable the State to integrate global best practices with local solutions to protect its fragile Himalayan ecology while creating sustainable green livelihood opportunities for

Three killed after assailants attack village in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Three people, including a woman, were killed after armed assailants launched an attack at a village in Manipur's Kangpokpi district early on Friday, officials said.

At least seven houses were also gutted in a fire during the attack around 4 am at Loibol Khullen village in Saitu-Gamphazol subdivision of the district, they said.

The three died amid an exchange of fire between rival groups for several minutes, which prompted villagers to run for shelter in



nearby forest areas, an official said.

The deceased have been identified as Lethkhongam Haokip, Tinmary Haokip and Jangminlal Haokip.

Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen condemned the attack and said those responsible will be dealt with as per law. "The killing of three inno-

cent persons and the burning of homes by unknown armed miscreants is a tragic and unacceptable act. My thoughts and prayers are with the bereaved families and all those who have been affected.

"The Government is taking this incident very seriously. Necessary steps are being taken, and those responsible will be dealt with as per the law. The safety and security of our people remain our priority," she said in a statement.

Kipgen also appealed to people to remain calm and "not be provoked by those

who seek to create fear and division".

Meanwhile, the Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), the apex body of Kuki tribes in the state, also denounced the attack and demanded an investigation to apprehend the perpetrators.

"KIM unequivocally denounces this barbaric act of violence against unarmed civilians. The deliberate killing of innocent persons, and the destruction of homes and livelihoods constitute a serious violation of human dignity and fundamental human rights," it said in a statement.

Ramalinga Reddy resigns as Karnataka minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The two-day-old Congress Government in Karnataka, led by Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, suffered a setback on Friday when Minister Ramalinga Reddy resigned, expressing displeasure over portfolio allocation.

Reddy said he was promised the Bengaluru Development portfolio but was instead made Minister for Major and Medium Irrigation Projects.

The resignation came after Chief Minister DK Shivakumar allotted portfolios on Thursday night.

"I am resigning from my post because I cannot work against conscience," Reddy said at a press conference. He said, "How long can I tolerate this humiliation, and what other options did I have?"

"Twice they called me and promised to give me that (Bengaluru Development) portfolio, but in the end it went to someone else. That is why I feel hurt. Therefore, today I am resigning," Reddy told reporters, while asserting that he would continue in Congress and remain as



MLA. The development marks the first major challenge for the Shivakumar Government, which assumed office on Wednesday.

Reddy, an eight-time MLA from Bengaluru, said he had never lobbied for a ministerial office or sought any specific department from the party leadership during his five-decade-long political career.

Asked whether he would reconsider if persuaded by the party leadership or offered the portfolio he wanted, Reddy replied with a firm "no".

"I will remain in the Congress party. I will continue as a Congress MLA. There is no second thought about that," he said. During the press conference, the Congress leadership made a last-ditch attempt to persuade him, but Reddy remained firm.

Jammu gets regional MeT centre to boost weather forecast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Friday formally declared the establishment of a new Regional Meteorological Centre at Jammu, marking a major step towards strengthening weather forecasting and disaster preparedness across Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh and Himachal Pradesh.

The newly established MeT centre at Jammu will integrate weather observations with a state-of-the-art X-band Doppler Weather Radar system and an expanded network of automatic weather stations, significantly enhancing real-time weather monitoring, forecasting accuracy and early warning capabilities across the northwestern Himalayan region, the officials said.

Singh said the centre would provide regional weather forecasting, district-wise forecasts and advanced nowcast services, enabling highly accurate weather predictions up to three hours in advance.

"Specialised weather forecasts will be issued for



Union Minister Jitendra Singh

tourists, mountain regions and disaster management agencies. Dedicated forecasting services will also be available for sectors such as agriculture, aviation and pilgrimage-related helicopter operations," he said.

The minister said the upgraded meteorological infrastructure would play a key role in minimising losses by natural disasters and contribute to the vision of a developed India.

"Timely forecasting and early warnings for flash floods, cloudbursts, avalanches, heavy snowfall, thunderstorms and landslides will help save lives

and reduce economic losses. Separate forecasting mechanisms have been designed for flood management, aviation operations and farming activities," he said.

He said the establishment of the Regional Meteorological Centre in Jammu marks a new chapter in the department's long history and reflects the Centre's focus on strengthening scientific infrastructure in the Himalayan region.

Referring to the region's diverse agro-climatic conditions, Singh said weather advisories would be customised for different crops and farming systems.

India has immense opportunities in seafood sector: CM Naidu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Friday said India accounts for only five per cent of the global seafood business, observing that the country has immense opportunities in the sector.

Addressing a national workshop on seafood exports in Visakhapatnam, the CM said the growth of Andhra Pradesh's blue economy would contribute significantly to the country's development.

The blue economy focuses on the sustainable use of ocean and coastal resources to drive economic growth while protecting marine ecosystems. "India's share in the global seafood business is only five per cent. The country has tremendous opportunities in this sector," Naidu said.

According to the CM, Andhra accounts for 28 per cent of India's fish production and 66 per cent of shrimp production, while contributing 38 per cent of the country's seafood export earnings. He said Andhra's seafood exports



Union Minister Piyush Goyal and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu during the inauguration ceremony of a national-level workshop on seafood exports in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh

are valued at about ₹28,000 crore annually.

Naidu said that if Andhra Pradesh develops further in the sector, India's seafood exports would also grow, adding that the State's 1,053-km-long coastline, ports, and airports provide a major advantage.

For the success of products in any sector, the CM said quality, sustainability, traceability, innovation, and zero pollution are essential.

He also urged the Centre to take measures to further develop aquaculture products. Assuring cooperation with the Centre's initiatives to

develop the sector, Naidu said the Union Government had promised to establish mega seafood processing parks in the State.

He said the "Andhra Shrimp-India Seafood" brand should be promoted globally, adding that while India should emerge as a global leader in aquaculture, Andhra Pradesh should position itself as the sector's growth hub.

Naidu announced that an aquaculture corridor connecting Amaravati, Bhimavaram, Kakinada, Visakhapatnam, Krishnapatnam, and Nellore would be developed.

Editor's

TAKE

From Caracas

with crude

As the Strait of Hormuz stalls Indian tankers, a South American lifeline grows in strategic importance, opening a high-stakes diplomatic chapter

The visit of Venezuelan Acting-President Delcy Rodríguez is good news for Indian households, as she brings with her the promise of an alternative to Gulf oil that can keep Indian cars running and the wheels of industry turning. Venezuela's Acting President, heading a high-powered delegation that includes her finance, science and transportation ministers, arrives at a moment when India's energy calculus has been upended. The near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz – a corridor that once handled over 40 per cent of India's crude imports – has forced Indian refiners into a scramble for alternative supplies. Venezuela, sitting atop the world's largest proven oil reserves, has stepped decisively into that breach. The numbers are striking. India imported 427,000 barrels per day from Venezuela in May alone, making it the second-largest buyer of Venezuelan crude globally, trailing only the United States. Reliance Industries has emerged as one of Caracas's three largest customers worldwide. Bilateral trade stands at \$678.94 million – modest by global standards, but a number that carries momentum and direction.

Diversification is meaningless without reliable alternatives. Venezuela, once sidelined by US sanctions, re-entered India's supply map after sanctions were eased in February under a Washington-Caracas oil pact. The timing was fortunate: it gave Indian refiners a viable Western Hemisphere alternative precisely when the eastern routes tightened. New Delhi – with at least tacit American encouragement – has moved with unusual swiftness to secure the relationship.

What makes this partnership structurally attractive is price. Venezuelan heavy crude trades at a significant discount to Brent benchmarks, helping India moderate its import bill at a time of fiscal pressure. Three takeaways deserve particular attention. First, supply-chain resilience now demands geographic diversification, not just source diversification. India cannot afford a repeat of the Hormuz shock; Venezuela offers a supply route across the Atlantic, entirely decoupled from West Asian chokepoints. Second, the bilateral agenda – stretching across pharmaceuticals, renewable energy and transportation – suggests India intends to offer Venezuela a development partnership, not merely a transactional crude contract.

Third, Rodríguez's visit comes five months after President Nicolás Maduro's dramatic detention by U.S. forces, a fact that places India in a diplomatically delicate position - one it is navigating with characteristic pragmatism, keeping Washington engaged while preserving access to Caracas.

Diplomatically, the trajectory points towards a structured long-term energy agreement – possibly involving rupee-bolivar settlement mechanisms, equity participation by Indian PSUs in Venezuelan oilfields, and joint ventures in refining. India has walked this road with Russia, Iraq and the UAE. Venezuela is the next chapter. The risk is political volatility in Caracas. New Delhi will seek contractual architecture that hedges against it. If this visit delivers even a framework agreement, it will mark a significant step in India's quiet but relentless effort to build an energy supply network that no single geopolitical crisis can unravel.

Realpolitik over idealism

Sharing a long and porous border with Myanmar, confronting cross-border insurgency, managing refugee flows, advancing critical infrastructure projects, and countering China's growing influence leave India with little room for diplomatic idealism



PARUL CHANDRA

Driven by strategic pragmatism, India has had to embrace the military government of Myanmar despite the severe democratic backsliding there. New Delhi recently rolled out the red carpet for Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing, who seized power in 2021 through a military coup that toppled the democratically elected government of National League for Democracy (NLD) leader and State Counsellor Aung San Suu Kyi.

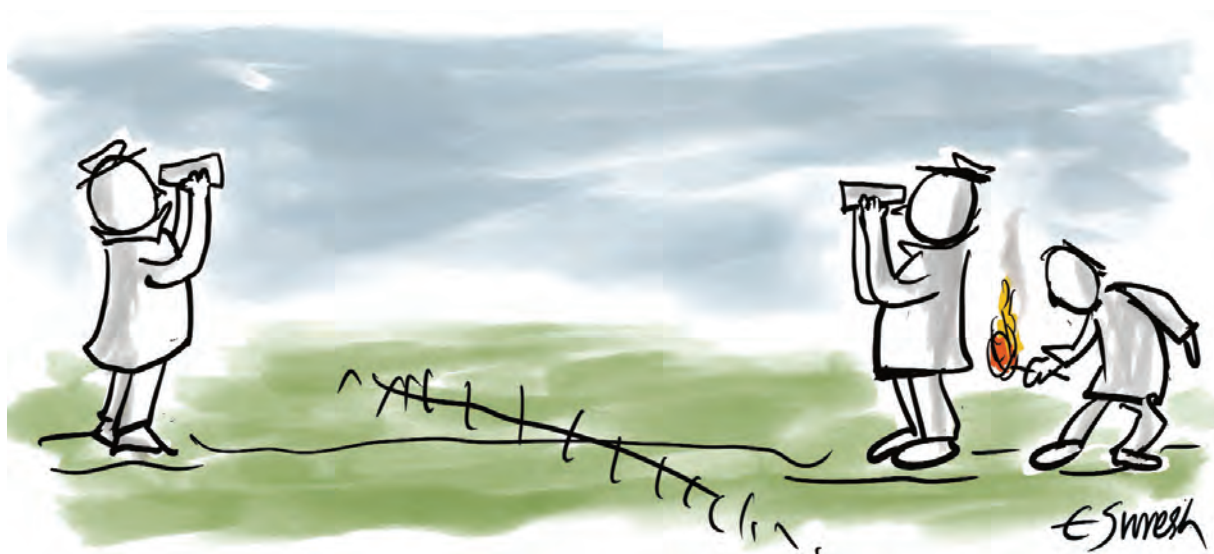
India, which prides itself on being the world's largest democracy, notably refrained from hosting U Min Aung Hlaing during the first four years after the coup. However, the veneer of legitimacy the former military chief has now achieved by engineering his appointment as President through a dubious parliamentary vote helped India shrug off its hesitation.

Myanmar, after all, is of immense geostrategic importance to India, with the two countries sharing an extremely porous 1,643-km land border. A restive and unstable neighbourhood directly threatens India's national security interests, reinforcing the pressing need for New Delhi to engage with Nay Pyi Taw at the highest level.

India was the military leader's first port of call since becoming President in April. Myanmar's close ally, China - which has no qualms about the military junta's trampling of democratic norms – had already engaged with U Min Aung Hlaing on the sidelines of regional summits before he assumed the role of President. This intensifying geopolitical jostling with Beijing for influence remains a primary driver behind New Delhi's diplomatic outreach.

Following the high-level meeting between U Min Aung Hlaing and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, New Delhi sought to frame this renewed engagement not as an endorsement of a repressive regime, but as part of its belief in "sustained dialogue" with a neighbour. As Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri noted, "History has shown that disengagement doesn't give us any results that are better than engagement, and it certainly doesn't produce democratic change."

The visiting Myanmar President's assurance, in turn, that "its territory would not be permitted to be used against India's security interests" was certainly welcomed here. This pledge is critical for two reasons. One, armed insurgents from India's Northeast have long used Myanmar's soil as a safe haven from



A RESTIVE AND UNSTABLE NEIGHBOURHOOD DIRECTLY THREATENS INDIA'S NATIONAL SECURITY INTERESTS, REINFORCING THE PRESSING NEED FOR NEW DELHI TO ENGAGE WITH NAY PYI TAW AT THE HIGHEST LEVEL

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which to launch operations in Mizoram, Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh.

Two, the ongoing civil war in Myanmar and the consequent regional instability directly threaten Indian interests. There has already been a huge exodus of refugees into Manipur and Mizoram, forcing India to scrap the long-standing Free Movement Regime (FMR) with Myanmar and step up border fencing. Additionally, the spillover of Rohingya refugees from Myanmar's restive Rakhine State into neighbouring Bangladesh, as well as India, is also a major concern.

Like India, Myanmar faces its own domestic security challenges from various armed rebel factions. Reflecting these shared anxieties, the India-Myanmar joint statement extended Indian support for Myanmar's "sovereignty and territorial integrity", while both sides also condemned the "misuse of sovereign territory for activities inimical to their security interests".

India's strategic imperatives in Myanmar also include a vital connectivity dimension. New Delhi has undertaken two ambitious infrastructure projects in the country: the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway. Both initiatives have suffered massive delays and remain in limbo due to Myanmar's precarious security situation.

The Indian delegation raised the issue during the presidential visit, stressing that these projects remain a "major priority" for India. While U Min Aung Hlaing assured New Delhi that his administration would do everything possible to ensure their completion, achieving this is easier said than done against the backdrop of an active civil war. For now, India can only exercise patience

and hope that local conditions improve enough for construction to resume.

In its quest for alternative routes to bypass the narrow and vulnerable Siliguri Corridor - which could become a chokepoint in a conflict with China - India has heavily invested in the Kaladan project to connect with its landlocked Northeast. Crucially, India has already developed the strategically located Sittwe Port in Myanmar, which will allow goods to be shipped from mainland India by sea and then moved to the Northeast via river and road corridors up to Mizoram. Overlooking the Bay of Bengal, the port is an integral piece of India's strategic calculus - especially since China has developed its own gateway to the bay, the Kyaukphyu deep-sea port.

Equally critical is the trilateral highway project, which can be a game-changer in terms of trade and connectivity. This highway will provide India with direct road connectivity to ASEAN nations, reducing its historical reliance on maritime links and boosting regional trade. In effect, it anchors India's efforts to forge deeper ties with Southeast Asia in line with its "Act East" policy. Myanmar, incidentally, is the only ASEAN member that shares a land border with India, making it an indispensable bridge to the regional bloc.

With Myanmar "sitting at the confluence of India's Neighbourhood First, Act East, and MAHASAGAR policies", as Foreign Secretary Misri described it, New Delhi remains hopeful that its latest overtures to Nay Pyi Taw will successfully protect its long-term strategic interests.

India's calculated embrace of Myanmar's military regime is governed by hard-nosed realpolitik. Bound by a volatile border, escalating security threats, and a high-stakes geopolitical rivalry with China, New Delhi simply cannot afford the luxury of isolation.

Before building temples, build community values



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

We are preparing to vote in our society elections, and the mudslinging and slugfest have descended to levels that many of us have come to associate with elections at much larger political levels. Among the issues dominating the campaign is the proposal to construct a religious structure within the complex, a subject that has generated debate over the limited common space.

The argument advanced by some contestants is that such a structure would create an enabling environment for senior citizens and help inculcate values in the younger generation. It is an attractive proposition because it appeals simultaneously to tradition, culture and community identity. Yet a few conversations over the past few days made me wonder whether we sometimes confuse symbols with substance.

We are, in fact, a household of three senior citizens - my father, my wife and I. My wife observed that many of those advocating such facilities in the name of senior citizens have not yet entered that phase of life themselves. Those of us who have, she remarked, do not necessarily feel the need for such elaborate handholding. The comment contained a larger truth. People often speak for others without understanding what they may actually need.

Another conversation was revealing. A young resident recounted how one of the leading contestants, whose manifesto featured the proposal, had spent considerable time explaining its importance. When the youngster attempted to present an alternative perspective, however, he found himself brushed aside. What struck him was the unwillingness to listen.

His response stayed with me. He pointed out that his parents live with him and that he cares for them every day. What greater lesson in values, he asked, could he impart to his own children than the example of looking after ageing parents within the family? His comment reminded me that values are absorbed through example. Children watch what we do long before they understand what we say.

Religious spaces have their place in community life, just as parks, libraries, playgrounds and cultural centres do. They can provide comfort, belonging and opportunities for engagement. But values are rarely transmitted through buildings alone. They are learned through observation and experience. Children absorb them when they

see respect for differing opinions, courtesy in disagreement, honesty in public life, concern for neighbours and care for elderly family members.

Perhaps the larger question is not what serves us today, but what kind of community we leave for those who come after us. Every society, whether a residential complex or a nation, ultimately depends on citizens who are willing to think beyond immediate preferences and short-term gains. The challenge is not merely to choose what serves us today, but to consider what will enrich the lives of those who will inherit these spaces long after we are gone.

In that sense, every citizen must aspire to be something of a statesman. A politician thinks of the next election; a statesman thinks of the next generation. Our choices about common spaces and values are rarely confined to the present. They shape the culture that future residents and children will inherit.

If a community wishes to leave a lasting legacy for its younger generation, it may need to focus less on what is constructed in concrete and more on what is demonstrated in everyday life. After all, values are not taught merely through places of worship. They are taught through the quiet acts of responsibility, respect, compassion and thoughtful stewardship that children witness every day.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A lifeline beyond blood compatibility

Andhra Pradesh's decision to legally recognise cross-family kidney donation for immunologically incompatible patients is a significant healthcare reform that deserves national attention. For years, many families have faced a heartbreaking dilemma: a willing donor is available, yet blood-group or tissue incompatibility prevents a life-saving transplant. Patients are then forced onto lengthy waiting lists as their health steadily deteriorates.

The newly approved organ swap system offers a practical solution. By allowing compatible donor-recipient exchanges between families, it transforms individual incompatibility into a collective opportunity. The policy also broadens the donor pool to include parents, children, grandparents and grandchildren, increasing the likelihood of successful matches.

The need is evident. Andhra Pradesh currently has 3,634 registered patients awaiting transplants, while 209 deceased donors contribute 663 organs annually. Even a modest rise in successful matches could translate into hundreds of additional transplants each year.

However, policy alone is not enough. Effective implementation and wider awareness are crucial. Most importantly, patients in smaller towns must enjoy the same access as those in cities. Other states should follow suit.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

Annamalai's challenge in Tamil Nadu

One of the biggest challenges facing K Annamalai is not his personal popularity but the political limitations of the BJP in Tamil Nadu. Annamalai remains one of the most recognisable and energetic faces of the party in the state. However, many voters who appreciate him as an individual are still reluctant to support the BJP.

The issues and narratives that work for the BJP in several parts of India have often failed to resonate with Tamil Nadu's distinct political culture. Had Annamalai represented the party in many northern states, his electoral prospects might have been very different.

The BJP's performance in Tamil Nadu has also been affected by organisational weaknesses and internal political dynamics. Critics point to the party's leadership decisions and its relationship with allies as factors that have hindered its growth. The appointment of Nainar Nagendran as state president and the influence of AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami have generated debate within political circles.

Despite these challenges, Annamalai continues to project himself as a hardworking, grassroots leader with a strong connection to ordinary people. His supporters believe that, with greater backing, he could become a stronger force in Tamil Nadu politics.

C K SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

India-Venezuela ties gain momentum

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's talks with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodríguez come at a crucial time for global energy markets. With tensions in West Asia disrupting supply chains and pushing up oil prices, stronger India-Venezuela relations are both timely and strategically important.

India has been increasing its crude oil imports from Venezuela as it seeks to diversify its energy sources and reduce vulnerability to geopolitical disruptions. Recent discussions between the two leaders focused on expanding cooperation in energy, trade, investment, critical minerals, automobiles and other key sectors. Venezuela has emerged as an increasingly important energy partner for India amid ongoing uncertainty in global oil markets. Beyond energy security, deeper engagement offers both nations an opportunity to strengthen economic ties and build a more resilient framework for cooperation. Reliable partnerships are essential in an era marked by supply disruptions and geopolitical volatility.

The visit of Acting President Rodríguez to New Delhi is therefore a welcome development. If both sides can translate discussions into concrete outcomes, the partnership could strengthen India's energy security and expand trade and investment ties.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

HAS RAJYA SABHA LOST ITS

FEDERAL CHARACTER?

When the Constitution came into force and the Rajya Sabha was established in 1952, its framers envisaged it as a true Council of States. Members were expected to represent the interests of the states from which they were elected by state legislatures. For many years, this principle was largely respected.

The first significant departure came in 1991, when Manmohan Singh was elected to the Rajya Sabha from Assam despite not being a native of the state. A residence was arranged in Guwahati, enabling him to contest from Assam before he joined Prime Minister PV Narasimha Rao's Cabinet as Finance Minister.

Since then, the convention that a state's representatives should have a close connection with that state has steadily weakened. Today, individuals can be elected

to the Rajya Sabha from virtually any state, provided they secure the support of a political party with sufficient MLAs in the Assembly.

As a result, disgruntled politicians, businessmen and other influential figures often find entry into the Upper House through states with which they have little or no association. Distinguished public figures are no exception. The trend has raised questions about whether the Rajya Sabha still functions as the Council of States envisioned by the Constitution.

If state representation is no longer its defining principle, critics argue that the Rajya Sabha risks becoming less a federal institution and more a chamber shaped by political convenience.

T H CHOWDARY | HYDERABAD

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PIC TALK



Workers at a lavender field, at Bhaderwah, in Doda district, Jammu and Kashmir.

PHOTO: PTI

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Nutrition security: Why strategic food reserves matter for BRICS

BRICS countries must strive for a future in which strategic food reserves contribute not only to stable food supplies but also to improved nutrition, stronger food systems and greater resilience for millions



ELISABETH FAURE

For decades, discussions on food security have focused, rightly, on ensuring adequate food availability. The central question has been whether countries can produce, procure, and distribute sufficient food to meet the needs of growing populations amid climate shocks, economic uncertainty, and geopolitical disruptions. Over time, BRICS countries have emerged as key contributors to addressing this challenge, playing an increasingly important role in global food production, trade, and food system resilience.

Today, however, the global food security agenda is evolving. While ensuring adequate food supplies remains fundamental, there is growing recognition that food security must also encompass nutrition security. The challenge is no longer only about ensuring access to calories, but also about enabling regular access to diverse, safe, affordable, and nutritious diets that support healthy lives.

The BRICS grouping is uniquely positioned to lead this transition. Collectively, the expanded BRICS countries account for a substantial share of global food production and consumption. Their policies, investments, and food management strategies influence global markets and shape food security outcomes far beyond their borders. In this context, strategic food reserves can play a transformative role—not merely as emergency stockpiles, but as instruments for strengthening resilience, promoting nutrition, and supporting sustainable food systems.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi emphasized while addressing agricultural scientists at the MS Swaminathan Centenary International Conference, the next frontier for agricultural and food systems lies in moving beyond food security towards nutritional security. Strategic food reserves can be a powerful vehicle for achieving that vision.

India's Experience: Building food security through strategic reserves

India's experience offers valuable lessons for countries seeking to strengthen food and nutrition security. Over several decades, the Public Distribution System (PDS), supported by procurement and storage mechanisms, has evolved into one of the world's largest food-based social protection programmes. Public food stocks have played a critical role in stabilising markets, ensuring uninterrupted supplies to vulnerable households, and enabling rapid responses during emergencies. During periods of global market volatility and domestic disruptions, strategic reserves have provided an important buffer, helping maintain food access for millions of households.

India's capacity to sustain large-scale distribution of foodgrains through public programmes has demonstrated how strategic reserves can function as a cornerstone of economic and social policy. These reserves have supported food access, enhanced resilience, and strengthened the country's ability to respond effectively to crises.

At the same time, India's development experience highlights an important policy evolution. While substantial progress has been achieved in reducing hunger and expanding food access, nutrition outcomes require continued attention. This underscores the need to broaden the role of strategic reserves beyond ensuring food availability towards supporting dietary diversity and improved nutrition. The policy question for BRICS countries, therefore, is not whether strategic reserves should be maintained, but how they can be designed to meet the evolving requirements of food and nutrition security.

Strategic reserves in an era of uncertainty

The global environment in which BRICS countries operate is becoming increasingly complex. Climate-related events are affecting agricultural production



and infrastructure, geopolitical developments are influencing trade and input markets, and economic pressures continue to affect food affordability for vulnerable populations.

Against this backdrop, strategic food reserves serve several important functions.

First, they enhance resilience by acting as shock absorbers during periods of market volatility. Reserves provide governments with the flexibility to stabilize supplies, support safety-net programmes, and maintain public confidence during disruptions. Second, they strengthen social protection systems by enabling timely assistance during emergencies such as droughts, floods, pandemics, or economic shocks. By supporting targeted interventions, reserves help protect vulnerable households from severe food insecurity and nutritional setbacks.

Third, strategic reserves can contribute to shaping food systems. Procurement, storage, and distribution policies influence production incentives, market development, and dietary patterns. Well-designed reserve systems can encourage crop diversification, support nutrient-rich food production, and strengthen local value chains.

For BRICS countries, these functions make strategic reserves an important component of broader resilience-building strategies. They also create opportunities for cooperation. Enhanced information-sharing on stock levels, production forecasts, and policy measures can improve transparency, reduce uncertainty, and support more stable global food markets. Greater collaboration during crises can further strengthen collective preparedness and food security outcomes.

Reimagining reserves for nutrition security

Staple grains such as rice and wheat will continue to play a central role in strategic reserves and social protection programmes. Their importance for food security remains unquestioned. However, there is growing scope to design reserves in ways that contribute more directly to nutrition outcomes. India has already begun moving in this direction through efforts to diversify food baskets and strengthen the nutrition sensitivity of public food programmes. Greater emphasis on pulses, millets, fortified foods, and biofortified varieties reflects a broader vision that links food security with nutrition security.

By progressively diversifying procurement and distribution systems, governments can help ensure that public food stocks provide not only energy but also essential nutrients. Such approaches can support healthier diets, reduce dependence on a narrow range of staples, and strengthen resilience against nutritional vulnerabilities.

Strategic reserves can also be more closely integrated with programmes that directly influence nutrition outcomes, including school meal initiatives, maternal and child nutrition programmes, and social protection interventions. When procurement systems prioritise diverse and locally appropriate foods, and when storage and logistics infrastructure is adapted to handle these products effectively, reserves become powerful instruments for advancing nutrition goals.

India's promotion of millets, expansion of

pulse-based interventions, and efforts to strengthen food fortification provide valuable examples of this transition. Other BRICS countries offer equally important experiences, including Brazil's local procurement approaches for school feeding programmes and South Africa's leadership in food fortification initiatives. Together, these experiences create an opportunity for BRICS countries to develop a model of "nutrition-smart" strategic reserves that can inform food security strategies across the wider Global South.

A BRICS agenda with global significance

The decisions made by major economies regarding food reserves have implications that extend far beyond national borders. Policies related to procurement, stock management, and food distribution influence international markets and affect the food security prospects of many food-importing countries.

A coordinated and nutrition-oriented approach to strategic reserves within BRICS could therefore generate significant global benefits. Such an agenda could emphasize maintaining adequate and well-managed reserves, prioritising support for vulnerable populations, integrating nutrition considerations into procurement and storage policies, strengthening transparency, and expanding cooperation on food security and resilience.

It could also create opportunities for enhanced South-South cooperation through technical assistance, knowledge-sharing, research partnerships, and support for countries facing acute food insecurity.

India is particularly well positioned to advance this agenda. Drawing on its extensive experience in public food stock management and its growing role in international development cooperation, India can facilitate dialogue, promote innovation, and foster partnerships that strengthen food and nutrition security across the Global South.

Towards a nutrition-secure future

The World Food Programme has worked alongside India for many years as the country has expanded food-based social protection systems, advanced food fortification initiatives, strengthened digital delivery mechanisms, and explored innovative approaches to nutrition-sensitive food security.

Today, these experiences hold value not only for India but also for many countries seeking to strengthen resilience in the face of increasingly complex challenges. The transition from food security to nutrition security represents one of the most important priorities for contemporary food systems. Achieving this goal requires a broader understanding of strategic reserves—not merely as emergency stocks, but as instruments that support resilience, inclusion, dietary quality, and sustainable development. By embracing this vision, BRICS countries can help shape a future in which strategic food reserves contribute not only to stable food supplies but also to improved nutrition outcomes, stronger food systems, and greater resilience for millions of people across the Global South.

What Cambridge kept asking: The crisis has a centre



ACHARYA PRASHANT

On May 30, I spoke at the Cambridge Union as part of the Cambridge India Business Dialogue, in conversation with Professor Jaideep Prabhu of the Judge Business School. I had been told it would run for about an hour; the room had other intentions. Hands kept rising, the questions deepened, and what had been planned as a single session became nearly three across two days.

What struck me was not the grandeur of the surroundings but the quality of the hunger. These were economists and business scholars, trained to solve problems with models, data and policy; yet something in that room kept returning, insistently, to a question no model addresses: the question of the self that produces the crises the world is so busy trying to solve.

Technology, management and policy are tools, held in hands, and the question that drove me out of the corporate world was not about the tools but about the person behind them: what that person actually wanted, and whether they had ever examined that wanting with any seriousness.

The crisis is a specific combination: enormous outer power meeting an almost entirely unexamined inner life. Inwardly, the human being still operates from the same primitive centre that drove the cave dweller, the felt sense of incompleteness, the restless wanting that no acquisition has ever settled. The issue of having has been met with extraordinary sophistication; the issue of wanting remains almost entirely untouched, and it is there that the crisis lives. A member of the audience asked, with genuine urgency, whether there was time, since climate catastrophe advances faster than any inner transformation could. I understand the urgency and do not dismiss it; but I want to be precise about what the data actually shows.

The economist William Stanley Jevons observed in 1865 that as steam engines became more efficient, coal consumption did not fall but rose. The reason is not complicated: efficiency lowers the effective cost of using a resource, and lower cost increases demand. Yet the electricity demanded by digital infrastructure, streaming and artificial intelligence has grown to staggering proportions, the efficiency gain consumed by the appetite it was meant to constrain. The Jevons Paradox is the operating principle of an ego handed a cheaper instrument: it uses more, not less, because the instrument was always in service of an appetite, and an appetite does not self-limit through efficiency.

In 2024, every single energy source on the planet, coal, oil, gas, nuclear, hydro, wind and solar, reached its highest level of consumption in recorded history. Clean energy did not replace dirty energy; it was stacked on top of it, because the demand underneath kept growing and did not care where the electricity came from.

The carbon inequality data is perhaps the most telling fact of all. The richest one per cent of humanity is responsible for sixteen per cent of global emissions, consuming its entire fair annual share of the carbon budget within the first ten days of the year. The people doing the damage are not the people in need; they are the people who already have everything, and in having everything they want more, not less. They are the ordinary human with the external brake removed, revealing an appetite with no internal point of rest.

Then there is the record of more than three decades of climate negotiation, thirty Conferences of the Parties since 1992. When that process began, atmospheric carbon dioxide stood at roughly 356 parts per million; it stands today at above 425 and is still rising. The policy route keeps falling short because the person who drafts the policy in the morning is the same person who finds the workaround in the evening. The voter who demands climate action at the ballot box is the same consumer who demands comfort at the checkout, operating from a centre never examined, whose wanting was never on the table when the policy was written.

None of this is an argument against technology or policy. Solar panels and carbon pricing are necessary; the physics of the crisis demands material responses. But they are structurally insufficient on their own, because they address the symptom while leaving the generator of symptoms entirely in place. Stopping does not require time; it is reaching that requires time, accelerating that requires time.

The question is not what more can be done, but whether the one doing can first be understood. Someone in the Cambridge audience asked at what age the inner education should begin. The answer is simple: from the moment a child is curious enough to ask "What is this?" about the world, the capacity is already present to ask "What am I?" about the asker. The first question has been cultivated across every education system in the world; the second has been almost entirely ignored. This is what I have been trying to address through the education programme I run, in which students work through philosophical texts not because the texts are the point but because they are mirrors, asking the one question every other curriculum omits: Who is the one who knows?

The distinction between willpower and intent is, I think, the heart of the matter. The climate summits have been exercises in willpower: the ego identifying an external enemy and mobilising force against it, while its own wanting remains entirely intact.

Intent is the ego turned against its own grain, the self choosing to examine itself rather than its objects. It does not require a new summit; it requires a mirror, and the willingness to look into it without looking away. I remain grateful to the Cambridge India Business Society, the Judge Business School and Professor Prabhu for the warmth of that afternoon and the seriousness of its questions. That hunger is not unique to Cambridge; it is everywhere a person reaches for the next thing and finds it insufficient.

The crisis is not out there. It has a centre, and the centre is the human being who has never been asked, in any classroom or at any summit, to look at himself with the same rigour he has applied to everything else. The education this planet needs has not yet been seriously attempted. What is being waited for is not a better instrument. It is the willingness to turn the instrument around.



AVINASH NEGI

India's tribal communities have often lived at the margins of public conversation, even though they remain deeply connected to the soul of Indian civilisation. The *Janjati Sanskritik Samagam* held at Delhi's Red Fort on May 24 sought to change that reality. More than a government-sponsored cultural gathering, it became a powerful reminder that tribal identity is not separate from India's national identity - it is one of its oldest and strongest foundations.

For many who arrived in Delhi from remote forests and hilly regions, this was their first visit to the national capital. They did not come merely as beneficiaries of welfare schemes or participants in a cultural programme. They came carrying centuries of memory, tradition, and resilience. As tribal songs echoed through the Red Fort and traditional drums filled the air, the event created a rare moment where the country's political center connected with its civilizational roots.

At the heart of the *Samagam* was the legacy of Bhagwan Birsa Munda, lovingly remembered as "*Dharti Aaba*"—the Father of the Earth. His 150th birth anniversary has become a rallying point for a wider tribal awakening across the country. Birsa

Munda was not simply a freedom fighter who challenged British rule. He stood for something much deeper - the right of tribal communities to protect their land, culture, faith, and way of life.

When Birsa Munda called for "our rule" instead of the "Queen's rule," he was speaking about dignity and selfhood. He believed tribal society should not lose its identity to outside forces. That message continues to resonate strongly today.

The larger ideological vision behind the *Samagam* also reflects a long-held belief associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh- that tribal communities are not outside the Indian mainstream, but are an inseparable part of Bharat's cultural family. The phrase heard repeatedly during the event, "*Tu-Main Ek Rakt*" (You and I are one blood), captured this sentiment beautifully. It sought to reduce the emotional distance between the tribal citizen, the villager, and the urban Indian.

For decades, tribal communities have often been viewed only through the language of poverty, welfare, or backwardness. The *Samagam* tried to replace that gaze with one of respect and belonging. It reminded urban India that tribal traditions are not relics of the past, but living knowledge systems rooted in harmony with nature, community life, and spiritual balance.

Yet behind the celebration lies a deep concern



that many tribal leaders openly expressed - the fear of losing their cultural identity through large-scale religious conversions and outside influence. Across several tribal regions, there is growing unease that missionary-driven conversions are slowly weakening traditional customs, local belief systems, and community bonds that have survived for generations.

It is this concern that has brought the issue of "de-listing" converted Scheduled Tribes into sharp national focus. Organizations such as the Janjatiya Suraksha Manch have been particularly vocal in arguing that constitutional benefits meant for Scheduled Tribes should remain with those who continue to preserve tribal customs, traditions, and social practices. Their argument is that reservations and constitutional protections were originally designed to safeguard vulnerable indigenous communities and

their unique identities, not to encourage religious and cultural disconnection from those roots.

Supporters of de-listing believe that if large-scale conversions continue unchecked while constitutional benefits remain unchanged, tribal identity itself may weaken over time. They argue that preserving tribal civilisation requires legal and constitutional safeguards that protect original traditions and discourage cultural fragmentation. Alongside cultural preservation is the equally important question of self-governance. Tribal communities continue to demand stronger implementation of the PESA Act in Fifth Schedule areas so that local people retain control over land, forests, and village institutions. For them, real empowerment is not just about roads, subsidies, or welfare announcements. It is about having the right to protect their traditions and make decisions about their own future.

At the same time, there is also a visible shift in the tribal landscape. Increasingly, tribal communities are moving from dependence to entrepreneurship. Government initiatives such as PM-JANMAN and the *Dharti Aaba Janjati Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan* aim to combine economic development with cultural confidence.

Traditional tribal products- textiles, forest produce, herbal knowledge, handicrafts- are now finding larger markets. Platforms such as *Aadi Mahotsav* are helping tribal artisans connect directly with buyers while preserving the authenticity of their work. This is important because economic growth becomes far more meaningful when it strengthens identity instead of erasing it. Another encouraging step is the effort to bring tribal heroes and histories into the national mainstream. For too long, the sacrifices of tribal freedom fighters remained absent from schoolbooks and public memory. Museums dedicated to tribal resistance movements are helping correct that silence and giving younger generations role models rooted in their own history.

The Janjati Sanskritik Samagam ultimately represented more than a cultural event. It reflected a growing national recognition that tribal communities are not passive recipients of development, but equal partners in shaping India's future.

The real success of such efforts, however, will depend on whether cultural pride is matched by long-term respect for tribal identity, traditions, and self-governance. India's tribal communities do not seek charity; they seek recognition, dignity, and the freedom to preserve the civilizational heritage they have protected for centuries.

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Order Order

Himachal ex-deputy advocate general booked for defamation

Shimla Police on Friday registered a defamation case against former Himachal deputy advocate general, Vinay Sharma, following a complaint by former state chief secretary Sanjay Gupta. On May 30, Gupta lodged a police complaint, accusing Sharma of making false allegations of corruption, abuse of office, benami property holdings, illegal use of funds and administrative interference, and described the claims as malicious and intended to damage his reputation.

After the complaint, an FIR was filed against Sharma under BNS sections 248 (fabricated or baseless criminal charges with the explicit intent to injure or harass someone), 351 (Criminal Intimidation) and 356(2) (criminal defamation), police said on Friday.

Gupta, who retired as chief secretary on May 31 and took charge as Chairperson of the Punjab State Electricity Regulatory Commission (PSERC) on June 3, 2026, had in his complaint filed at Chhota Shimla Police Station said Sharma's complaint on March 24, 2026, was not supported by facts, legal provisions or documentary evidence. He alleged that the purpose of the complaint was not only to tarnish his personal image but also to undermine the dignity of the state's highest administrative office. Pointing out irregularities in the Chester Hill project in Solan district, Sharma had raised questions regarding a land transaction and alleged misuse of official position. (PTI)



Calcutta HC orders Bengal Govt report on PILs

The Calcutta High Court on Friday directed the West Bengal Government to file a report on the alleged parading of some arrested persons, accused of being involved in extortion, with ropes tied to their waist. A division bench presided by Justice Jay Sengupta said that the police should act within the law and no accused should be subjected to humiliation.

PILs alleged that the police were at various places in West Bengal parading persons, arrested on various charges, including extortion and intimidation. The vacation bench directed the state Government to file a report on the allegations within three weeks. The court directed that the PILs will come up for hearing again after four weeks. (PTI)



Delhi court acquits two men in murder case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A court has acquitted two persons in a 2022 murder case, saying the prosecution had failed to establish their identity as the assailants despite proving that the victim died due to injuries inflicted during an assault.

Special Judge Puneet Pahwa was hearing the case against Naushad and Kamruddin, who were accused of assaulting Javed, allegedly leading to his death.

In an order dated June 2, the court said, "This court has no hesitation in holding that both accused persons, namely, Naushad and Kamruddin, are entitled for benefit of doubt and thus, they stand acquitted for the charged offences."

According to the prosecution, Javed was assaulted in northeast Delhi's Shastri Park on May 31, 2022, and was declared dead when taken to a hospital.

A post-mortem later revealed that he died due to haemorrhagic shock caused by an abdominal injury from blunt force impact. The prosecution alleged that Naushad and Kamruddin had beaten Javed with a wooden stick and their fists, leading to his death.

Kerala HC dismisses CMRL appeal against ED money laundering probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court on Friday dismissed an appeal filed by CMRL against a single-judge verdict allowing the ED to continue its money laundering probe into the mining company's financial dealings with Veena T, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.

A Division Bench comprising Justice Raja Vijayaraghavan and Justice K V Jayakumar upheld the single-judge order of May 26 saying it finds no reason to interfere with that judgement. The High Court also declined the request by the lawyer for Cochin Minerals



and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) to protect it for two weeks so that it can move an appeal before the Supreme Court.

While dismissing the company's appeal, the bench said, "Non-registration of an FIR or non-filing of a complaint in respect of scheduled offence will not

bar the ED from initiating civilisation under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). Registration of a scheduled offence is a pre-requisite only for a penal prosecution and not for civil action or for exercise of inquiry powers under the Act."

The court also rejected the company's plea to quash the Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) registered by the Enforcement Directorate (ED). The bench said that the ECIR was not a statutory document and since its non-registration does not impede the commencement of civil action, the prayer to quash the same cannot be granted in the case.

SC refuses to entertain plea to fill vacant posts in SHRC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain a petition seeking a direction for expeditious filling up of vacant posts of chairperson and members of some State Human Rights Commissions (SHRC).

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and V Mohana asked the petitioner as to why he has not approached the high court concerned.

After the bench showed its disinclination in entertaining the plea, the counsel appearing for the petitioner urged that he be allowed to withdraw the petition.

The bench permitted him to withdraw the plea with a

liberty to avail remedy as available in law.

During the hearing, the petitioner's counsel referred to the vacancies in the state human rights commissions and said that Uttar Pradesh Human Rights Commission does not have a chairperson for the last two years.

He said notice was earlier issued by the top court in a similar matter. The bench asked why the petitioner has filed a separate petition.

The counsel said the earlier petition was regarding filling up of vacancies in the National Human Rights Commission, while the petition filed now relates to vacancies in the state human rights commissions. "Why have you not gone to



the high court? The high courts have been monitoring all this," the bench said.

The petitioner's counsel

said the plea relates to multiple States and the Uttar Pradesh Human Rights Commission will become



AI now operational reality, not speculative: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Artificial intelligence is no longer a speculative technology but an operational reality and poses one of the most significant tests for international law, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant has said, underlining that choices made during this decade will shape the future relationship between technology, power, freedom and justice.

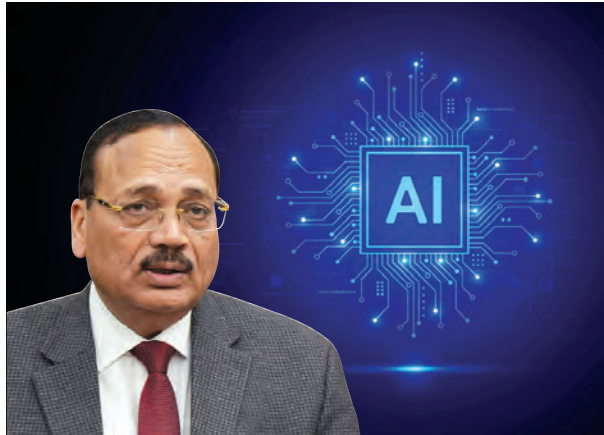
He also stressed that technology itself is neither inherently benevolent nor inherently harmful.

Speaking at a public lecture in Birkbeck College of University of London on "Artificial Intelligence and International Law", the CJI

said unlike previous technological revolutions, AI does not merely enhance human capacity, it increasingly participates in decision-making processes that were historically considered uniquely human.

"Technology itself is neither inherently benevolent nor inherently harmful. Its impact depends upon the legal, political and ethical frameworks within which societies choose to deploy it.

The responsibility of law, therefore, is neither to resist technological progress nor to surrender unquestioningly before it. Its responsibility is to ensure that technological power remains accountable to constitutional values, democratic legitimacy and human dignity," he said.



Justice Kant said AI is now an operational reality that is reshaping governance, commerce, warfare, communication, public administration, and increasingly, the exercise of judicial and sov-

ereign power itself.

"Governments now utilise algorithmic systems to allocate welfare benefits, assess immigration applications, monitor borders, regulate financial systems and support

policing functions. Militaries are rapidly developing autonomous capabilities. Courts across jurisdictions are beginning to confront questions involving AI-generated evidence, automated decision-making and digital due process. Private corporations possess technological capacities that rival, and in some instances exceed, the informational reach of sovereign states," he said.

The organisers of the event did not allow questions on alleged hostilities towards dissent in India and asked the participants to stick to the topic of AI.

One of the visitors wanted to put questions to the CJI on India's track record on protecting democracy in the age of AI. She also raised concerns

on so-called hostilities towards dissent in India.

The CJI said AI poses one of the most significant tests for international law in its modern evolution and asserted that the choices made during this decade will shape the relationship between technology, power, freedom and justice for generations to come.

"The central challenge before us is to ensure that, in an age of intelligent machines, humanity retains authorship of the principles by which it is governed. If international law can rise to that challenge, artificial intelligence may become not merely a technological revolution, but an opportunity to reaffirm the values that lie at the foundation of democratic civilisation itself," he underscored.

HC vacates stay on Delhi riots charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday lifted its earlier stay on framing of charges in the alleged larger conspiracy case related to the 2020 riots and allowed the trial court to pass a final order.

Justice Neena Bansal Krishna vacated the court's order while dismissing a plea by accused Devangana Kalita seeking direction to the police to provide her certain videos and WhatsApp chats in relation to the case.

After the pronouncement of the verdict, Kalita's counsel urged the judge to continue the operation of the stay order for the time being, stating that she would approach the Supreme Court with her grievance.

"I won't be able to do that," Justice Krishna responded.



The court, however, allowed a separate petition by Kalita and permitted her to inspect the unrelayed-upon documents in the case under the anti-terror law UAPA.

Kalita had moved the high court in 2023, claiming that Delhi Police had commissioned certain persons to record the protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and National Register of Citizens (NRC) in February 2020 and the

footage should be supplied to her before the trial court proceeds to hear the arguments on the framing of charges.

She had contended that the footage would show that she was protesting peacefully. Besides the video footage, she had also sought the "entire WhatsApp chat" of a group, alleging that "selective extracts" were being used against the petitioner.

In the judgment, the court stated that all the evidence

against Kalita, which is being relied upon by the prosecution, along with the chargesheet, has already been provided to her in compliance with the law, and the entire footage of the riots relevant to the petitioner has also been given.

The court said that only such communication, information, chats of police official groups and WhatsApp groups, which are neither relied upon nor relevant, have not been shared as they may contain sensitive information or privileged communication that cannot be disclosed. "Hence, the WhatsApp Group chats etc pertaining to the police officials and their activities which had not been relied upon were held to be not required to be supplied under Section 207 CrPC," the court held.

NIA court frames charges against 26 in PFI case, calls it juristic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Friday ordered framing charges against several top leaders of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) outfit, observing that there is "grave suspicion" of a conspiracy to overthrow the Indian Government and establish an Islamic caliphate by 2047.

Additional Sessions Judge Prashant Sharma ordered framing charges under the Indian Penal Code and Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act against 25 PFI members as well as the organisation. "Considered as a whole, the material on record raises grave suspicion that the accused, acting through and on behalf of the Popular Front of India and



its National Executive Council, agreed and acted in furtherance of a single conspiracy — to overthrow the secular democratic Government of India and establish an Islamic caliphate under Sharia law in India by or before the year 2047 through an armed struggle against the State," the judge said.

Each accused's role, on the material at face value, fits into one or more limbs of the conspiracy, he added.

Manisha circulated leaked NEET question papers: CBI tells Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Friday informed a Delhi court that Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, an accused in the NEET paper leak case, circulated question papers to students for monetary consideration. The agency made the submissions before Special Judge Ajay Gupta, who was hearing Waghmare's bail plea.

The judge reserved the order on the plea for June 9.

After the CBI opposed the bail application, the judge asked the prosecutor appearing for the agency



whether she allegedly provided the leaked question papers to students in lieu of money.

"She gave students questions from physics, chemistry, and biology papers ... We have statements from students that they paid money in exchange for the leaked papers ... Waghmare circulated the question papers," the prosecutor said.

The accused's counsel, however, sought bail, saying his 47-year-old client was a certified education counsellor who did not indulge in any illegal activity. The lawyer contended that no cash was recovered from her premises, neither was anything incriminating found stored

in her two seized mobile phones, and that she suffered from medical ailments, such as vertigo.

Waghmare was arrested on May 14 and is in judicial custody. According to the agency, Waghmare, who runs a beauty parlour in Pune, collected the questions from alleged kingpin P V Kulkarni and gave them to another accused, Dhananjay Lokhande, who was arrested from Ahilyanagar, and also to other accused persons.

The CBI alleged that kingpin Kulkarni ran special coaching classes for students at his house in Pune and mobilised students with Waghmare's help.

SC issues contempt notice to AIIMS acting director

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking strong exception to the non-filing of an affidavit in a matrimonial case, the Supreme Court has issued a contempt notice to the acting director of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) and sought an explanation from him on the issue.

A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan said the AIIMS director was impleaded in the case on April 16 and directed to submit an explanation by filing an affidavit.

The court said an affidavit has been filed and the most "objectionable" part of it is that one Nishant Kumar, who claims to be the deputy secretary in AIIMS-New Delhi,



was authorised to file the document. "We pause here to indicate that we had specifically sought explanation to be furnished by Director, AIIMS, and it is not within the discretion of any person to submit his/her explanation by authorising someone else to do the same," the bench said.

The apex court was informed that there is no

permanent director in AIIMS-New Delhi as of now. "On a further query, as to why the person currently holding the charge of director has not filed the explanation, the answer is that he is only in temporary capacity," the court said, adding that it is not only "surprised but shocked" at the response.

"Any person who is on a post, either in substantive

capacity or in acting capacity, has to take responsibility and perform the duty of the post held by him/her in whatever capacity it may be.

We will not give benefit of doubt to the present Director/Acting Director of any ignorance," the bench said. "Accordingly, in the court's tentative view, the present Acting Director, AIIMS, New Delhi, has committed contempt. Accordingly, Dr Nikhil Tandon, Acting Director, AIIMS, is impleaded as party respondent no.4. Notice in contempt is issued against him.

Cause title be amended accordingly. He shall be personally present along with his explanation on the next date of listing, i.e., July 7, 2026 at 12 noon, treating it as part-heard," the bench said.

Man sentenced to death for Jalgaon rape, murders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

A special court in Maharashtra's Jalgaon district has sentenced a 19-year-old man to death for raping a 13-year-old girl and murdering her as well as her three minor siblings, observing the crime was "premeditated and exceptionally cruel".

Special POCSCO Court Judge S R Yadav said the case fell in the "rarest of rare" category and had shocked the judicial and societal conscience. The act of 19-year-old Sitaram Barela was "unpardonable and it warrants the death penalty," the court asserted. "The accused has wiped out four



minor children in a premeditated and cold-blooded, exceptionally cruel and diabolic manner. One of them raped by him," the special judge said.

Noting that sexual offences against minors are increasing day by day rapidly, the court highlighted that minors are being killed for "sexual lust of the youthful generation" and, hence, the judicial fraternity owes a duty to punish such people in a harsh voice.

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MG Motor India installs 1,000 EV chargers at over 470 sites

JSW MG Motor India on Friday said it has installed 1,000 community chargers under the 'MG Charge initiative' at more than 470 sites across the country, making it the first original equipment maker to build electric vehicle community charging infrastructure at this scale. The installations span residential societies, condominiums, hospitals, campuses, hotels and industrial parks, the company said. It views India's sustainability journey as one that can be driven by multiple technologies, the company added. The carmaker also said it is preparing an aggressive product lineup for the current calendar year, with three new energy vehicles (NEVs) slated for launch, including the introduction of plug-in hybrid technology. JSW MG Motor India utilises more than 78 per cent renewable energy at its manufacturing plant in Halol, Gujarat, in line with the central government's vision, it said. The plant meets nearly 95 per cent of its total power requirements through renewable energy sources, the company said.

Rupee rises 81 paise to close at 94.93 against US dollar

The rupee appreciated 81 paise to close at 94.93 (provisional) against the US dollar on Friday after the Reserve Bank announced measures to support foreign capital inflows and strengthen forex liquidity. Forex traders said the announcements in RBI policy boosted investor sentiments after apex bank asserted that the country's forex reserves provide a sufficient buffer against external shocks. The RBI expectedly kept interest rates unchanged for the second time in a row as it weighed the impact of rising energy prices and supply disruptions caused by the West Asia crisis. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.72, then touched an intraday high of 94.89 and finally ended the session at 94.93 (provisional), registering a rise of 81 paise from its previous close. On Thursday, rupee rose 2 paise to settle at 95.74 against the US dollar. Announcing second bi-monthly monetary policy for current fiscal, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has unanimously decided to retain short-term lending rate or repo rate at 5.25 per cent with a neutral stance. By holding the repo rate at 5.25 per cent with a neutral stance even while raising the FY27 inflation forecast by 50 basis points to 5.1 per cent, the RBI has drawn a clean line.

Tata Motors' expansion to go on, Iveco acquisition to help it rank among top 4 global CV makers: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Tata Motors Ltd will expand globally, gain leadership in emerging segments while sustaining top position where it is strong in the next five years, with the Iveco acquisition set to help it rank among the top four commercial vehicle makers in the world, according to its Chairman N Chandrasekaran. The company is expected to strengthen its leadership across segments of commercial vehicles driven by strong volume growth in the next three to four years, Chandrasekaran said in his address at the Tata Motors commercial vehicles dealer business planning meet 2026 in Goa, according to people aware of the development. Noting that the Tata Group's "automotive business today is both large and globally competitive", he said presently the automotive vertical alone is poised to clock revenues of \$80 billion, as compared to the group's total revenues of \$100 billion in 2017. Chandrasekaran, who is also the Chairman of Tata

Sons — the promoter holding firm of the Tata conglomerate, further said, "Our aspiration is clear — to build a truly global, high-impact commercial vehicles company." The next five years are about "sustaining leadership where we are strong and gaining leadership in emerging segments", Chandrasekaran said. He also told the dealer partners that in the next five years, Tata Motors will continue to expand globally, while also deepening innovation and technology leadership. Noting that Tata Motors' global ambition has taken a major step forward with the bid for Iveco acquisition, the regulatory approvals are currently underway and are

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | JUNE 6, 2026

India can return to 7% GDP in FY28 on macro stability: CEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Macro stability and supply measures can bring back India on a 7 per cent growth trajectory in FY28, Chief Economic Adviser V Anantha Nageswaran said on Friday, asserting that the growth is contingent on improvement in external conditions. The Reserve Bank on Friday lowered its GDP forecast for FY27 to 6.6 per cent from the 6.9 per cent estimated in April, citing elevated energy and other commodity prices, as well as continued supply disruptions arising from the conflict in West Asia, which are likely to weigh on economic activity. "We have no reason to second-guess them (Reserve Bank of India forecast) at this point, because there are both possibilities on the upside and on the downside with respect to the numbers that they have presented," he said

here. "So, even if the growth were to slip below 7 per cent as the RBI forecast suggests...macro stability measures and supply assurances will bring us back to a 7 per cent plus growth track in FY28 or as soon as external conditions improve," he said. He further said it is a hope based on the assumption that the pre-February 28 condition is restored before FY28. "Now, if these conditions continue, then we will revisit the estimate for the next financial year," he added. Talking about nominal GDP, he said, it is a fair estimate that it will overshoot the 10.1 per cent estimated in the Budget 2027, given the upward momentum of retail inflation. "The good news is that the nominal GDP growth will be significantly higher than the number which the budget estimates used, which is 10.1 per cent for the current financial year," he said.

India GDP Growth

At 2022-23 prices, in per cent

2023-24	7.2
2024-25	7.1
2025-26	7.7

Quarter-wise Trend

7.5	6.6	7.4	7.0	6.8	8.3	8.0	7.8
Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
— 2024-25 —				— 2025-26 —			

2024-25: 1st Revised Estimates; 2025-26: Provisional Estimates

KBK

Weak monsoon may impact rural demand: RBI Governor

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Friday said a projected deficiency in the south-west monsoon could impact rural demand and private consumption, though mitigation measures are expected to cushion the effect. During the post-monetary policy conference, Malhotra said rural demand and private consumption have remained healthy so far but acknowledged that some moderation may be inevitable. "Rural demand, yes; private consumption, yes. Some impact will be there," the governor said while replying to a specific question on the issue. Malhotra said the projected deficiency in the south-west monsoon may have implications for agricultural production and demand in rural areas.

"Additionally, the projected deficiency in the south-west monsoon will have implications for agricultural production and rural demand. However, programmes and initiatives for crop diversification, water harvesting and conservation, climate-resilient practices and short-duration crops, among others, are expected to mitigate the impact," he said. The governor also pointed to broader risks from rising input costs and supply disruptions, which could weigh on economic activity and consumption if pressures persist. "Going ahead, the rise in prices of energy and other inputs, coupled with supply disruptions, is likely to weigh on economic activity," he said, adding that the overall

impact would depend on the duration of the conflict and the pace of supply-chain normalisation. Further, the central bank said the rise in prices of energy and other inputs, coupled with supply disruptions, is likely to weigh on economic activity going ahead. While import diversification in affected commodities is likely to improve supply, it would come at a higher cost. "The full impact, however, will depend on the duration of the conflict, the time taken for normalisation of supply chains and the burden-sharing approach among the stakeholders," Malhotra said. Meanwhile, the central bank lowered the GDP growth forecast by 0.30 per cent for FY27 to 6.6 per cent, from 6.9 per cent earlier, due to heightened uncertainty over the West Asia crisis and downside risk.

'Polymer currency notes proposal under consideration'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Friday said a proposal to introduce polymer currency notes is under consideration of the central bank, and the idea is currently at a preliminary stage. Malhotra said no decision has been taken in the matter as yet, and the apex bank is examining the feasibility of such a move. "As far as polymer notes are concerned, the proposal is under consideration. As soon as any decision is taken on it, we will inform you," Malhotra said during the post-monetary policy press conference here. The governor said media reports on the issue carry some truth, but clarified

that the central bank has not taken any decision and the proposal remains at a preliminary stage. "We are examining the pros and cons of it and whether it would be worthwhile to implement. It is still at a preliminary stage," Malhotra said.

India to surpass China in share of global GDP by 2060: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India is expected to surpass China in terms of its share of global GDP measured in purchasing power parity (PPP) by 2060, as Beijing's contribution is likely to decline in the second half of the 21st century, according to a report by researchers associated with World Inequality Lab. World Inequality Lab (WIL) is a research laboratory based at the Paris School of Economics (PSE) and focused on the study of inequality worldwide. The report, titled Global Justice Report: A Plan for Equality and Prosperity With Planetary Boundaries, said that regarding China, it is worth emphasising that its share in world GDP is currently about 20 per cent in PPP terms (about one third higher than the US) and is scheduled to be twice as large as the US by 2035 according to our benchmark projections. "However, China's population share is falling very fast, from 23 per cent of the world population in 1945 to about 17 per cent in 2025 and less than 8 per cent in 2100.

"As a consequence, the share of China in world GDP is projected to stabilise and decline in the second half of the 21st century, and to be overtaken by India around 2060," it said. In any case, the report said, China is very unlikely to ever reach the kind of hegemonic position which the US had in the world around 1950 (with as much as 35-40 per cent of the world's GDP) or which Europe had around 1900-1910 (around 40-45 per cent). In brief, it said the world is set to be multipolar in the 21st century, unlike the worlds of the 19th and 20th centuries. The report pointed out that it is also striking that India has much more inequality than China, but much lower productivity

Stock markets end slightly lower after post-RBI policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Friday amid profit-taking after the RBI lowered its growth expectations for the current fiscal year and forecast inflation to rise to 5.1 per cent. Also adding to the bearish trend in equities were foreign fund outflows, geopolitical uncertainties and a weak trend in Asian markets. The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 116.67 points, or 0.16 per cent, to settle at 74,243.34. During the day, it hit a high of 74,717.57 and a low of 73,988.75, gyrating 728.82 points. A total of 2,138 stocks declined, while 2,056 advanced and 205 remained unchanged on the BSE. The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 49.85 points, or 0.21

per cent, to end at 23,366.70. On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark declined 532.4 points, or 0.71 per cent, and the Nifty dipped 181.05 points, or 0.76 per cent. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday kept its benchmark repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent and announced a raft of measures to attract foreign capital and support the rupee amid growing risks to growth and inflation from the prolonged West Asia conflict, elevated energy prices and global supply-chain disruptions.

NSE NIFTY

Intra-day on June 5, 2026

Open: 23,478.95

High: 23,516.35

Previous close: 23,416.55

Low: 23,282.65

Close: 23,366.70

BSE SENSEX

Intra-day on June 5, 2026

Open: 74,629.94

High: 74,717.57

Previous close: 74,360.01

Low: 73,988.75

Close: 74,243.34

KBK InfoGraphics

Paying beyond disclosed rates to attract deposits not acceptable: Governor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Friday said payment of a higher interest rate than the one already disclosed is "not acceptable" to the central Bank. He, however, declined to comment specifically on a matter involving HDFC Bank, where the largest private sector lender is alleged to have paid an extra sum to garner a big deposit and showed it as a marketing spend. HDFC Bank has denied the allegation, while there have been reports suggesting that many banks resort to such means to garner deposits. Addressing the customary post-policy review press conference, Malhotra said the RBI

permits differential pricing of deposits, whereby senior citizens may get higher interest rates and the tenor of a deposit may also influence the rate a bank offers. "They (banks) have to display it. Any differential rate beyond that if someone is giving is certainly not acceptable," Malhotra said. He said competition among banks for garnering deposits is good, but asked the lenders to be "transparent" as they go about mobilising the deposits. Meanwhile, replying to a question on upper layer NBFCs, Malhotra said this RBI will shortly come up with updated list. The list which is already out will continue to be the operational one till new one is put out, Malhotra said.

'Stable home loan interest rate to sustain housing demand'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Real estate industry bodies CREDAI and NAREDCO on Friday hailed the RBI's decision to keep repo rate unchanged despite inflationary concern, saying a stable interest rate regime would help sustain housing demand. On Friday, The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) kept its benchmark repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent, and announced a raft of measures to attract foreign capital and support the rupee. CREDAI President Shekhar G Patel said the RBI policy indicates a calibrated response amidst the current global economic environment, while NAREDCO President Parveen Jain described it as a positive development for both the economy and the real estate sector.

CHINA

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi on Friday held talks with his Myanmar counterpart Tin Maung Swe in Beijing, days after Myanmar President Min Aung Hlaing visited India on his first tour abroad after his election, garnering global headlines. Wang and Tin discussed scaling up bilateral ties and accelerating the development of Myanmar, which for long was caught in civil war between the military junta that ruled the country for decades and ethnic armies. China has deepened its influence in Myanmar, backing the military rulers with major strategic investments. Min's visit to Delhi was watched with interest in Beijing as it was the first major trip by a Myanmar leader to India and also his first visit abroad, less than two months after he became president following parliamentary elections. In his talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Min assured that his country's territory will not be allowed to be used against New Delhi's security interests.

Russia is "ready and willing" to reach an agreement with Ukraine based on US President Donald Trump's peace proposal if Kyiv was ready to make certain "compromises". President Vladimir Putin has said even as he asserted that Russian forces are dominating the battlefield.

In an interaction with heads of leading global news agencies, including *PTI* on Thursday night, the Russian President said Moscow is strengthening its air defences to counter Ukrainian drone strikes, asserting that there is "patriotism and will of the Russian people" will ensure they achieve their goals in Ukraine. In a related development,

Israel's air force struck different parts of southern Lebanon on Friday as the military issued evacuation warnings for nine villages, including one that has been spared much of the destruction and was sheltering thousands of people displaced by the three-month war.

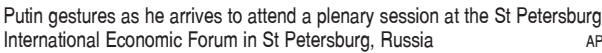
Six people were killed, Lebanon's state news agency reported. The warnings forced hundreds of families to flee the village of Anqoun and the area of Aarnaya, on the edge of the predominantly Christian village of

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, in an open letter to Putin, called for a face-to-face meeting between himself and the Russian president to end the war peacefully.

Zelenskyy pitched for a full ceasefire to hold negotiations between the two sides arguing that peace could only come through direct engagement between Ukraine and Russia.

The Kremlin said it received the letter. "Ukraine proposes ending this war through direct engagement between us - and you. I am proposing a meeting," the Ukrainian president wrote.

In the press interaction where PTI was the only Indian media outlet, Putin insisted



that Ukraine will have to make compromises and specifically referred to the summit meeting he had with President Trump in Alaska's Anchorage in August last year. "Without doubt, we are ready and willing to reach an agreement with Ukraine by peaceful means — and based on what we have discussed at the meeting with President

Trump in Anchorage,” Putin said. “At that meeting, certain questions were put before Russia so that we could agree on certain compromises. Russia agrees to the compromises discussed in Anchorage. It is necessary that Ukraine also agrees to make them. Then, the conflict will be resolved naturally and quickly,” he said without elaborating. Putin said Russian military has brought approximately 2,440 square kilometres of territory under its control recently by pushing Ukrainian forces and that there is not a single place in the battlefield where Russian troops are not advancing.

“The offensive is ongoing on a daily basis. At present, the Russian Federation has

letter proposing the meeting as "boorish." "Is it a way to create conditions for personal meetings and talks, or create an environment which makes any personal meetings impossible?" he said. "I think it's the second. He said that he sees 'no point' in the meeting.

taken full control of the Luhansk People's Republic. Russia has brought over 85 per cent of the territory of the Donetsk People's Republic under its control. We also control 80 percent of the Zaporozhye Region. This process continues on a daily basis," he said. "Naturally, under these circumstances,

the Ukrainian side would like us to halt the advance. But rather than stopping that, it would be better to bring the war to an end altogether by agreeing to the compromises that were discussed in Anchorage," he said.

"Russian troops are advancing along the entire line of contact," he said. (PT)

The strikes came a day after the Hezbollah militant group rejected the

latest ceasefire agreement between Israel and the Lebanese Government, and demanded a complete Israeli withdrawal from

Lebanon. Lebanon's Parliament Speaker Nabih Berri, a strong ally of Hezbollah who has been acting as a mediator on behalf of the group, said in his first comment on the agreement reached in Washington this week that he accepts Hezbollah's withdrawal from the areas south of the Litani River as long as it coincides with the withdrawal of Israeli troops from southern Lebanon.

The river, located about 30 kilometres north of the border with Israel, forms the boundary of a 2006 UN-established buffer zone in which Hezbollah is banned. Israeli troops have currently pushed far past the Litani River into southern Lebanon.

Berri added in a statement that the ceasefire should be "complete and comprehensive" without any restrictions or conditions on land, at sea and in the air, and "without bulldozing and demolishing everything that exists." He was referring to wide areas that have been demolished by Israeli troops.



Russian President Vladimir Putin has offered New Delhi Russia's fifth-generation stealth aircraft Sukhoi Su-57 and even suggested that the combat jet could even be jointly produced in India in line with the strong strategic

For decades, Russia has served as India's primary defence supplier. However, persistent supply chain disruptions and delivery delays stemming from the war in Ukraine have forced New Delhi to aggressively diversify its military procurement strategy.

ambitious Advance
Multicoe Combat Aircraft
(AMCA) project, widely
regarded as the nation's
largest indigenous aerospace
programme. In an interaction
with heads of leading global
news agencies, including *K*
on Thursday night, Putin
delving into various aspects
of India-Russia defence and
military ties, said Moscow
still keen to involve New
Delhi in the Su-57 aircraft
programme. (PTI)

This Is To Inform We Crown Traders Limited, Having Registered Office At 2888, 2nd Floor, Hauz Quazi, Lal-Qua Bazaar, Sikri Wala, Hauz Qazi, North Delhi, Delhi-110006. We Owner Of 500 Shares Of The Grasim Industries Limited. Company Share's Which We Have Lost Original Share Certificate While Coming Back To Home In Auto-Rickshaw On Date: 15-10-2016. The Total Of 500 Missing Share Certificate Were Mentioned In The Below Table. Those Documents Were Not Found Even After Searching In Many Place. If Any One Finds The Original Documents In The List Below, Please Contact Crown Traders Limited.

Government of India
Ministry of Home Affairs
Department of Official Language

NOTICE

The Department of Official Language, Ministry of Home Affairs circulates list of books in Hindi language marked by qualitative excellence, with recommendation for their purchase by Libraries of the Central Government Ministries/ Departments/Organizations etc. Accordingly, list of books of a range of subjects published in Hindi during the period from 01.01.2025 to 31.12.2025 and meeting the parameters of excellence is to be circulated by this Department. Books are invited from writers, publishers, printers, distributors and NRIs/persons of Indian origin for the above-said purpose.

Complete details in this regard are available at the department's website www.rajbhasha.gov.in.

The last date for submission of books is **15.06.2026**.

Joint Director (Patrika)
Telephone: 23438159

CBC 19201/11/0002/2627

This Is To Inform We Crown Traders Limited, Having Registered Office At 2888, 2nd Floor, Hauz Quazi, Lal-Qua Bazaar, Sikri Wala, Hauz Qazi, North Delhi, Delhi-110006. We Owner Of 8000 Shares Of The SRF Limited. Company Share's Which We Have Lost Original Share Certificate While Coming Back To Home In Auto-Rickshaw On Date: 15-10-2016. The Total Of 8000 Missing Share Certificate Were Mentioned In The Below Table. Those Documents Were Not Found Even After Searching In Many Place, If Any One Finds The Original Documents In The List Below, Please Contact Crown Traders Limited.

Company Name : SRF Limited			
Folio No.	Certificate	Distinctive No.	No. of shares
SRF0113260	559052	25872204-25872253	50
SRF0113260	559053	25872254-25872303	50
SRF0113260	559054	25872304-25872353	50
SRF0113260	559055	25872354-25872403	50
SRF0113260	559056	25872404-25872453	50
SRF0113260	559057	25872454-25872503	50
SRF0113260	90137824	6618608-6618657	50
SRF0113260	90137825	6618658-6618707	50
SRF0113260	90137826	6618708-6618757	50
SRF0113260	90137827	6618758-6618807	50
SRF0113260	90137828	6618808-6618857	50
SRF0113260	90137829	6618858-6618907	50
SRF0113260	90137830	6618908-6618957	50
SRF0113260	90137831	6618958-6619007	50
SRF0113260	90137832	6619008-6619057	50
SRF0113260	90137833	6619058-6619107	50
SRF0113260	90137834	6619108-6619157	50
SRF0113260	90137835	6619158-6619207	50
SRF0113260	90137836	6619208-6619257	50
SRF0113260	90137837	6619258-6619307	50
SRF0113260	90137838	6619308-6619357	50
SRF0113260	99725	4215792-4215841	50
SRF0113260	90241919	7481098-7481137	40
SRF0113260	90241919	9210510-9210519	10
SRF0113260	410052	17852412-17852461	50
SRF0113260	410053	17852462-17852511	50
SRF0113260	410054	17852512-17852561	50
SRF0113260	410055	17852562-17852611	50
SRF0113260	410056	17852612-17852661	50
SRF0113260	410057	17852662-17852711	50
SRF0113260	90249778	6209606-6209645	40
SRF0113260	90249778	10096600-10096609	10
SRF0113260	90249918	8945106-8945125	20
SRF0113260	90249918	14434190-14434219	30
SRF0113260	136302	5609468-5609517	50
SRF0113260	1134834	295790002-295796401	6400
		TOTAL	8000

O/o Executive Director (Material Management), Block No. 8, Ground Floor, Shakti Bhavan, Vidyut Nagar, Rampur, Jabalpur 482008 (M.P.).
Phone No. : 0761-2702700, E-Mail : cesnmppgc@rediffmail.com, Website : www.mppgc.mp.gov.in, CIN - U40109MP2001SGC014882

M.P. Power Generating Co Ltd. invites Electronic Tenders from reputed/established Manufacturers/Authorized Dealers/Authorized Distributors/Suppliers/Contractor/Service Provider/Firm for the following items/Works for various Power Stations of MPPGCL:

S No.	Tender ID	Tender Particulars	Estimated Tender Cost (Rs. in Lakh)	EMD (Rs. in Lakh)	Date and Time for Closing of Online Submission	Date and Time for Opening of E-Tender
1.	2026_MPPGC_500779_1	Procurement of High Pressure Cold Drawn Seamless Steel Tubes for various Thermal Power Stations of MPPGCL	850	8.50	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
2.	2026_MPPGC_489773_1	Procurement of Electric Resistance Welded Steel Pipes For Various Thermal Power Stations of MPPGCL for Two Year Rate Contract	Total Estimated Cost For 02 Years : 5535.28 Lakhs. Annualized Estimated Value : Rs. 2767.64 Lakhs	29.49	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
3.	2026_MPPGC_507921_1	Procurement of ERW Steel Tubes for use in PH-I/II, SGTPS, MPPGCL,Birsinghpur	315	3.15	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
4.	2026_MPPGC_489982_1	Supply of Caustic Soda Lye for SSTPP Khandwa, SGTPS-Birsinghpur, ATPS-Chachai and STPS-Sarni of MPPGCL for period of one year.	625.70	6.25	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
5.	2026_MPPGC_489979_1	Supply of CS FLAKES, for ATPS-Chachai, SGTPS-Birsinghpur and SSTPP-Khandwa of MPPGCL for period of one year.	75.65	1.51	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
6.	2026_MPPGC_489978_1	Supply of Hydrated lime for SSTPP Khandwa, SGTPS-Birsinghpur, ATPS-Chachai and STPS-Sarni for period of one year	23.04	0.46	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
7.	2026_MPPGC-505315_1	Manufacture and supply of FR and NFR Grade conveyor Belt for various TPS of MPPGCL.	Total Estimated Cost For 02 Years : 3450 Lakhs Annualized Estimated Value : Rs. 1725 Lakhs	15.50	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
8.	2026_MPPGC-505319_1	Manufacture and supply of Manganese Steel Toothed/Plain Ring Hammers for Coal Handling Plants of various TPS of MPPGCL	125	2.00	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards
9.	2026_MPPGC-509066_1	Manufacture and supply of P.A. Elbow Assy., Guide pipe (Regulating Rod) & P.F. Nozzle with S.S. Tip for PH-I SGTPS, Birsinghpur	92	1.84	29.06.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	01.07.2026 From 15:30 Hrs onwards

This tender is being invited through an e-tendering system. For viewing detailed NIT, downloading tender documents and participating in Electronic Tender, for any clarifications and/or due date extension or corrigendum, please visit the website www.mptenders.gov.in regularly. Any clarifications and/or due date extension or corrigendum shall be issued on the website www.mptenders.gov.in only.

SAVE ELECTRICITY

CHIEF ENGINEER (MM)

Sr No	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADRI	SUPER ENAMELED COPPER WINDING WIRE OF VARIOUS SIZES AND OTHER 1 TENDER	CLOSING DATE 11.06.2026	10.09 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8816016044 xenworkshopdadri@gmail.com
2	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK	REPAIRING DAMAGED LINING PATCH AT VARIOUS RD&E'S OF ASANDA MINOR. + 2 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 09.06.2026	19.95 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9464040970 xensampla@gmail.com
3	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADRI	REQUIREMENT OF JOB/MATERIAL FOR REPAIR OF DP SET OF CAPACITY 02 CS. (FILED MARSHALL MAKE)	CLOSING DATE 10.06.2026	0.92 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01250-220058 xenlwsmec@gmail.com
4	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, JHAJJAR	CONSTRUCTING SUMPWELL AND CROSSING OF PIPE LINE UNDER ROAD AT GODHRI LINK DRAIN	CLOSING DATE 10.06.2026	14.50 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9050805156 xenjwsdnjr@gmail.com
5	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	SUPPLY OF HARDWARE AND ELECTRICAL ITEMS FOR LWS MECH. DIVISION CHARKHI DADRI OF IRRIGATION DEPARTMENT HARYANA.	05.06.2026 18.06.2026	35.32 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0172582542 xenproc@gmail.com
6	PANCHAYATI RAJ ,FARIDABAD	CONSTRUCTION OF DRAINS AND TREATMENT PROCEDURE OF WASTE WATER (GWM) AT VILLAGE BIJOPUR BLOCK BALLABGARH DISTRICT FARIDABAD + 4 WORKS	04.06.2026 11.06.2026	206.64 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467905067 prexeeng.fbd1@gmail.com
7	PANCHAYATI RAJ,FARIDABAD	CONSTRUCTION OF SUB HEALTH CENTRE AT VILLAGE KHERI GUJRAN BLOCK FARIDABAD DISTRICT FARIDABAD SFC	04.06.2026 11.06.2026	51.25 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467905067 prexeeng.fbd1@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ , BHIWANI	CONSTRUCTION OF KHET KHALIHAN RASTA IN VILLAGE KHARAK KHURD UNDER KHET KHALIHAN SADAK YOJNA GP. + 1 WORKS	03.06.2026 08.06.2026	74.96 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0166243927 prexeeng.bhw@hry.nic.in
9	WOMEN & CHILD DEVELOPMENT, HISAR	HIRED VEHICLE FOR THE OFFICE OF DPO AND WCDPOS	04.06.2026 14.06.2026	EMD 80000/-	https://wcdhry.gov.in/	9466150800 pkhsr.wcd@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 45964-I-27-7

US passes \$70bn immigration enforcement bill

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The Senate passed legislation to fund President Donald Trump's immigration enforcement agencies early Friday morning, after weeks of delays and fierce backlash to an unrelated \$1.776 billion settlement fund that threatened to derail the bill.

Senators voted 52-47 for the \$70 billion legislation to fund Immigration and Customs Enforcement and Border Patrol for the next three years, through the end of Trump's term.

The final vote came just before 5 am, after Republicans narrowly defeated multiple attempts by Democrats and Republicans



President Donald Trump speaking in the Oval Office

AP

to add language to the bill that would permanently ban Trump's settlement fund for political allies who believe they have been politically persecuted. Republicans cleared a major hurdle overnight when they defeated an amendment proposed by one of their own

members, Louisiana Senator Bill Cassidy, that would have redirected payments from the settlement to members of law enforcement who were injured in the January 6, 2021 attack on the Capitol.

The amendments were a test of party unity that complicated what should have

been an easy vote for Republicans who wanted to keep the focus on immigration enforcement in an election year. Instead, they spent almost a full day haggling among themselves over whether to block the settlement fund, even after acting Attorney General Todd Blanche had said earlier this week that it would not go forward.

"This would have been done several hours ago if we weren't having to deal with some of the issues around the fund," Senate Majority Leader John Thune, R-SD, said shortly before midnight. Thune himself has criticised the judgement fund, which was part of a settlement that resolves Trump's lawsuit

against the IRS over the leak of his tax returns and has angered many of his GOP colleagues. But he has been pushing GOP senators for weeks to keep the bill focused on the funding for Immigration and Customs Enforcement and Border Patrol, which Democrats have blocked since early this year, and to avoid adding new provisions that could complicate its passage in the House.

Still, a group of Republican senators pushed all day and into the night to block the settlement's payouts through legislation. That effort came after Trump raised new doubts about the settlement's future Wednesday afternoon - just

after the Senate had voted to start debate on the immigration bill - when he told reporters that the settlement is "very important" and said "I don't know" whether it is dead or on hold. "I'd have to ask the lawyers," he said.

The first vote on Thursday morning, a Democratic effort to ban the settlement, was held open for several hours as three senators, including Cassidy, decided whether to support it. The Democratic motion was narrowly defeated when Cassidy eventually voted against it and the two other GOP senators - Jon Husted of Ohio and Dan Sullivan of Alaska, both of whom are up for reelection this year - voted for it.

Pope Leo's visiting Europe's migration hot spots



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Barcelona

Pope Leo XIV is delving into the hotly contested issue of migration by visiting two flashpoints - Spain's Canary Islands in the Atlantic next week, and Italy's Lampedusa island in the Mediterranean in early July. These rocky, remote outposts of Europe have struggled with the arrival of tens of thousands of mostly African migrants through some of the world's deadliest migration routes. Even as

numbers decreased this year, especially in the Canaries, the issue continues to roil politics in these historically Catholic countries. Many Catholics and migrants hope the upcoming papal trips will refocus attention on solidarity and support - and away from divisive political debate that is splitting the right in addition to pitting it against the left. "Stuck in the middle are the migrants," said the Most Rev. Jose Mazuelos, the bishop of Canarias, whose diocese includes several of the islands.

Indian-American couple gives \$5.5M for healthcare

SEEMA HAKHU KACHRU
■ Houston

A prominent Indian-American entrepreneur couple has donated \$5.5 million to expand medical services in the Greater Houston area and its suburb in the US.

The donation by Brij Agarwal and his wife, Sunita Agarwal, will support clinical programmes at St Luke's Health-Sugar Land Hospital and help establish a nearby Primary Care Community Clinic in a city with limited access to primary healthcare. According to hospital officials, the donation is the largest single gift in the hospital's history. In recognition, the hospital's main patient tower and pavilion will be renamed in honour of the Agrawals.

The couple, longtime Sugar Land residents, have combined business



Premises of the St Luke's Health Sugar Land Hospital with a patient tower named in honour of Indian-American couple in Houston, Texas

AP

success with philanthropy focused on healthcare, education and com-

munity development. Brij Agarwal, a native of Chhattisgarh, moved to

Houston in 1979 and earned a degree in mechanical engineering from the University of Houston.

The latest donation adds to the family's longstanding record of philanthropy in the Houston region. The Agrawals have previously contributed \$1 million in 2022 to the University of Houston at Sugar Land to support manufacturing education and research facilities. The varsity has named the building's ground-floor auditorium, the Brij and Sunita Agrawal Auditorium, in the couple's honour.

He credits his experience at the varsity for providing him with the foundation to launch and sustain a successful career as the CEO and President of VKC Group.

Earlier, the family had also contributed to healthcare initiatives at Houston Methodist Sugar Land

Hospital. In an interview with PTI, Sunita Agrawal said the contribution reflects the family's gratitude to a community that played a central role in their personal and professional journey.

"We have been blessed by this community and wanted to give back in a meaningful way," she said, adding that they hope this gift creates a legacy for their children and grandchildren and inspires others to support the communities that helped them succeed.

Community leaders also welcomed the announcement. The Indo-American Chamber of Commerce of Greater Houston (IACCGH) said the Agrawals have long demonstrated leadership through both business achievement and community service. (PTI)

President Xi to travel to North Korea next week

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Beijing

Chinese leader Xi Jinping will travel to North Korea next week, both countries announced on Friday, in what will be his first visit in nearly seven years.

His trip will be the latest in a series of steps by China to reinforce its close ties with its nuclear-armed neighbour, whose leader Kim Jong Un has reached out to Russia in recent years, notably by sending troops and conventional weapons to support its war against Ukraine.

Kim has likewise been cozying up again to China, the North's biggest trade partner and aid provider, in



the past year.

"As North Korea builds closer ties with Russia, China seeks to use Xi's trip to reassert its influence over Pyongyang and safeguard its strategic interests in north-east Asia," said William Yang, an analyst for the

International Crisis Group. Xi will make a state visit from Monday to Tuesday, state media from both nations said in brief dispatches. His last visit was in June 2019. The trip will come just weeks after Xi hosted US President Donald Trump and

Russian President Vladimir Putin in quick succession in Beijing. North Korea's nuclear weapons programme has long been a major concern for the United States, which opposes it. The UN has imposed economic sanctions on North Korea because of its nuclear and missile development.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given for the information of the general public and all persons concerned that Mr. R.K. Yashwant Singh, son of Late Maharaja Himmat Singh Ji, R/o 18/10, Halley Road, New Delhi-110001, Delhi, expired at Jodhpur, Rajasthan on 14th February 2026, leaving behind no spouse and children.
Take Notice that Mr. R.K. Rajendra Singh, S/o Late Maharaja Himmat Singh Ji, R/o Sh. Himmat Singh Bungalow, Residency Road, Jodhpur, Rajasthan, being the real brother of the deceased, has claimed entitlement to succeed to the movable and immovable properties, assets, rights, interests and estate left behind by Late Mr. R.K. Yashwant Singh. Any person(s), institution(s), authority(ies), legal heir(s), claimant(s) or any other party having any claim, right, title, interest, share, lien, charge, objection or demand of whatsoever nature in respect of the estate, properties or assets of Mr. R.K. Yashwant Singh, is hereby called upon to submit the particulars of such claim or objection, together with supporting documentary evidence, to the undersigned within 15 (Fifteen) days from the date of publication of this notice.
In the event no claim or objection is received within the aforesaid period, it shall be presumed that no person other than those already known has any claim, right, title, interest or objection in respect of the estate of Mr. R.K. Yashwant Singh, and appropriate steps shall thereafter be taken on the basis of the records and documents available, without any further reference to any person whomsoever.
Date: 06.06.2026
Veerban Singh Rao
Advocate
Rajasthan High Court, Jodhpur
Residence/Office: 104,
Shiv Shakti Nagar, Nandri,
Banar Road, Jodhpur
Mobile: 9928799200
968772009

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Mr. Kamal Narang alias Kamal Narang had acquired Plot measuring 395 sq. yds., Khara No. 37/13/2, situated in the village Ajrona, near Ajrona Chowk, Tehsil Badkhal and District Faridabad, Haryana, vide Transfer Deed dt. 26.02.2024 executed by Mrs. Kiren Narang w.r.t. said property. Original Sale deed dt. 20.10.2000 executed by Mrs. Veena Gupta and Original Regd. Will dated 05.10.2011 executed by Mr. Harsharan Narang w.r.t. said property is lost. Mr. Kamal Narang alias Kamal Narang is willing to Mortgage the above said property with CFCIL.
OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance whatsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H.No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi 110024

GURU JAMBHESHWAR UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY, HISAR
(Established by State Legislature Act 17 of 1995)
'A+' Grade NAAC Accredited
ADMISSION TO Ph.D. PROGRAMME (2026-27) (SUMMER TERM)
Online applications are invited from eligible candidates through University Web Portal for admission to Ph.D. Programme in various departments of the University for the Summer Term of the session 2026-27 latest by **24-06-2026**. Applicants are required to visit University website **www.gjust.ac.in** w.e.f. **09-06-2026** for the Ph.D. Information Brochure 2026-27 (Summer Term) and other relevant information.
REGISTRAR
1237/11/170/2027/45931/C/27/7

US journalist pleads guilty to acting as an illegal agent for China

DIDI TANG ■ Washington

An American journalist who has lived in China since 2010 and worked for several State media organisations there pleaded guilty in a US court to acting as an illegal agent for the Chinese Government, the Justice Department said.

Thomas Pauken II is set to be sentenced September 1 in a US District Court and he faces up to 10 years in jail, the department said. He writes under the name Tom McGregor to distance himself from his father with the same name, who was a former chairman of the Texas Republican Party in the 1990s and ran for governor more than a decade



ago. It is the latest in a string of cases that the federal Government has brought against people suspected of working for the Chinese Government without proper disclosure. Eileen Wang, a former mayor of Arcadia, California, agreed in May to plead guilty to acting as an illegal agent for the Chinese Government. She was accused of doing the bidding of Chinese officials, including sharing articles favorable to Beijing. (AP)

Sri Lankan man arrested for promoting LTTE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

A 24-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly promoting the banned Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), Sri Lankan police said on Friday.

The man, from Udayanagar in Kilinochchi whose name wasn't disclosed by police, was arrested four days ago for allegedly performing LTTE promotional songs during a concert held in Jaffna district's Navatkuli area on May 31.

NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida G.B. Nagar, (U.P)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in
E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firm for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.
A) Short Term Fresh-Tender Work:

S. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the Work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
1	41/GM/SM(WC-2)/ET/2026-27	Cleaning of open drains Ashok Nagar to Botanical Garden DSC road, MP-2, MP-1 to MP-2 between Sector-19 and 27, Noida.	55.17

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated **08.06.2026 to 15.06.2026 up to 5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated **16.06.2026 at 11.00 AM**.
General Manager (Civil) NOIDA
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot
Ph: 01639-256232-256236
Advt. No.BFU-26/18
VACANCIES
Online applications are invited w.e.f. 08/06/2026 to 28.06.2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhhs.ac.in for recruitment to the posts of **Sub Divisional Engineer (Civil-01, Mechanical-01, Electrical-02, Public Health-02)** under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot. For Application form, fee, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhhs.ac.in
Sd/-
REGISTRAR
3108/12/2026-27/12044 Dated CHD :- 05/06/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
General Public at large is hereby informed that Mr. Jawahar Singh, son of Shri Paras Ram Yadav, and Mr. Mayank Yadav son of Sh. Jawahar Singh, both residents of House No. 1401, Block K, Palam Vihar, Sector 1, Gurugram are proceeding to sell following TDR certificates to our client:-
i. Jawahar Singh: TDR Certificate bearing Nos. 460-626 of 29/2026 carrying a face value of 50 Sq. Mtr. each with an FAR of 2.0 and TDR Certificate No. 627 of 29/2026 carrying a face value of 63.165 Sq. Mtr. with an FAR of 2.0 all dated 27th April 2026 out of 01-627 of 29/2026 dated 27th April 2026 granted against land bearing Rect. No. 25, Killa no. 20/1 (2-9), 21/1/1(3-15) situated in village Gopalpur, Sub Tehsil Harsaru, District Gurugram.
ii. Mayank Yadav: TDR Certificate bearing Nos. 01-251 of (Certificate No)/2026 carrying a face value of 50 Sq. Mtr. each with an FAR of 2.0 out of 01-338 of (Certificate No)/2026 dated 27th April 2026 granted against land bearing Rect. No. 27, Killa no. 6/1 (1-4), Rect. No. 28, Killa no. 10/2/3/1 (0-6) and Rect. No. 32 Killa no. 24/2/2 min (1-17) situated in village Gopalpur, Sub Tehsil Harsaru, District Gurugram.
In case any person, Company, Firm, Bank, Financial Institution, statutory authority, Society and/or any other entity have got any interest, claim, demand, right or title of any nature pertaining to the above mentioned TDR Certificates or land parcels against which the same have been issued or any part thereof including but not limited to by way of sale, exchange, will, treaty, gift, lease/ tenancy, license, assignment, mortgage, hypothecation, charge, lien, encumbrance, trust, family settlement/ arrangement, inheritance, bequest, easement, exchange, possession, maintenance, development rights, joint venture, partnership, order/ decree/ judgment of any court, MOU or through any other document with respect to the ownership rights and possession of the aforesaid owner in respect of the same, in that event the same be intimated in writing to us by Speed Post at the address indicated hereinafter or by way of email along with supporting documents within a period of 10 days from the date of publication of this notice failing which our client shall presume that the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued are free from all encumbrances/ charges/ third party claims and shall proceed to transact on the same from the Owner indicated above. In case no claim is lodged within the period stipulated above, the same shall be presumed to be wilful waiver of the claim which might be held by any person/ third party in respect of the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued.
Harshit Batra & Associates
Advocates
R/o Krishna Mansion, Civil Lines, Gurugram - 122001(HR)
Email: contact@hbatlegal.in
Mob. 91-7838828878

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Upasna W/O Ramesh Chander R/O 1402- Cmc4 Supertech Capetown near tower- cs10 Gate No-2 Sector- 74 Noida u.p Gautam Buddha Nagar have changed my name upasna to upasna charak for all other future.
PD(1281)C
I, Ushabai Sitaram, Mother of: No.14658187W Hav Rathod Balaji Sitaram, R/o- At Shastrinagar, PO- Dalimb, TA- Omerga, Dist- Osmanabad, Maharashtra- 413604, have changed my name from Ushabai Sitaram to Ushabai Sitaram Rathod, vide affidavit dated 05/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1282)C

GOVT. OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS) CACHAR CIRCLE, SILCHAR
No. SE/CC/E-TENDER/SOPD-G/2026-27/268(1)
PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER
The Superintending Engineer, PWD, Cachar Road Circle, Silchar, on behalf of Governor of Assam invites bid for **01 (ONE) No.** of road work schemes amounting to **Rs. 146.32 Lakh** (approx.) for (BALANCE WORK) - **Construction of Vivekananda Road & Drain Cum Footpath including Box Cell Culvert (From G.C college to India club point) of Ch.0.00m to ch.2200.00m under SOPD-G for the year 2020-21 Silchar LAC (pkg. no. SOPD_G_20_21_91)** pertaining to Cachar district of Assam.
Scheme is sanctioned by the competent authority and as per Chief Engineer's letter no. CE/DEV/TB/11/2025-26/18 DT. 12/5/2026, the e-tendering process for the balance work of aforesaid road was initiated vide No. SE/CC/E-TENDER/SOPD-G/2026-27/190(T) dt. 20/5/2026 as no tender received against the earlier notice inviting tender, hence, in the interest of public service the Press Notice Inviting Re-Tender for the aforesaid scheme is Re-Initiated.
Details along with Schemes for the works may be seen at website www.assamtenders.gov.in and also at the office of the undersigned in the "Technical branch". Amendment / addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor / bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.
Note:- NIT Value is inclusive of GST (12%), Labour Cess (1%) etc.
Sd/-
Superintending Engineer, PWD (Roads)
Cachar Circle, Silchar

GOVT. OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS) CACHAR CIRCLE, SILCHAR
No. SE/CC/E-TENDER/SOPD-G/2026-27/268(1)
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Note:- NIT Value is inclusive of GST (12%), Labour Cess (1%) etc.
Sd/-
Superintending Engineer, PWD (Roads)
Cachar Circle, Silchar

Government of Goa
Department of Tourism
Paryatan Bhavan, Patto, Panaji-Goa
Tel.0832-2494200, 2494211
Email: dir-tour.goa@nic.in Web: www.goatourism.gov.in
No. 3/(5243)2026/DT/1413 Date: 05/06/2026
BRIEF TENDER NOTICE
(E-TENDERING MODE ONLY)
The Department of Tourism, Government of Goa invites e-tenders from partnership firm, Limited Liability Partnership (LLP), private limited company registered under Companies Act 1956 or 2013, public limited company registered under Companies Act 1956 or 2013 including government-owned entities or consortiums of aforesaid entities for **Development, Operation and Management of Allied Floating Experiential Tourism Services and Digital Nomad Hub Aboard Ferry Vessels in The Mandovi River, Goa on Public-Private Partnership (PPP) Basis**. Agencies interested in applying for the tender may submit their bids with complete information as required as per the tender document. The last date for submission of the bid is **07/07/2026 upto 04.30 pm**. For detailed Tender Notice and for participation in e-tender, please visit our e-tender website <https://eprocure.goa.gov.in>. Tender notice is also available on official website: goatourism.gov.in for reference. All pre-bid queries may be emailed to dir-tour.goa@nic.in by **19/06/2026 upto 5.30pm**.
DI/ADVT/587/2026

The Pioneer Classified
CHANGE OF NAME
I, Upasna W/O Ramesh Chander R/O 1402- Cmc4 Supertech Capetown near tower- cs10 Gate No-2 Sector- 74 Noida u.p Gautam Buddha Nagar have changed my name upasna to upasna charak for all other future.
PD(1281)C
I, Ushabai Sitaram, Mother of: No.14658187W Hav Rathod Balaji Sitaram, R/o- At Shastrinagar, PO- Dalimb, TA- Omerga, Dist- Osmanabad, Maharashtra- 413604, have changed my name from Ushabai Sitaram to Ushabai Sitaram Rathod, vide affidavit dated 05/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1282)C
I, Rathod Renuka, W/o- No. 14658187W Hav Rathod Balaji Sitaram, R/o- At Shastrinagar, PO- Dalimb, TA- Omerga, Dist- Osmanabad, Maharashtra- 413604, have changed my name from Rathod Renuka to Rathod Renuka B, vide affidavit dated 05/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1283)C
PD(1284)C

CENTRE FOR SIGHT
Every eye deserves the best
PUBLIC NOTICE
Centre For Sight - Group of Eye Hospitals, through this notice informs all public that the old medical records from 1st April 2020 to March 31st 2021 (except MLC, court cases & Paediatrics cases) are to be discarded at the following locations: Delhi/NCR: Dwarka, Safdarjung Enclave, Preet Vihar, Vikaspuri, Rohini, Rajouri Garden, Ashok Vihar, Gurugram (sector 29 & NRR), Faridabad. Any patient who wants to collect their medical documents, may contact the MRD Dept. at Centre For Sight, Dwarka, Sector 9. After one month of publication of this notice, we will destroy all medical records from 1st April 2020 to March 31st 2021 (except MLC, court cases & Paediatrics cases) and will not be responsible for same.
Medical Superintendent - Centre For Sight

PROSPECT



CRPF Director General GP Singh, IPS, met Manipur's newly appointed Director General of Police Mukesh Singh, IPS, at police headquarters on Friday. The two officers discussed the prevailing security situation and outlined measures for close coordination between central and state forces to maintain peace and normalcy. The high-level engagement follows the Ministry of Home Affairs' recent approval to deploy two CRPF CoBRA battalions in Manipur for specific operations against armed groups involved in violence. The move is expected to strengthen efforts to stabilise the conflict-affected state in the coming days and bring relief to affected civilians.

PIONEER PHOTO



On the occasion of World Environment Day 2026, Advocate General Assam and BCCI Secretary Devajit Lon Saikia planted a sapling in the premises of Jyoti Bishnu Antarjatik Kala Mandir in Guwahati

Ai+ Smartphone records strong growth with 3 lakh units sold in May

The Ai+ Smartphone has announced a significant commercial milestone, crossing three lakh units in smartphone sales and generating over ₹350 crore in revenue in the month of May 2026 alone. Commenting on this milestone, Sheth, CEO, Ai+ Smartphone and Founder NxtQuantum Shift Technologies, said, "Crossing 3 lakh units and over ₹350 crore of revenue in a single month is not just an important business milestone for us, it is a validation of a larger movement. Our ambition has never been to only sell smartphones," added Sheth.

The company says the numbers reflect the growing momentum behind its vision of building a 'new age' technology brand from India.

The milestone follows the successful launch of the Ai+ Smartphone Nova2, Nova2 Ultra & NovaFlip in April 2026, which has quickly emerged as a key driver of the brand's growth and reinforced the growing appetite among Indian consumers for technology experiences that combine innovation, design and value.

India, Argentina 'called to work together': Envoy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

There is "objective complementarity between India and Argentina", and both are "called to work together", Argentine Ambassador Mariano Caucino said on Thursday while speaking at the India-Latin America and Caribbean Roundtable at the India International Centre.

The Argentine envoy said that links between Delhi and Buenos Aires "are based on common interests, shared values and an elevated degree of economic complementarity".

Caucino affirmed that "India is growing so much that it has already become Argentina's sixth largest partner" and assured that "although we are very far-away countries, we are destined to continue collaborating for our mutual benefit."

"The political and diplomatic establishment in our

countries are taking into account the strategic importance of India in the world today, having become one of the first five global economies and the world's fastest economy," the envoy emphasised.

"Asia and the Indo-Pacific are becoming more and more important in today's world to the extent that we always have to remember that in this part of the world lives sixty per cent of the whole humanity," he added.

"Argentina is today India's main provider in terms of edible oils, contributing to India's food security", Caucino stated.

The Argentine envoy reminded that India's goal of becoming a fully developed nation by 2047 "needs investment, opening and more deregulation, as Prime Minister Modi has stated frequently and in that sense more cooperation with our countries is key".



Argentine Ambassador Mariano Caucino

Ambassador Caucino recalled that "In 2009, Argentina opened a General Consulate in the thriving city of Mumbai, India's Economic and Financial capital and in 2019, Argentina and India elevated its relationship to the degree of strategic partnership. That same year, we opened the Agriculture Attache office in Delhi, under the leadership of agribusi-

ness expert Mariano Beheran, having achieved remarkable goals, to the extent that Argentina became India's number one provider of edible oils."

Argentina mainly exports soybean oil, sunflower oil, legumes, hides and recently critical minerals such as lithium and copper, sectors that have gained importance due to the energy transition

and Indian industrial needs. For its part, India exports pharmaceuticals, chemicals, machinery, motorcycles, auto parts and industrial manufactures to Argentina.

The Argentine Ambassador reaffirmed that "both countries share common values regarding democracy, freedom and respect for human dignity. At the same time, both countries are pursuing a path of development with basis in a common understanding of the benefits of free markets and limited Governments."

"As Prime Minister Modi said recently, we agree with the idea that governments should keep the minimum interference with private initiative while having to provide maximum support to those in need," Caucino said.

Caucino added that "Prime Minister Modi's visit to Argentina in July 2025 marked a milestone in our relationship. For the first

time in 57 years, an Indian head of government made a bilateral visit to Argentina".

"Recent years have also marked a significant milestone for the investment of Indian mining companies in our country. The Catamarca province is home to Indian companies that are not only exploring for lithium but are also showing interest in copper and gold", the ambassador said.

"These investments are particularly important as India moves forward with the development of its electric vehicles (EVs), aiming to ensure a resilient and diversified supply chain for critical minerals essential for various industries in India".

With regard to the energy and minerals sector, the strengthening established through various institutional and business visits that have taken place in recent years is noteworthy, he noted.

Indian Army observes World Environment Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

On the occasion of World Environment Day, the Indian Army's Spearhead Division under the Spear Corps organised a series of environment-centric activities across Tuting, Boraroopak and Sigar, reaffirming the Indian Army's commitment towards environmental conservation and sustainable development.

The celebrations witnessed enthusiastic participation from students, teachers, troops and members of the local community.

A variety of activities including tree plantation drives, cleanliness campaigns and poster-making competitions were conducted to promote environmental

awareness and encourage responsible stewardship of natural resources.

Army personnel joined hands with school children and teachers in a tree plantation and cleanliness drive, highlighting the collective responsibility of preserving the region's pristine ecological heritage. In Tuting, young students showcased their creativity and environmental consciousness through a poster-making competition centred on themes of sustainability and environmental protection.

As part of the initiative, troops at Boraroopak undertook a large-scale tree plantation drive aimed at enhancing green cover and promoting a culture of environmental responsibility.



NCC scripts history with first all India basic paramotor course

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The National Cadet Corps (NCC) achieved a historic milestone on Friday as the first-ever all-India NCC Basic Paramotor Course concluded at the National Institute of Mountaineering and Adventure Sports Centre, Guwahati.

The 15-day course, conducted from May 21 to June 4, 2026, trained 50 novice cadets from 10 States and union territories across India in ground handling, powered flight and aerial navigation.

Demonstrating exceptional courage, each cadet completed a minimum of five solo flights, marking their transition from ground zero to certified paramotor pilots.

The training was imparted by the NIMAS Paramotor Node, Guwahati — the only institute in the country, apart from the Indian Armed Forces, that conducts certified paramotor courses. The Node provided expert instructors, DGCA-compliant training syllabus, and safety supervision throughout the course.



This course was a follow-up to the first All NCC NER Directorate Basic Paramotor Course, held from May 4 to May 19, in which 50 cadets from the north-east region were trained. With the conclusion of the All India course, the NCC has qualified 100 senior division boy cadets as basic paramotor pilots within a month, setting a new benchmark in aero-adventure training for youth.

"Unity and Discipline in the Sky" was on full display as cadets from Ladakh to Assam took to the air. All participants were provided complete flying apparel by NCC and would be

awarded Basic Paramotor Qualification Certificate by NIMAS.

As a way forward, the NCC announced that 60 senior wing girl cadets will undergo basic paramotor course training between October and November 2026. The Basic Paramotor Course will now be a regular fixture in the NCC Yearly Training Curriculum, institutionalising aero-adventure as a core NCC activity.

The initiative underscores NCC's commitment to instilling adventure, leadership and national pride among India's youth while expanding skill-based training avenues.

IIT Roorkee hosts cyclothon, tree plantation drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Roorkee

Marking World Environment Day with a strong message of sustainability and environmental responsibility, IIT Roorkee organised a grand Cyclothon under the theme "Save Fuel" in collaboration with the Gangey Foundation and the Sports Council of IIT Roorkee.

The initiative aimed to promote fuel conservation, environmental protection, and sustainable living, drawing enthusiastic participation from more than 500 students.

The Cyclothon was flagged off by Prof. K.K. Pant, Director, IIT Roorkee, who emphasized that World Environment Day is more than a symbolic observance and serves as an opportunity to reinforce collective commitment towards environmental conservation. Appreciating the efforts of the Gangey Foundation and the Sports Council, he noted that such initiatives inspire young people to actively contribute to sustainable development and environmental stewardship.

DAILY SUDOKU

6	1					3	
5		7	4				
		9		6	4		
	2			4	1		9
			3		2		
	5		6	9			8
		5		3		1	
					4	7	8
	9						2
							4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

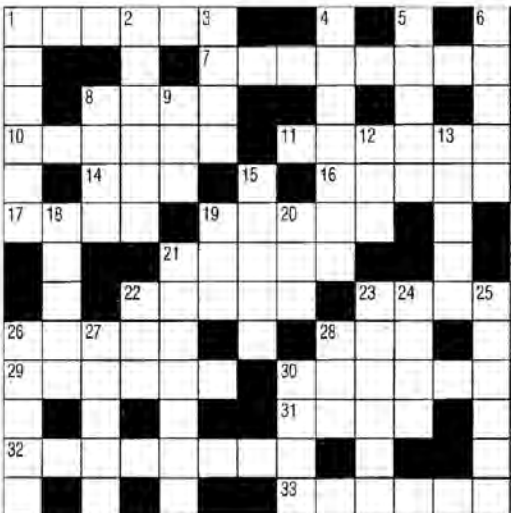
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (5.6.26)

6	7	5	2	9	8	4	3	1
9	1	3	6	4	5	2	8	7
4	8	2	1	3	7	5	6	9
8	5	7	4	1	6	3	9	2
2	6	1	9	8	3	7	5	4
3	9	4	5	7	2	8	1	6
7	2	8	3	6	1	9	4	5
1	3	9	7	5	4	6	2	8
5	4	6	8	2	9	1	7	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
SATURDAY | JUNE 6, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 Trouble getting a vehicle put in reverse (4-2)
- 7 Outdoor man getting a bad score (8)
- 8 Girl with two soldiers in an old film (4)
- 10 Angler's boat (6)
- 11 To give a little devil beer is a fatal thing to do (6)
- 14 Allowed a share in a raffle ticket (3)
- 16 Revealed how to make bread (5)
- 17 Chaps an inexperienced driver notices (4)
- 19 Friendly to everyone in extremes of poverty (5)

DOWN

- 1 The measure of a president, to the Spanish (6)
- 2 Being small, they need only three wheels (3)
- 3 To the batsman, disastrous spectacles (4)
- 4 Though sweet, could it make you go to pieces? (7)
- 5 Golden boy? (5)
- 6 Lavished affection on a boy at a party (8)
- 8 The champion's standard of goodness (4)
- 9 Move out of Georgetown (3)
- 12 A bit of money for father (3)
- 13 To be played slowly, but in fast time by the orchestra leader (5)

- 21 She takes me out for a change of air (5)
- 22 An evasive trick in the City (5)
- 23 Bit of bother with a dog? (4)
- 26 Could he sing a wrong note right? (5)
- 28 Vegetarian food can upset a lad! (3)
- 29 Broken in rude fashion (6)
- 30 American style banger (6)
- 31 A military outfit needs some ammunition (4)
- 32 In the mountains, a novice will never get fat (8)
- 33 A would-be specialist in clean sheets? (6)

- 15 Fat little girl? (5)
- 18 One can get cross when farewells are repeated! (5)
- 19 On which to write home? (3)
- 20 You can take the rest as mere fiction (3)
- 21 Kind of cherry, or an extra two pounds of duck! (7)
- 22 Does he get put on? (3)
- 23 Such a solution could upset aliens (6)
- 24 A scheme for vegetable production (4)
- 25 Potter, forename Dennis, once world champion (6)
- 26 Even half of it can possibly hurt! (5)
- 27 Point to it again, this chemical (5)

SOLUTION (5.6.26)

ACROSS	20. Uni-old	DOWN	(rev.)
1. Alpha	22. Pare	2. Loof-a-h	18. Death
6. Silly	24. Tre	3. Hatter	19. Playboy
9. Assault (a salt)	25. Starlet	4. A-sh	21. New-est
10. Worth	26. Syph	5. Matev	22. Pretty
11. Act-O-r	27. Kabb-b	6. Slacker	23. Re-Ta-in
12. Teach	28. Alias	7. It-Ch	25. Spell
13. Save-L-ay	29. Wouldn't	8. Loo-Ted	26. Sawm
15. Ver	30. Stony	12. Toime-d	28. Ant
17. Thor	31. Tyin-G	13. Si-out	
18. De-Ci-de		14. Volla	
19. Peter		15. Tenet	

ITBP launches nationwide massive plantation drive



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On the occasion of World Environment Day, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) carried out a massive plantation drive across the country. Marking the occasion, DG ITBP Shatruijeet Singh Kapur participated in a plantation programme at 22 Bn, Tigri, New Delhi, along with ADG Shri Sanjay Gunijal, senior officers and over 150 Himveers.

Addressing the gathering, the DG stated that environmental conservation is not merely a responsibility but an integral part of ITBP's work

culture. Serving in the ecologically sensitive Himalayan and border regions, ITBP personnel closely witness the impacts of climate change, glacier retreat and environmental degradation.

He emphasised that protecting nature is essential for ensuring a sustainable future for generations to come.

The DG informed that, under the leadership of the Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah, a nationwide plantation campaign is being undertaken today, and ITBP has been assigned a target of planting 75,000 saplings.

NTPC invites EOI for flexible thermal power solutions to support grid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's rapid renewable capacity growth is advancing clean energy goals but increasing demand for flexible power to manage grid variability. With limited hydro, gas, and large-scale storage, thermal plants remain key for grid balancing. NTPC said its entire thermal fleet already runs at a 55 per cent technical minimum load during low

demand. All stations participate in ancillary services including AGC, PFR, TRAS, SCED, and SCUC to accommodate renewables during solar hours, supporting grid flexibility and reliability.

Operational experience shows sub-critical thermal units may offer greater flexibility than supercritical and ultra-supercritical technologies for certain balancing needs due to lower parameter swings and reduced fatigue. Their ability to run

efficiently at low loads and handle frequent cycling can enable higher renewable integration.

To explore this, NTPC has invited an Expression of Interest (EOI) for 150-250 MW sub-critical units capable of two-shift operation and 25 per cent minimum technical load. The initiative aims to identify technology providers and EPC partners for highly flexible thermal solutions, reinforcing grid stability amid India's energy transition.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
(All India Service Centre of Preparation for Competitive Examinations)
Online applications are invited from the candidate for admission in All India Service Centre of Preparation for Competitive Examination (AISCEE) for preparation of UPSC/ PCS (Prelim.), UGC (NET/ JRF). The last date for admission of online applications is **15-07-2026**. For online registration and more details, visits website <http://gndu.ac.in/ais/> (Deputy Director)
2426/12/2026-27/12/2024
Dated CHD :- 05/06/2026

BRIEFLY

Selection trials 4 begin Saturday, Asian Games spots at stake



Aiming to pick the Indian squad for the Asian Games, the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) will conduct selection trials 4 for Group 'A' shooters in rifle and pistol events from Jun 6-10 at the Trishul Shooting Range at Maharana Pratap Sports College here.

The squad for the ISSF World Cup in Hangzhou, China, scheduled for next month and the Asian Games 2026 in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, scheduled for September, will be decided after the trials conclude, in line with NRAI's selection policy.

All the country's top shooters will be in action at Dehradun.

With the total number of participants capped at 30 across all three disciplines (Rifle/Pistol/Shotgun) for the Asian Games, multiple shooters must excel in multiple events to make the squad, giving these selection trials greater importance.

The first event scheduled in the competition is the Stage 1 25m Rapid Fire Pistol Men. The finals for that event and the finals for both 10m Rifle men and women will be conducted on June 7.

Pakistan to not send team to India for fencing tournament



Pakistan will not be sending its team to India for the Asian Fencing Championships. Usman Ahmad, the secretary of the Pakistan Fencing Federation, said that the organisers had not provided any assurances for the visas and security of the Pakistani players in India.

"Without these guarantees we decided not to participate in the championship," Usman said. The championship is being held in New Delhi from June 18 to 24.

He said it was the responsibility of the organisers to get government clearances and assurances for visas and security.

"We twice contacted the organising committee and Indian Fencing Association to get the assurances but we didn't get it," he said. Usman said without the required guarantee there was no point in submitting any visa application documents and working on a process to send the team.

Inter Milan brings back Dejan Stankovic's son, Aleksandar, on five-year deal

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Milan

The son of one of Inter Milan's treble-winning heroes is returning to the Serie A club. Inter announced on Friday that it has exercised a buyback clause to re-sign Aleksandar Stankovic from Club Brugge, with the Serbia midfielder penning a five-year contract.

The 20-year-old player is the son of former midfielder Dejan Stankovic, who spent almost a decade in Milan and was part of the team that won the Champions League, Serie A and Italian Cup in 2010 under Jose Mourinho. Current Inter coach Cristian Chivu also played in that side.

Aleksandar Stankovic progressed through the youth ranks at Inter but never made a senior appearance for the team before going on loan to



Swiss Super League club Luzern in 2024. He signed for Brugge the following season on a long-term deal but Inter has exercised its buyback clause at the first opportunity.

Inter reportedly sold Stankovic to

Brugge for 10 million euros (\$11.6 million) with the option to bring him back for 23 million euros (\$26.8 million) in 2026, and a higher figure of 25 million euros (\$29.1 million) if activated in June 2027.

FIFA cancels World Cup tickets for 60 fans who got them for free due to error

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Coral Gables (USA)

FIFA has canceled World Cup tickets issued to about 60 fans who mistakenly got them for free because of a website error. The tickets were "allocated at no charge (0 USD) due to a prior payment issue during the checkout process," FIFA said in a statement Thursday.

"FIFA regrets the error and any inconvenience caused," soccer's ruling body said. "The tickets requested by these fans remain reserved, and the affected fans have been invited to complete payment of the correct amount."

It is the latest glitch in an often controversial World Cup ticketing program that the attorneys general of New York and New Jersey are investigating for possible violations of consumer protection laws.



The mispriced tickets were sold through the official World Cup site on May 21, FIFA said in an email message to buyers.

That date was more than three months after FIFA president Gianni Infantino said all 104 World Cup games had sold out.

Tickets are still being sold by FIFA for games at the World Cup which opens next Thursday in Mexico City. It is unclear if seats for games in less demand will drop in price under FIFA's surge pricing model that has been controversial for fans.

Dedicated World Cup fans skip tourney over costs, politics

RJ RICO ■ New York

Jun 5 (AP) Soccer fans will soon crisscross continents to see their beloved national teams compete on the sport's grandest stage, the World Cup. They'll pack bars and fan zones, singing chants and debating who is going to win it all.

This time, however, it's different for some superfans, who say organizers have made this summer's World Cup the least welcoming one they have experienced. Ticket prices, expensive cross-country travel and concerns about entering the US have prompted some of them to stay home.

London-based IT worker Mike Wilson has been to four World Cups over the past 20 years. This summer, he'll be staying in Europe and watching part of the tournament from a Portuguese beach. Argentine doctor Emiliano Becerra likes to follow his team through every step of the elimination round.

This time he'll attend two early matches and then fly home.

Dutch-born finance manager Peter Bergakker flew to South Africa to watch the Netherlands play in the 2010 World



Cup final. But no matter how far the "Oranje" advance this summer, he said he won't travel to the US.

Exactly how many fans are staying away is unclear, but the warning signs are there.

A financially inaccessible tournament

The number of fans able to travel and take weeks off of work to cheer on their team during the World Cup understandably skews to the wealthy. But previous tournaments have remained accessible for fans who, in some cases, would

save for years for their flights and match tickets.

Four years ago, lower-tier Category 3 tickets to group stage matches were \$69. This year, FIFA has been selling them for as much as \$265.

The last two tournaments in Russia and Qatar offered match-going fans free transportation between host cities, though many matches were much closer than the vast area covered by the 16 stadiums hosting matches across the US, Canada and Mexico.

Praggnanandhaa in 3-way Norway Chess title battle

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa has put himself firmly in contention for the Norway Chess title after a commanding classical victory over compatriot D Gukesh moved him to within half a point of leader Wesley So of the USA, setting up an intriguing final round battle here.

Praggnanandhaa piled more misery on Gukesh, defeating the world champion in a classical game to earn three full points and put himself in the hunt to become the first Indian chess player to win the prestigious tournament.

He moved into the sole second place on 15 points, just behind American GM Wesley So (15.5) after Round 9, with one round remaining on Friday.

The tournament could hardly have asked for a more dramatic finale, with France's Alireza Firouzja also in title contention on 14.5 points in third place, leaving three players with a realistic shot at the title heading into the final round. Significantly, whoever emerges victorious on Friday will be crowned Norway Chess champion for the first time.

Playing black, Praggnanandhaa



came armed with the ambitious Nimzo-Indian Samisch Variation and sprang a surprise on Gukesh. The game followed an even course through the opening before Praggnanandhaa introduced a fresh idea on move 14. Gukesh's response turned out to be a decisive mis-step, allowing Praggnanandhaa to win a rook and wrest complete control of the position.

Yet the game was far from being

straightforward. Gukesh dug in and fought tenaciously, creating practical chances and even briefly reviving hopes of a comeback. Having let a winning position against the world champion slip away in their earlier meeting amid a time scramble, Praggnanandhaa was determined not to repeat the mistake.

This time, he kept a firm grip on the game, neutralised every counter-chance and converted his

advantage with precision to claim a crucial victory.

Praggnanandhaa will face Germany's Vincent Keymer in the decisive final round, while leader Wesley So takes on Alireza in a clash that could determine the destination of the title.

With So on 15.5 points, Praggnanandhaa on 15 and Firouzja on 14.5, all three remain in contention and are likely to push for

victory rather than settle for safety.

American So holds the advantage, as a classical win would guarantee him the championship, but any slip-up could reopen the race, with Praggnanandhaa and Firouzja poised to capitalise if results fall their way. So defeated Magnus Carlsen in the Armageddon tie-break after holding his nerve in a tense finish, a result that ultimately proved decisive in the standings.

Had So lost the Armageddon, he would have been tied with Praggnanandhaa on 15 points, keeping the title race even tighter going into the final stretch. Carlsen pressed hard throughout the game, but So defended resiliently to secure a crucial win.

Bibisara clinches women's title

Reigning world blitz champion Bibisara Assaubayeva clinched the Norway Chess women's title with a round to spare, even after an Armageddon tie-break loss to Ukraine's Anna Muzychuk added just a single point to her tally.

The Kazakh star's consistency carried her to 16.5 points, enough to secure the title despite the Armageddon setback, as she entered Round 9 with a commanding five-point lead. She needs just half a point to seal the championship.

Rumesh Pathirage goes past Neeraj Chopra with monster throw of 92.62m in Rome DL



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Rome

Neeraj Chopra and Arshad Nadeem need to watch out for Asia's next javelin superstar in the making, Sri Lankan Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, especially in the Commonwealth and Asian Games later this year.

Pathirage stunned the athletics world with a monster throw of 92.62m to win the prestigious Rome Diamond League title, sending his spear to the second longest distance by an Asian in history

and surpassing Indian star Neeraj Chopra.

The 23-year-old Pathirage destroyed the 10-man field which includes the likes of two-time world champion Anderson Peters of Grenada, who ended a distant second with 83.91m, Tokyo 2025 World Championships gold medalist Keshorn Walcott of Trinidad and Tobago (83.45m) and bronze medalist Curtis Thompson (83.89m) of the the USA. Thompson finished third while Walcott was fourth.

India's 26-year-old Sachin

Yadav struggled as he finished a disappointing eighth with a 79.18m effort in his Diamond League debut Thursday night.

Pathirage became only the fourth Asian and 28th overall to breach the coveted 90m mark.

His effort fell just short of Pakistani Arshad Nadeem's Paris Olympics gold-winning throw of 92.97m but went past Chinese Taipei's Chao-Tsun Cheng (91.36m) and Chopra (90.23m) to produce the second best throw in Asia.

Sachin Yadav finishes eighth on Diamond League debut in Rome

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Rome

Rising Indian javelin thrower Sachin Yadav struggled in his Diamond League debut as he finished a disappointing eighth while neighbouring country Sri Lanka's Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage breached the coveted 90m mark for the first time in his career to win the title here.

The 26-year-old Yadav could only muster a best throw of 79.18m on Thursday night, well below his personal best of 86.27m which he had produced while finishing fourth in the Tokyo World Championships last year.

He has the season's best of 81.95m.

The Rome leg of the prestigious Diamond League was Yadav's first international event since finishing a creditable fourth in 2025 World Championships.

Yadav began with a foul

throw, and then had 79.18m, 77.02m, 76.62m, 75.54 in his next four attempts to end at the eighth spot after five throws.

Only the top three after the fifth round are allowed to have their sixth and final throw.

The 23-year-old Pathirage destroyed the 10-man field as he recorded the second longest throw by an Asian and eighth on

winning throw of 92.97m but went past Chinese Taipei's Chao-Tsun Cheng (91.36m) and Indian star Neeraj Chopra (90.23m) to produce the second best throw in Asia.

Pathirage became only the fourth Asian and 28th overall to breach the coveted 90m mark.

He came into Thursday's competition as the season leader in the world with his 89.37m throw in a domestic event in March.

It was his first Diamond League title.



the world all-time list, sending his spear to a massive 92.62m in his second attempt to win the title. His first round throw measured 84.49m. All his last four attempts were foul throws.

His effort fell just short of Pakistani Arshad Nadeem's Paris Olympics gold-

Weekend work on putting pays Kochhar rich dividends

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ El Jadida (Morocco)

Having worked on his game after missing a cut last week, India's Karandeep Kochhar carded a 6-under 66 and placed himself one shot behind the leader, Thailand's Runchanapong Youprayong (65), on the first day of the \$500,000 IGPL Bharath Classic.

Stung by last week's reversal, Kochhar spent the weekend at the Mazagan Beach & Golf Resort course working on his short game. It paid off at the same venue.

Another Indian Aryan Roopa Anand, a recent winner at IGPL Congo, was also in the Top-10. He shot 4-under 68 and was tied eighth.

Kochhar, 26, winner of four



pro titles in India, added his first IGPL win last year at the IGPL Dubai and has been in good form. He was tied fourth at the Philippine Golf Championship and then tied fifth at the high-profile

International Series Japan. He also made cuts at the New Zealand and Singapore Opens.

Kochhar said, "I think the key to this round was putting. I felt like I hit the ball well last week as well but the putter was the main difference."

"The pace on the greens wasn't there. I would say, I was really much more comfortable than I had been the last week, but yeah, I think, but I think I'd really put in a lot of work over the last few days, trying to sort off my putting, and I'm very happy that it showed."

He added, "I put in a lot of work over the weekend and the first few days on Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday as well. So I think all of that, all of that work really showed. in today's round."

Veer Ahlawat leads Indian challenge in Switzerland



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucerne (Switzerland)

Veer Ahlawat was the top Indian at the end of the first round of the Swiss Challenge at Golf Sempach here. Ahlawat carded a round of 2-under 69 and placed tied 28th while Arjun Prasad was one shot behind at 1-under 71 to be placed T-41.

Saptak Talwar had a rough day and was placed T-110 after carding 3-over 74. Christoffer Bring of Denmark led the field after carding a bogey free 7-under 64 and he was one shot clear of four players, Haydn Barron, George Bloor, Tadeas Tetak and Tobias Eden.

Ahlawat, who played on the main DP World Tour last year, has been dividing his time between the Hotel Planner Tour and the DP World Tour.

He began his opening round on the back nine and was 1-over par at the turn. He had dropped shots early in his round with bogeys on the 11th and 14th holes along with a birdie on the 17th hole. On the front nine Ahlawat made four birdies in six holes starting with a birdie on the second hole. His third and final bogey of the day was on the sixth hole. He finished the day with five birdies and three bogeys.

Arjun Prasad began on the back nine and made early progress with birdies on the 13th and 15th holes before dropping shots on the 16th and 18th holes to be even par at the turn. An early birdie on the front nine on the first hole allowed him to move back to below par before dropping a shot on the third hole.

Iyer set to be India’s new T20I captain for UK tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Shreyas Iyer will formally replace Suryakumar Yadav as India’s new T20 captain when the national selection panel meets here on Saturday to finalise squads for the white-ball tour of the UK and the subsequent Asian Games in Japan.

The tour of UK will feature a couple of T20 Internationals against Ireland on June 26 and 28 in Belfast followed by a trip to England for five T20Is and three ODIs beginning July 1.

The Asian Games will take place in September-October in Aichi-Nagoya and the squad is being announced early to meet the deadlines set by the event organisers.

It is expected that young Mumbai Indians batter Tilak Varma will be the new vice-captain, while 15-year-old batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will earn his maiden senior team call-up.

As PTI had reported on Wednesday, Suyakumar is not only being sacked as India captain despite winning the T20 World Cup earlier this year, he is also being dropped



from the squad for his poor form over the last 18 months during which he is suspected to have played with a wrist injury.

The 31-year-old Iyer, who was not a part of the T20 World Cup squad, is expected to take on the No.4 slot in the batting line-up.

He is being rewarded for being one of the most astute IPL

captains, having taken three different franchises (Delhi Capitals, Kolkata Knight Riders and Punjab Kings) to IPL finals, winning the trophy once.

Leading three different set-ups to the title round is no small feat and he is the only IPL captain to do so, an achievement that inspires confidence in his leadership.

Add to it, his batting form has not dipped while captaining and the only blip in his run would be this year’s free fall by Punjab Kings

during the second half of the IPL after starting out rather well.

Chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar will announce two separate squads for the UK Tour and the Asian Games set to be held in Japan in September-October.

The BCCI will field its best possible squad even though the event clashes with a bilateral white-ball home series against the West Indies at the same time.

For Asian Games, Tilak Varma could be seen leading the side with Sooryavanshi likely to be a part of that T20 squad.

Some new names could enter the fray, including pacer Prince Yadav, and left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey, who is also in the Test and ODI squad for the series against Afghanistan starting on Saturday. Will Buvneshwar Kumar get a recall?

While the selectors have been firm on moving on from Mohammed Shami, it will be interesting to see if Bhuvneshwar Kumar, after a 28-wicket haul in the Indian Premier League, gets a recall at the age of 36.

Bhuvneshwar has been brilliant on flat decks and has a good chance of succeeding in English conditions. However, with Agarkar, the philosophy has always been looking at the bigger picture.

ICC’s pink ball trial for day Test matches gets thumbs up from India coach Gambhir



KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

India head coach Gautam Gambhir on Friday welcomed the ICC’s decision to allow usage of pink balls during day Tests, describing it as an opportunity for teams to get results in matches affected by unexpected weather.

Following its board meeting, the ICC had okayed a trial of pink balls in regular Test matches, with prior agreement from both teams, “to maximise play in case of anticipated bad light.”

It is understood that such a match will start with a red ball but if there is bad light, then floodlights would be turned on and pink ball will be used to make up for the overs that could otherwise be lost.

“I love that. The reason is because I always believe that if there’s an opportunity to get a result, you should always have that opportunity,” Gambhir said on the eve of the one-off Test against Afghanistan.

The rule will be effective from October 1. Gambhir’s firm support for it has an underlying reason.

India will be playing the Border-Gavaskar Trophy at home in February-March. The third Test is in Guwahati and the final one in Ranchi, both in the eastern part of India where sun sets by 4pm leading to loss of overs. (PTI)

India seek missing links against Afghanistan before WTC games

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Battling demons of a horrendous home Test run in the not so distant past but nevertheless a formidable unit, India are pitted against a plucky Afghanistan in a one-off Test here that might help the hosts figure out a balanced combination, starting Saturday.

In 2018, Afghanistan lost 10 wickets in a session between lunch and tea on the second day of the Test against India. The next 10 fell by the wayside between tea and end of day’s play which also was end of the game.

In 2026, Hashmatullah Shahidi would want his team to at least stretch the home side which is going through a tough transition phase and will be in experimen-



tal mode during this game trying different combinations.

However, the Indians would not have forgotten the 0-2 drubbing handed by a meticulously prepared South Africa last year and would do well to not take the opposition lightly despite the gulf in experience.

Sai to get long rope

A stable No.3 and Ravindra Jadeja’s potential successor in red ball cricket are the two pieces of the jigsaw puzzle that head coach Gautam Gambhir and skipper Shubman Gill need to fix during this game before the important two-match Test series

against Sri Lanka in August.

The choice has been between Sai Sudharsan and the stylish Devdutt Padikkal. Gambhir on Friday made it clear that Sudharsan would be persisted with, insisting that he deserves a fair chance.

Hunt for Jadeja’s successor

Ravindra Jadeja has been rested for this match but this is a fact that the Indian selectors and team management are trying to look at options to prepare themselves for life beyond the Rajkot all-rounder. The reason for this search is his bowling form, which has deteriorated considerably and he hasn’t been as incisive as the team management would have liked. (PTI)

Rashid’s availability uncertain as Afghanistan eye bigger Test future

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Afghanistan head coach Richard Pybus is keen to have a conversation with star leg-spinner Rashid Khan about his long-term red-ball future but admitted that the bowler’s chronic back issue and packed global schedule make his immediate Test availability uncertain.

On the eve of Afghanistan’s one-off Test against India, Pybus said managing Rashid’s workload would be a priority as the team looks to build a sustainable Test programme despite an erratic fixture list.

“Rashid has got this longstanding back complaint. He’s

got such a huge volume of cricket, you know, he’s got to manage himself,” Pybus said.

“I look forward to having that conversation to see how we can support him, not only just



with the opportunity to maybe continue to play some red-ball cricket if there is potential for that, but generally make sure he can play as long and as healthy as possible for Afghanistan,” the Englishman said.

Rashid’s absence has once again highlighted the challenges Afghanistan face in balancing the demands of franchise cricket and the Test format, a subject Pybus repeatedly returned to during his first media interaction since taking charge of the national side. The former West Indies director of cricket, overseeing his maiden assignment with Afghanistan, stressed that the larger issue was not merely player availability but the lack of a consistent Test calendar.

“When a country gets full membership, it’s one thing to get full membership, but then you need to get a full fixture list,” Pybus said. (PTI)

Rohit does not need to prove in ODIs, WC needs him: Dinesh Lad

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Dinesh Lad, the formative coach of former India captain Rohit Sharma, believes the batsman should ignore critics questioning his fitness and form, and simply enjoy his game to return stronger in his favourite World Cup format next year.

Rohit has faced a dip in his recent ODI form, managing just 61 runs across three innings during his last ODI appearance against New Zealand, the slump sparking scrutiny among critics.

“Being a coach, I don’t think he needs to prove anything to anyone. He badly wants to win the ODI World Cup. I have spoken to him and he is very categorical with what he wants in career. I don’t think he needs to prove his fitness. Despite the age factor, he is still fit enough,” Lad told PTI Videos during an interview on Friday.

“Critics keep talking. It’s their job. India needs Rohit’s experience if we want to reach the finals. Technique wise there is no problem. Moreover, in 50 overs cricket, you need to settle a bit.

“Rohit has got such technique that allows you to settle and then launch yourself. In IPL also, he showed his technique and he wasn’t only playing big shots but also taking the singles and the doubles. I don’t understand the critics’ point of view. My view is that he must be in the team.”

Lad also took a dig at former India selector Saba Karim, who said that Rohit would have to “do a lot of heavy lifting” and prove both his fitness and batting form to remain in the selectors’ plans for the 2027 ODI World Cup.



“Why are the next six months crucial only for only Rohit? It’s crucial for all players. Everyone needs to play well to retain their place in the team. I have a 100 per cent guarantee that Rohit will definitely play the 50 overs World Cup in 2027.

“He will do well during these six months and the later months as well. If you give him an opportunity he will do well.” Lad added, “I don’t think Rohit needs to prove anything to anyone. He has retired from Tests and T20Is, not ODI. And in whatever ODI matches he had played last, he did well. I don’t think there is any pressure on him. (PTI)



INDIA-AFGHANISTAN ONE-OFF TEST WILL HINGE ON HOW BATTERS TACKLE SPIN BOWLING: PYBUS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Afghanistan head coach Richard Pybus on Friday said the course of the one-off Test against India starting here on Saturday will be decided by how batters from both the teams tackle the spin challenge.

India and Afghanistan will face off here on Saturday in what will only be their second ever Test in history,

having played another one-off game in Bengaluru in June 2018.

That game was won by India inside two days.

“The Mullanpur pitch, for how long grass cover can hold the pitch (together) and how well both sides play with spin bowling playing huge part, will decide (the course of the Test),” Pybus told the reporters here on the eve of the Test.

Smriti Mandhana, Shafali Verma’s form key to India’s T20 World Cup hopes: Diana Edulji



ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ Mumbai

Former captain Diana Edulji believes openers Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma finding form quickly will be imperative and crucial to India’s chances of winning the Women’s T20 World Cup.

India head into the global showpiece, scheduled to be played from June 12 to July 5 after suffering a 1-2 T20I series defeat to the tournament hosts England, with both Mandhana (40 runs) and Verma (35) enduring a lean patch with the bat.

“Though it was not a very good series, we have lost 2-1, we need to just focus on our



opening partnership,” Edulji told PTI Videos on the sidelines of the launch of BBC Research’s report on Indian women in sport.

“Smriti and Shafali need to get quickly into form, and once they start getting into form, I think that will help India win (at the T20 World Cup),” she added. (PTI)

DDCA Women’s T20 League expands: 60 teams, 700 players

SANSKRITI GAUBA ■ New Delhi

The Delhi & District Cricket Association (DDCA) on Friday launched the second edition of its Women’s T20 League, and the expanded version will see participation from 60 teams and over 700 players. The inaugural season of the league in 2025 had 42 teams in it, and the addition of 18 new teams underlines the growth of women’s club cricket in the national capital.

The competition, inaugurated by DDCA President Rohan Jaitley, will feature 10 groups of six teams each, including established clubs such as Delhi Gymkhana CC, Hind CC, Young Friends CC, Delhi Blues CC and City Gymkhana.

“Last year, we started the league as an initiative in which 42 clubs participated. This year, the number has increased to around 60 clubs and more than 700 players,” Jaitley told PTI Videos.

“The intent is to give players an off-season platform that combines competition, performance review and complete training. As



the league grows with time, performance and development will continue to multiply,” he added.

The matches will be played across five venues in the city: Modern School (Grounds 1 and 2) in Barakhamba Road, Shivaji College in Rajouri Garden, Guru Gobind Singh College in Pitampura and Modern School Ground in Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar.

The DDCA vice-president Shikha Kumar attributed the increase in participation this

year to growing opportunities in women’s cricket and the heightened interest following India’s recent success on the global stage.

“There is year-on-year growth. Going from around 42 teams to 60 teams is a significant achievement for DDCA and for young girls playing cricket,” Kumar said.

“Parents are increasingly realising the opportunities available in women’s cricket. The response from clubs has been very encouraging.” (PTI)

Pakistan beats Australia by four wickets to clinch ODI series 2-1

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lahore (Pakistan)

Pakistan overcame Australian spin on a tricky wicket to win the third and final one-day international by four wickets and clinch the series 2-1 on Thursday.

Pakistan had to fight hard on a turning wicket to reach 161-6 in 41.5 overs after Australia had crashed to its lowest ODI total in Pakistan and got bowled out for 157 in 42 overs.

All-rounder Shadab Khan, who had earlier picked up 2-28, made unbeaten 29 while Abdul Samad was 18 not out to earn Pakistan its third successive ODI win in a bilateral series against Australia.

Australia had won the second game by 41 runs at the same venue to level the series while Pakistan won the first match at Rawalpindi last week by five wickets on pitches tailor-made for spinners. Left-arm spinner Matthew Kuhnemann (3-38) had pushed Australia’s bid when he clean bowled top-scorer Babar Azam for 40 in the 30th over and Pakistan



slumped to 112-6.

But Shadab and Samad both showed plenty of patience on an abrasive pitch before Shadab smashed Adam Zampa to long-on boundary for winning runs. Earlier, Australia’s middle-order crumbled against Pakistan captain Shaheen Shah Afridi (3-30) and leg-spin of Abrar Ahmed (2-19) despite skipper Josh Inglis scoring 65 off 71 balls after he had won the toss and opted to bat first. Inglis’ second successive

half-century seemed to keep Australia on track for a challenging total but none of the other batters could score more than 19 as the visitors lost their last seven wickets for 38 runs.

Fast bowler Haris Rauf ignited the collapse when he hit the top of Alex Carey’s (19) middle stump in the 23rd over and then Afridi struck twice in one over with the old ball when he dismissed Inglis and Cameron Green in the 27th over.